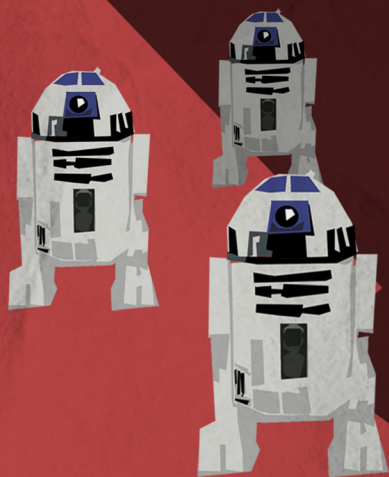


FUTURE IS A STATE OF MIND

a novel



Patrizio
Pirra



Future is a state of mind

Patrizio Pinna

www.patriziopinna.com

To my daughter.

He had suspected it for some time already, work had dropped to an all-time low, and the crisis in which the whole country now seemed to have settled, agonizing but incredulous, had repeatedly outdone the Vajont tragedy in terms of casualties. For years Francesco had greeted his paycheck with a kind of astonishment, and he knew that if they were to let him go – like most of his colleagues – they'd do it on a Friday.

And that day, as luck would have it, was indeed Friday.

His boss was merciful, it must be said, he didn't wait until the end of the day like his more distinguished peers, after all he too would soon be closing the door behind him, trying to limit the damage, then looking for new promising youngsters to squeeze, still hoping that software development and graphic design were fields in which Genoa – one of the most provincial cities in the world – could somehow compete with Silicon Valley.

Had he been in America, Francesco would have left the office carrying a cardboard box filled with his few gadgets, a couple of bubble-heads from unknown TV shows, a vintage mouse pad, some mugs with incomprehensible quotes printed on them, and a chili plant that seemed to appreciate the warm air the olympic iMac blew its way. But since America was far away, Francesco stuffed his few toys into his backpack, hastily uploaded the project he was working on to his own cloud, wiped all sensitive data from the computer with a Jack Bauer-grade formatting, and started down the *Albaro* hill, holding Apocalypse Now with both hands.

It was almost lunchtime, but school was ending, and the streets were already jammed with little hipsters wearing rolled-

up pants, branded yet worn-out shoes, tattoos, long beards (at least those who could grow them), and riding bicycles worth thousands of euros that, however, had to look as if they'd just been pulled from garbage bins. And these were only the kids, their older brothers would be leaving their offices later, clogging the streets with their battered motorbikes, bicycles, skateboards, segways, and converted wheelbarrows.

Francesco had never felt anything like that for any other subculture. He had never met hippies or post-hippies, except for his mother, of course, who, after letting slip that she had conceived him in '84 at a Frank Zappa concert with a perfect yet beautiful stranger – thus forcing him, unwillingly, into a few years of therapy – tried not to let any other details of that hazy past slip out, a past even she barely remembered. He had narrowly missed the punks, though they had been a godsend, musically speaking. The more unpleasant skinheads, fortunately, he had only heard about. He had never hated the new wave crowd, with their teased hair and oversized shirts, or the goths, dressed in black in forty-degree heat and pale as corpses even in a city where clouds appeared only on album covers. He'd felt nothing toward the grunge kids and their flannel shirts and ripped jeans, except perhaps a faint envy for the unrestrained love all the girls lavished on Kurt Cobain. He had never cared about the metalheads, the mods, the rockers, the straight edge, the emos (a sort of dark 2.0), or the yuppies. Only *punkabbestia* got on his nerves, for dragging poor pets into their street lives, but what he felt for hipsters was something else entirely.

Contemporary hipsters had no real history, apart from an obvious semantic misunderstanding with the Beat Generation and '40s jazz, and from a certain angle had plundered what could now be considered nerd culture, though up to that point it had never really been cultural at all. In the eighties, nerds were simply smart kids, perhaps unathletic and even less well-off,

who didn't care about fashion, preferring to focus on their passions, which often converged in technology and its offshoots. They did well in school, poorly with girls, and the nights spent reading or staring at computer screens forced them into thick-framed glasses. Their rolled-up vintage pants weren't bought for hundreds of euros, they were just what they had at home, and their bicycles were simple means of transportation when they couldn't afford anything better. Their ironic, often tech-themed T-shirts were perhaps their only indulgence, a kind of language closed off to the masses, like binary code, hexadecimal, or jokes about mysterious TV series never aired on national channels.

Modern hipsters, instead, were rich kids who enjoyed growing beards just because others in America did, not for lack of time or sleep, who scoured vintage markets for the right clothes, spent hours folding their pant cuffs so they wouldn't look too neat but not too sloppy either, who tortured themselves getting tattooed everywhere, and who didn't even have a real culture or musical direction: they picked almost at random from various eras, favoring low fidelity, huge headphones, background hiss, and organic food. Hipsters were the new release of *paninari* and what Francesco hated most was that, having spread so widely, from TriBeCa to the entire world, he was no longer free to wear his own clothes, glasses, or accessories without seeming almost like one of them. Hipsters had forced him to care about his wardrobe and his appearance, something he had never done in his whole life. That was why he couldn't stand them.

He crossed the entire neighborhood on foot, avoiding the bus to Apocalypse Now. What bothered him wasn't so much having just lost his job as the thought of having to transplant his little plant. Never had a chili lasted him so long, and never before had any of its predecessors managed to give him such explosive fruit.

As he got closer to home, crossing that imaginary border dividing *Albaro* from *Sturla*, a strange sort of euphoria came over him. He was unemployed, sure, in one of the darkest periods in history, yet he felt happy, even free, despite having just lost the money that made freedom possible. Or at least that's what many claimed.

After opening the door, Francesco stood still in the living room. Only on weekends could he see the place so bathed in sunlight, if only he didn't always get up well past lunchtime, and that sight erased any worry about what he'd have to say to his partner, who, working shifts at the hospital, was probably still in bed.

«I'm home...» he said softly, not wanting to wake her if she was still asleep. Then he set *Apocalypse Now* in a corner where the sun hit from morning to evening.

«Yes... yes...» he heard coming from the bedroom, in a tone he didn't immediately interpret as he should have. «I'm coming...» she went on, almost shouting.

Having an above-average IQ wasn't always enough in certain situations. A normal person, probably, would have grasped what was happening right away, wouldn't have wondered why she said that instead of a simple hello, but the doubt that should have appeared instantly took a couple of seconds to find its way through the maze of synapses trying to decode that simple phrase, accompanied by the moans he had learned to recognize well in three years of cohabitation.

Francesco peeked into the bedroom, smiling, savoring what this strange morning seemed about to turn into, now certain he had caught his partner in an intriguing moment of self-pleasure. But once at the door, he realized his naïveté, finding her bent over with a bearded, tattooed hipster behind her who, at the peak of orgasm, though startled, didn't hesitate to deliver two final thrusts before pulling out and wrapping himself in a sheet.

«Oh... Christ, Frank» she blurted, slipping on her T-shirt.
«It's not what you think...»

Francesco was dumbfounded by those words. Even the tattooed guy, wrapped in the sheet, looked at her, puzzled, trying to understand what she could possibly mean. They had been caught, that was obvious, and it was equally clear that it had been going on for who knows how long, given that he wasn't even wearing a condom. He wasn't some random hookup from a concert, assuming there were rock bands eager to play at ten in the morning, he was a full-fledged lover. And what disturbed Francesco most, what he couldn't look away from, was that with his beard, long hair, and that damn sheet, the guy looked exactly like Jesus Christ. Though it was hard to imagine the original getting a cross tattooed on his forearm.

Then, after what felt like an eternity, Francesco heard his own voice from outside himself, as if someone else were speaking: «It's not what I think? Don't tell me, you weren't doing nude yoga or some other hipster bullshit, and he didn't accidentally fall behind you? and inside you? is that it? Then please, enlighten me... What happened?» But as he listened to himself, he realized he felt nothing, not anger, not jealousy, nothing at all. Only a deep sadness for having wasted nearly three years with a girl he now understood he had never really loved.

Anita tried to scramble for excuses, but the guy behind her placed a hand on her shoulder. There was nothing to say, and Francesco wouldn't have listened anyway. He picked up *Apocalypse Now* and left.

«I'll send someone to pick up my stuff» he said from the landing.

«But Frank, Frank...» she sobbed behind him, for a reason neither he nor Christ could understand.

«How many damn times have I asked you not to call me Frank?» he whispered as he descended the stairs, without even turning around, as if asking himself, «how many times?»

After wandering around the neighborhood for a while, Apocalypse Now in hand and feeling drunk despite not having had a single drink, Francesco headed toward his mother's place.

He rang the bell and waited a couple of minutes, he was about to turn back when he heard the peephole click.

«Ma'» he said, «it's me...»

«Frank!» she exclaimed from the other side.

This will never end, he thought, before finding himself face-to-face with his mother in a robe who, at almost sixty, still had a hell of a body.

«Oh, damn. Did I wake you? Were you asleep?»

«I was in bed» she said with a smile, «but I wasn't sleeping.»

«Good God, is everyone screwing on Friday mornings?»

His mother punched him lightly on the shoulder. «Watch your mouth» she said, smiling as she tightened the sash of her silk robe.

They went inside.

«I lost my job today. The company shut down.»

«Oh, fuck!» his mother blurted.

«And when I got home, I caught Anita in bed with another guy.»

«Oh, fuck!» said a male voice behind him.

Francesco turned and saw another hipster, older tattoos, bare-chested, wearing tight jeans. «Oh, fuck!» he echoed.

«Frank, this is Walter. Walter, this is Frank, my son.»

«Nice to meet you, Frank» the man said, crushing his hand in a handshake.

«Francesco. My name's Francesco. How many times do I have to tell you, Ma'?»

«She's never forgiven me for conceiving him at a Frank Zappa concert» his mother said.

«Wow, Frank Zappa» the guy said, pulling on an old Atari T-shirt. «You should be proud of that...» But his mother gave him a look, and Walter stopped. «I'll make some coffee» he added, disappearing into the kitchen.

«I'm sorry, sweetheart. I've been meaning to introduce you two for a while, but...»

«But?»

«Well, you're always so judgmental when it comes to my boyfriends.»

«Maybe because it's a little weird having a mom who calls her men «boyfriends.»

«Hey, don't be rude. I may not be a young girl anymore, and I've never been very lucky with men, maybe that's my fault, I admit it, but I did something right. I raised you on my own, you know that, and I tried to make sure you never went without anything.»

Except a father, he thought, but didn't say it. She didn't deserve that. He was just now realizing that what really bothered him about her relationships was how easily she ended them. Fiamma still didn't know what she wanted, but she knew exactly what she didn't want. He, on the other hand, hadn't figured out a damn thing, and on top of that, he'd wasted three years of his life. His mother had never had a relationship that long.

«Hey Ma', I know you worked your ass off for me, and it can't have been easy. I love you, you know that. And I also know you never really liked Anita...»

«No, come on, don't say that. It's just that women understand each other better, especially a nurse...»

«A nurse?» Walter shouted from the kitchen.

«Oh, Christ, what does her job have to do with it?»

Walter came back in with the cups of coffee. «It has everything to do with it. You can't blame her. Those poor girls see every kind of horror day in and day out, they witness things most of us prefer not to even think about...»

«They know life is short, my boy» his mother continued, «and that out of nowhere it can turn ugly.»

«Just like doctors» Walter added. «Ever wonder why they all smoke like chimneys, even though they shouldn't? For the exact same reason.»

«So you're telling me all doctors are chain-smokers and all nurses are sluts?»

«Well, sluts is a strong word. Let's say they just have a clearer vision than we do. They're better at seizing the moment.»

«Maybe» Francesco admitted, «and apparently Anita's been seizing plenty of moments in my absence.»

«Well, now it's your turn. You're a good-looking guy, smart, and above all, young. It might feel strange now, but it won't take long to realize that changes, one way or another, are always positive.»

«Where'd you get that, from a fortune cookie?»

«Hey, don't be rude.»

«Relax, Fiamma. Your boy's a sharp little bastard. I like him. I think we'll get along fine. You made him sound way more nerdy than this.»

«Says the guy in the Atari shirt.»

They laughed.

Francesco had always been skeptical about his mother's boyfriends: a parade of misfits she seemed to attract like a magnet, but this time, though trying not to lower his guard, he felt something different. Hearing him call her by name usually

gave him mixed feelings. He'd always disliked the intimacy that came with it, but this time, for no clear reason, the words of that odd nerd-hipster-rocker hybrid, that sixty-year-old kid whose only sign of age was the pale silver still thick on his head, sounded strangely harmonious to his ears. Fiamma, he thought. No name had ever fit better. Too bad he was only realizing it now.

«Okay, I'm gonna take a shower so you two can chat in peace. Then, if you happen to have a few hundred euros in your pocket, I might even sell you my T-shirt.»

«For that much I could buy a whole pack of them on eBay.»

«Yeah, sure. This one's an original from the eighties, and don't pretend you don't know it. Ever since I put it on» he said as he walked toward the bathroom, «I've felt a tremor in the Force...» and disappeared inside before Francesco could reply.

«Okay» Francesco said quietly, «he seems nice enough, tattoos aside. Where'd you find him?»

«At a concert» she admitted, lowering her eyes slightly.

«Oh, come on, concerts again?»

«What? The Rolling Stones are still touring. Compared to them, I'm a youngster.»

«You went to see the Stones?»

«No, well... not recently. I met him at a Subsonica concert.»

«Subsonica? You're kidding me.»

«No, why?»

«Jesus Christ, Mom, Subsonica? It's music for teenager.»

«Hey, don't get all high and mighty with me. Besides, I've seen everyone live, from the Beatles to Hendrix, to the Zeppelins, to the Jethros, and so on, and you know it, all the way up to the legendary Frank... but this is Genoa, for heaven's sake, I have to take what the convent offers.»

«And what was he doing there, anyway?»

«He works there, not with Subsonica directly, but he's one of those who rent and set up the lights, the amps, stuff like that. One day it's Subsonica, another it's Paolini, and when it goes bad, some *Forza Italia* convention.»

«A life on the edge, huh?»

«Stop mocking him. This time it's serious. At least I hope so.»

«All right, I'll try to behave. But listen, I was hoping I could crash here for a few days while I figure things out, as long as there's still a spot where your boyfriend hasn't released bodily fluids.»

«Well, of course, this will always be your home. But if you've become that squeamish, I guess your only option is to sleep in the closet.»

«Mom?»

«And by the way, Walter lives here.»

«He lives with you? Since when?»

«A couple of months. I wanted to tell you, but you haven't dropped by in ages. I thought it'd be better if you met him in person, I didn't feel like doing it over the phone. Is it a problem for you?»

«No, of course not» he admitted, mostly to himself. «I'm glad you're not alone. Forget it, really. I'll stay at Teo's.»

«Well, I'm sure you'll be better off with your friends. All together again, like the good old days.»

«What the hell are you talking about, Willis?»

«You don't know? Sergio moved back in too, a couple of weeks ago I think. To split expenses, you know, times are tough» she giggled. «But wait, how long has it been since you've talked to them?»

«A while» he admitted, lowering his gaze. «But how do you know?»

«Well, Teo calls me every so often to check in. He's sweet. Says I'm his favorite MILF» she laughed.

«And you let him say that?»

«Why not? He's always cracked me up, ever since you were in kindergarten. The guy's a natural.»

«Yeah» he said, thinking that his two best friends, neglected for the dumbest reason, would surely welcome him back with open arms, and just as surely roast him alive for a good while afterward. Revenge, as Teo loved to repeat, was a dish best served at breakfast, lunch, dinner, and even as a snack, unless you were on a diet.

After promising his mother he'd take his friends out to dinner the next day, Francesco said goodbye. He yelled something toward the bathroom door, behind which Walter was butchering *All Along the Watchtower*, Hendrix version, complete with improvised guitar solos, and between verses Walter shouted back something vaguely intelligible like, *See you next time, kid!* before jumping perfectly back into the refrain.

Then he left, feeling like he was about to be frozen in carbonite like Han Solo and displayed in the living room of his two best friends, the same apartment they'd all shared four years earlier, until he'd gotten a girlfriend and Sergio had moved to Milan for work.

When Sergio opened the door – ready for his usual dialectic skirmish with the Jehovah’s Witnesses, who still couldn’t grasp his *scientifically proven thesis on the nonexistence of God*, despite hours and hours of detailed explanation – and found Francesco standing there, holding *Apocalypse Now*, for a moment his face broke into a genuine smile. Then, twisting that joy into a wicked grin, he shouted, “Teeeo! Guess who’s here?”

«Fraaank?!» came the reply from the living room, his voice struggling not to burst into laughter.

«And *Apocalypse Now*.»

«*Apocalypse Now*?! Someone needs a bed!»

«And a flowerpot.»

«A flowerpot, obviously.»

«You guys are idiots, you know that?»

The two exchanged a smug smile, as happy as kids on Christmas morning, thrilled to be together again, trying to hold onto that sort of late adolescence from which they were supposed to emerge as adults sooner or later, even if biologically and socially they already were.

«How’d you know it was me?» he asked, then realized, «Ah... she already called?»

«Just hung up. Come on in, Fiamma told me you lost both your job and your girlfriend this morning.»

«Oh, shit...» muttered Sergio.

«Exactly, but in the opposite order.»

«Damn, I didn’t remember him being such a stickler, did you?» asked Teo.

«Nope, not at all.»

They laughed.

«Okay, give us some input.»

«Not much data to process, there is a crisis.»

«Yeah, we know. Our friend here» he said, pointing to Sergio, «as you well know, had to move back after getting a small taste of Milan's nightlife but what we really want are the juicy details.»

«Yeah, I figured. But there's not much to tell, I came home early and found another guy in my bed and in my woman.»

The two burst out laughing.

«Forgive us» said Sergio, «we missed your innate gift for summary.»

«There's not much to summarize. The bitch had another guy, a full-on hipster.»

«No way! Fiamma didn't mention that. Hipster... hipster?»

«Beard and tattoos included.»

«Oh, fuck...» they both exclaimed in unison.

«I can't stand those guys.»

«Tell me about it. The world's going to hell. So what'd you do?» asked Teo.

«Did you punch him?» added Sergio.

«Nah, have I ever laid a hand on anyone?»

«No, but one day you should start, it might be cathartic.»

«Maybe. But I should've hit Anita, she's the one I trusted.»

«True, but come on, you should've seen it coming, given her job» said Teo.

«A nurse...» added Sergio.

«Christ, not you guys too. What, every woman who works in a hospital's automatically a slut?»

«No, of course not. It's just... with the kind of suffering they deal with every day...»

«They learn to mix the uterus with the useful better than anyone else.»

They laughed.

«But really, you never noticed?» asked Teo.

«Never really thought about it.»

«I can't believe my ears» said Sergio. «And yet you'll agree that everything in the universe can be reduced to, and expressed through, mathematics, right?»

«Christ, Sergio, where are you going with this?»

«It's obvious, come on. The patterns are right there, always have been. And I'm not talking about pure mathematics, but about basic, simple intuition. Nurses get laid more easily than most, legal secretaries seem genetically incapable of marriage and make up for their lack of affection with pets...»

«Not by sleeping with them, just to be clear» added Teo.

«Yeah, I got that.»

«And the guys who blow their girlfriends' brains out in the middle of some stupid argument are always cops.»

«Or night guards...»

«Or traffic wardens...»

«Rich girls are hornier than working-class ones, priests like kids, and nowadays, until around twenty-two, all girls are lesbians.»

«Come again?!»

His friends laughed like kids, delighted to be back at it, trading lines and teasing him in turn.

They'd known each other since kindergarten, and followed the same academic path all the way through to high school graduation. That's where their roads split. Sergio, already a computer prodigy back then, switched to Humanities after a brief stint in Computer Science, he couldn't stand dealing with professors who knew less than a third of what he did. Teo, whose real name was Gianfranco but who'd earned the nickname Teo from his habit of beginning every sentence with

“theoretically” enrolled in Physics and graduated with honors with a thesis on string theory.

Francesco, who didn’t have the financial comfort of a father who owned a huge villa on the hill of *Apparizione*, shared, incidentally, with a girlfriend twenty years younger who looked straight out of the Playboy Mansion West, since poor Teo’s mother had died young, or of a family of renowned lawyers like Sergio’s, ended up settling for a three-year diploma in Web Design. The only useful thing he learned there was the names of the teachers who drifted in and out of the classroom as if they had nothing better to do.

Their combined IQs nearly reached five hundred, and maybe that’s why they were all equally disappointed with their respective university paths. Sergio got his philosophy degree without breaking a sweat, causing minor earthquakes within his family. He figured the only way to make it through college was to study something he knew absolutely nothing about, only that way could he overcome the contagious lack of enthusiasm of the professors, who seemed hell-bent on shaping their students with as little effort as possible.

Teo, genuinely interested in theoretical physics and string theory, dropped out of a highly prestigious PhD program that would almost certainly have landed him at CERN in Geneva, because he knew that, in any other dimension, be it twenty-six or just ten, none of his alternate selves would ever agree to work without pay.

In the normal world, the one filled with soccer matches, trash TV, American bars, and bearded hipsters everywhere, having a higher-than-average intelligence might, in some cases, be a point of pride. But most of the time, it didn’t bring any kind of well-being. Quite the opposite. From the early school years, the three of them had been unpopular among both classmates and teachers. The feeling was mutual, so their interactions with the

rest of the world were kept to the bare minimum required for survival. They parted ways, figuratively speaking, only after graduation and, toward the end of their university years, ended up living together for four hilariously chaotic years. When Francesco met Anita, their relationship, and what he mistook at the time for common sense, led them to move in together.

Maybe if his mother and his friends had explained their “nurse theory” to him earlier, none of that would have happened. Then again, having above-average intelligence, as the Mensa nerds loved to remind them, was one thing. Knowing how to live in the real world was another.

«I see nothing’s changed in here» he said, putting Apocalypse Now down.

«No, the place is pretty much the same.»

«Except...»

«Except what?» Teo asked, sounding suddenly worried.

«Well, let’s just say your old room...»

«Yeah, your old room...»

«Jesus, guys! What happened to my old room? You didn’t sublet it, did you?»

They laughed.

«No, no, we wouldn’t let strangers in here.»

«To be honest, we’re not even sure we want you here.»

They laughed again.

«It’s just that, since your room was sitting there unused...»

«And we didn’t exactly need the space...»

«Well, we used it for...»

«Christ, guys, will you just tell me what the hell you used it for?» he asked, a little uneasy. He wanted to just walk down the hallway and see for himself, but it had been too long since he’d lived there to act like he never left. Teo and Sergio wouldn’t have cared, but it was a matter of principle.

«Relax, Onion Boy» said Teo. «It's not like we used it to chop someone up, Dexter-style.»

«What a shitty TV show, anyway.»

«We just shoved a bunch of stuff in there.»

«Yeah» laughed Sergio, «the stuff we didn't need.»

«Oh, crap...» burst out Francesco. «The Chamber of Horrors?»

«The Chamber of Horrors» confirmed Teo.

«Splendidly illustrated» added Sergio.

The Chamber of Horrors was the domestic incarnation of a bloodthirsty mythical beast, at least, that's how Francesco pictured it. Back in the day, his roommates had always bragged about its necessity, to avoid wasting time and energy trying to decide which gadgets were useless, which clothes too worn out, which shoes to get rid of, which comics and books they'd never read again, which furniture bored them, which broken appliances might someday be worth fixing if the shopping center didn't have replacements, which old computers might yield vintage components someday, which obsolete consoles and bulky CRT monitors might, in a few hundred years, be sold to some hipster for thousands of energy credits.

If it hadn't been for Francesco, at least during their years of cohabitation, Sergio and Teo would have thrown only smelly garbage into the dumpsters, happily sharing their already limited space with non-functioning household appliances, a washing machine here, a fridge there.

Philosophy and theoretical physics were both respectable disciplines, searching for answers to the greatest existential questions: the meaning of life and all its whys and wherefores, but just because Sergio and Teo could elegantly debate the Critique of Pure Reason or the flaws of standard quantum mechanics didn't mean either of them could operate a carpet cleaner properly, or even wanted to. Francesco had always

possessed the best home automation interface, as the other two liked to joke whenever, unable to train them in basic household maintenance, he preferred to take care of things himself.

Yet, looking around that day, he didn't notice anything out of place in the apartment. The floors were clean, the sofa covers didn't seem to have any particular stains, there were no dishes scattered around the living room or sticky glasses glued to the furniture. The bookshelves weren't caked in dust, and even the large windows overlooking *Via Isonzo*, in that almost trendy neighborhood that twenty years earlier everyone called *The Bronx* instead of *Sturla*, looked clean. His friends didn't seem to be wallowing in pestilential nests crawling with scabies or any of the other apocalyptic scenarios he had half-consciously imagined, as a way to dodge the guilt of having left them behind. As if, without him, Sergio and Teo couldn't help but turn into a pair of hyper-intelligent hobos.

But apparently, that hadn't happened. They had simply crammed all the useless stuff into what used to be his room, his world. A subtle act of revenge, maybe, or just the unconscious need to fill the void he'd left behind. Two comforting theories, in a way, if he hadn't known perfectly well, as his mother had reminded him since childhood, that the world did not revolve around him.

The truth was, Sergio and Teo were just lazy. Which, all things considered, was perfectly understandable. There was no great truth, no profound answer to life, the universe, or everything, to be found in taking out the trash. Not for a philosopher, and even less for a theoretical physicist who knew perfectly well (or almost) that there existed a dimension where he had already done it, another where he was doing it, another where he would do it, and even one where the very concept of trash had no meaning at all.

So Francesco decided that for that night, he could easily sleep on the couch. It was Friday the thirteenth, and he felt he'd already done more than enough for one day.

They spent the afternoon at home catching up on each other's lives, trying – sunk into the couches in the same old positions as always – to erase from the timeline those years in which they had each tried to make their way through the world alone. Not that those had been wasted years, or that they'd frittered away their time, of course: Sergio had gained valuable work experience at one of the top IT companies in the country, at least until the CEO fled to the tropics with money that wasn't his, forcing the company into an even tighter spending review that cut its staff in half. He could have easily found another job in Milan, but the city depressed him: the climate, the complete lack of class among its inhabitants, people who, despite having no real talent or distinction, strutted around acting superior to everyone else, and, not least, that hipster invasion that, like in old sci-fi movies, seemed to have wiped out the local youth and replaced them with alien life forms made of beards, tattoos, oversized glasses, pointed shoes, rolled-up pants, and wool hats holding back thick hair even in August. Sergio, though barely thirty, couldn't imagine living in a city where young people still wore sunglasses after ten at night.

Teo, for his part, had indeed made a crazy decision by abandoning his academic career, but someone had to start rebelling against that system of legalized exploitation, so quintessentially Italian. Sure, doing so had exponentially increased the distance separating him from the Swiss particle accelerator, probably even closed that path off for good, but he was proud of it. He might well have ended up selling used records at a market stall – since a degree like his wouldn't have

opened even the doors of Feltrinelli – but no professor, ever, would have signed his research again. Francesco, though he admired his courage, had his doubts about that decision, but he didn't say so.

He got up from the couch around dinner time, when his stomach, growling loudly, reminded him, just like in the old days, that if he wanted to eat, he couldn't rely on a philosopher, let alone a theoretical physicist. But before he could check the state of the fridge, once populated by the Ghostbusters monster, the door buzzer rang.

«Someone rang?» he asked rhetorically, waiting for permission to open.

«Well, I hope so» said Teo, «given the time.»

A female voice caught him off guard. He buzzed the door open and waited by the entrance, while the other two didn't seem inclined to move.

When the elevator reached the floor, Francesco saw emerge what he first mistook for the prettiest, sexiest pizza delivery girl not just on this planet, but in any parallel or perpendicular universe. About one meter seventy, brown hair framing an almost perfect oval face, and two large green eyes that reminded him of something he couldn't quite place. She wore a pair of combat boots, black leggings, and a matching tank top that enclosed a bust capable, all by itself, of invalidating Einstein's theories on gravitational interaction, and she carried three pizza boxes.

Francesco froze in the doorway, stunned not only by her beauty and charm, but by the radiant smile she gave him when she saw him. One of those smiles so genuine, so explosive, that couldn't possibly be faked for a better tip.

Completely short-circuited, he stepped forward and took the pizzas from her. She kept smiling, and the two dimples forming on her cheeks sent his endocrine system into overdrive.

They stood facing each other for a few seconds. She seemed to be waiting for Francesco to make the first move. He would have loved to toss the pizzas off the landing, three floors down, just to free his hands and take her in his arms and kiss her, first on those dimples, and then, of course, on the lips. In a whirl of passion, they'd have stumbled inside, his friends would've evaporated instantly, even out the window if necessary, and the two of them could have made love, unexpected, devastating, the way only dreamers can.

So when the closing credits of that magnificent adventure – compressed into the blink of an eye, complete with sex, marriage, children, and old age – rolled upward on the screen of a movie that existed only in his imagination, and after he had twisted internally without moving, feeling as if he'd just swallowed a cocktail of cyanide and laxative, Francesco finally made his move.

«How much do I owe you?» he asked.

«What the hell have you been smoking, pine processional caterpillars?» she shot back, in an instant shifting from angelic to sarcastic, giving poor Francesco a shock close to an embolism. That phrase, that expression, was one of the clichés often used by Sergio's younger sister: a sharp girl he'd seen born and grow up, who, barely out of her teens, often hung around their place to study or play on the computer.

«Mi...» he stammered, «Miranda?!»

«Christ, Frank, what's wrong, are you having a stroke?»

«God, Miranda, you were just a kid two days ago.»

«Two days, right. It's been at least two years since we last saw each other» she said, punching him on the shoulder, just like Fiamma used to.

Then, finally, they hugged.

Francesco couldn't believe that the girl he'd once known so well could have turned into a woman like that, almost overnight.

He even felt ashamed for having such thoughts about her, and her breasts, hard as marble against his chest, did nothing to lessen that shame.

«Jesus, Miranda» he said, trying to recover some of their old familiarity, «you've turned into a knockout.»

«Yeah, sure» she said, and punched him again.

Francesco didn't push it, it wasn't the time to flirt with her.

«So» she asked, «what's going on? It's been ages since we've seen each other.»

«He lost his job» said Sergio, stepping in and grabbing one of the pizzas.

«And the girl too, all on the same day» concluded Teo, grabbing another pizza box.

Miranda looked at him, puzzled, and he nodded slightly, confirming that the two, as much as they were jerks, weren't lying.

«Christ, I'm so sorry, Frank» she said, hugging him again.

«And you bastards» she went on, «you send me emails and texts for the dumbest reasons, and when something serious happens, you don't tell me a thing?»

«We wanted to see his face» said Sergio, «that's why we didn't tell you.»

«Yeah» added Teo, «he didn't even recognize you right away. I swear he was already thinking about unhooking your brassiere.»

«You really are an idiot, you know that? First of all, I'm not wearing one, and only nerds like you still call it a brassiere.»

Francesco blushed.

«You could've at least texted me to grab an extra pizza.»

«Eh, whatever, we'll share these, what's the big deal?»

«Share my ass» she said, winking. «You guys can eat your usual loser pizzas, Frank and I are going out.»

Sergio and Teo stood in the doorway with the pizza boxes in hand, staring at each other in surprise but saying nothing, while Miranda dragged their friend out of the apartment. They didn't hang out with many girls, that much was obvious, but as much as they loved teasing her, they knew perfectly well that Miranda always had the last word. So they retreated, pleased at the thought of having a half pizza bonus. Provided, of course, that she hadn't ordered one of her usual monstrosities, a mutant creation of ten random ingredients that sometimes had nothing in common with pizza except the shape.

They sat down at one of the tables in a fried-food joint, one of the last survivors, for which even the WWF, with all its asexual pandas, had mobilized. A peculiar place, mostly populated by old folks from the neighborhood and a few stray customers, given its absurd opening hours. Showing up at nine meant finding the shutters halfway down and the chairs flipped on the tables. The ideal time to get a full meal there was around hospital dinner hour. At six-thirty, they would've been safe, but at that time of day, anything could happen. Luckily, it was Friday, and although the kitchen was already closing, the two of them still had a decent time window to grab something hot.

Fortunately, hipsters, who survived entirely on aperitif dinner and didn't feel the slightest pang of hunger until after eleven, when, if they couldn't score another drink, they might reluctantly head to a restaurant, had no idea this place even existed.

«So» said Miranda after ordering fritters, *farinata*, vegetable pies, and a jug of red wine, «tell me everything.»

«Not much to tell» he said, still a bit surprised at the girl's appetite. «There's a crisis... and there are hipsters.»

«Shit! Hipsters... hipsters?»

«Full package: beard, tattoos, the works.»

«Christ, I'm sorry, Frank. You really didn't deserve that.»

Miranda was the only one who could call him Frank without irritating him, she always had been, but he realized it only now.

«No, I guess I didn't. But you know what's funny, if you can call it that?»

«Go on.»

«When I walked in and saw her there...» he paused, judging it a bit indecent to specify the exact angle of his ex's position, «I mean, I felt hurt, betrayed... yeah, the whole emotional starter pack, but it immediately hit me that I didn't actually care about her, you know? I was with her, and I never really questioned it. I mean, I never saw her as the mother of my children, sure, but I didn't think of it as some passing fling either. What really messes with my head is thinking how long that story could've dragged on if I hadn't lost my job and come home early today.»

«Well, if I can say so, Anita never did much for me.»

«You never told me that.»

«Of course not, what for? Would you have listened?»

«Why wouldn't I have?»

«Come on, I had just turned twenty back then, and you were what, twenty-seven, almost? Would you really have paid attention to what you thought was your friend's little sister's opinion?»

«Well, I don't know, it's just strange how...»

«How I've changed?»

«Well, yeah... you're still really young, but...»

«I'm living through my hormonal spring, I know it. I've exploded. I've got boobs hard as marble, every curve in the right place, that sort of thing. It's a blast, if it weren't for all the stares sticking to me on the street. But really, what did you expect from a nurse?»

Francesco spread his arms without answering, finally accepting that truth everyone else seemed to have known but him.

«Anyway, losing your job turned out to be a good thing» she said, filling their glasses with the house red: fourteen degrees of unbaptized violence in a vaguely defined blend: a must for the neighborhood's geriatric summer. «Think about it: it's had plenty of positive outcomes, hasn't it? You woke up, ditched a

relationship that was going nowhere, reconnected with your friends...»

«Yeah, you're right» he said, raising his glass, «not all bad things come to harm.»

They toasted. Repeatedly.

«Listen, Miranda, can I ask you something?» he said, slightly tipsy by now.

«You want to know why I dress like this, don't you?»

«God almighty, yes...» he burst out, «I'm killing myself trying to look you in the eye.»

They laughed.

«You're a sweetheart, Frank, you always have been» she said, reaching across the table to gently stroke his cheek. Frank sought oblivion in another glass of wine. «Basically, there are two reasons: hipsters and my old classmates.»

«Hipsters?» he asked, surprised.

«Yeah, you're not the only one who hates them, you know? I can't stand them, they just grabbed random habits and styles that were never theirs...»

«They ruined nerd culture.»

«Right. Not that I was thrilled to be labeled one, like you, Teo, and my brother, but that's what we were.»

«And what we're now partly ashamed of.»

«Yeah, and not for the same reasons we were embarrassed back then.»

«Like being smart and broke?»

«More like being smart and more interested in tech and science than the opposite sex.»

«Well, that was only for a limited phase of our adolescence.»

«Relatively limited, let's say.»

They laughed.

«And your friends, what do they have to do with it?»

«Everything. I was fine when they needed help passing a test, fixing a computer, or something like that. But when it came to going clubbing, to parties, or anywhere they could meet someone, I was the weird friend better left at home. And yeah, I was weird, and skinny and bland, let's say, but now I'm having my revenge, and I intend to enjoy it. And, to be honest, I like dressing this way. It's kind of a tribute to...»

«Lara Croft, yeah» he laughed, «I can imagine...»

«God» she whispered in his ear, «you've no idea what I'd give to walk around with a pair of pistols strapped to my thighs.»

Francesco emptied his glass in one gulp, trying to keep his face from bursting into flames. Miranda noticed, but pretended not to, lowering her head to focus on the fritters. Even she, who had never thought of him that way, now felt a certain attraction to the man she'd always seen as older and who suddenly seemed just a good-looking guy, a lifelong friend, with all the complications that implied.

«I heard you passed the bar exam» he said once his color had faded a little.

«Yeah, I'm a fucking lawyer now. You should see me in a suit, heels, and computer glasses.»

Francesco refilled his glass.

«Crappy job, though» she went on. «I'm an intern now, making something like five hundred euros a month in a firm where the partners rake in God knows what. Shakespeare was right, no doubt about it.»

«Yeah, but why law? I know your parents pushed you, but you could've picked anything else.»

«You think so? I don't know. You know they still haven't recovered from my brother, right?»

«Really?»

«Yeah, they already hated the idea that he could make a living programming, let alone making music. You remember, don't you?»

«Of course, I still have some of his electronic stuff on CD. He wasn't bad, for a kid with a computer.»

«Yeah, but for them it was a shock, you know how they are. Anyway, philosophy was the final straw, they never got over it. He and Dad had a huge fight a couple of years ago. Dad cut him off, that's why he moved to Milan to work. But then he had to come back, because of the crisis, because he hated the city... and the hipsters.»

«Yeah, not exactly the best place to live.»

«Exactly. And now, even though he'd never admit it, he's barely scraping by. He's broke, well, not literally, but if he didn't have Teo to share rent with and his sister bringing him food, he'd have to move straight to Hipsterland, and not just move there, he'd have to get tattooed and grow a beard too.»

«Jesus, what an apocalyptic scenario» he laughed.

«Yeah, well, it sounds funny» she smiled, «and sure, there are worse problems, I get that, but things are going downhill fast. Even Teo's got trouble with his dad. He hasn't cut him off yet, but he's getting close. And thank God he has no idea what his son turned down when he ditched his PhD. The guy just wants Teo to come work with him. Can you picture him as a plumber?»

They nearly choked on the *farinata*.

«Seriously, what's weird to me» he said, «is thinking that my friends, at their age, have no problems living off their parents.»

«That's another topic which, as you well know, is hard to bring up with a philosopher and a physicist. Sometimes I think those two planned their studies just so they could reshape the universe around them however they liked.»

«Yeah, they can seem a bit self-centered at times, but they're not. They're good guys. It's just that all of us, and a lot of other people too, to be fair, were missing something, a reference point. I didn't have my father, Teo didn't have his mother, and Sergio...»

«Well, Sergio and I still have our parents.»

«Exactly, and that's your problem.»

They laughed.

«So tell me» he said, joking, «are you dating anyone, married? Where are you living, what are you up to besides work?»

«Nothing much, to be honest. I was in a relationship for about a year with a guy who seemed fine at first. Then one day he showed up wearing pointy shoes, started rolling up his pants, talking about tattoos, and one night at a restaurant, would you believe, I caught him photographing his plate of ravioli.»

«No way.»

«As if nothing were wrong.»

«So what did you do?»

«Went to the bathroom and never came back.»

«Nice one, Randi!» he shouted, reviving the nickname everyone used for her as a kid.

She shivered.

«After leaving the restaurant» she went on after a generous sip of wine, «he must've walked straight into a tattoo shop. I ran into him some time later, just for a second, he was unrecognizable. Tattoos everywhere. He had a camera inked on his wrist.»

«A reflex?»

«Obviously. But what's the point?»

«Don't ask me. Let me guess, he's not a photographer?»

«No. And even if he were? He's an accountant.»

«Well, that explains everything.»

«Yeah.»

They managed to finish dinner and even have coffee before the lady behind the counter informed them she was about to close. Francesco checked his phone, it was quarter to nine.

«Your brother can't stand Milan, fair enough, but I just don't get this city» he said once they were outside. «It's not even nine and we've already been kicked out of a restaurant.»

«A fry shop, come on. Not exactly the same thing.»

«Maybe. But what options are left here? Have you been downtown lately? There's not a single shop open, and I'm not just talking about comics and computers, those days are gone, but in general. Last Christmas I wanted to buy Anita a pair of Dr. Martens, and guess what? There's no one left selling them, except that ridiculous hipster place at the top of *Via San Vincenzo*. They wanted two hundred euros. I ended up ordering them from England for half that, shipping included.»

«Let's hope they were too small for her» Miranda smiled.

«Yeah, at least that.»

«Oh, almost forgot, tomorrow night we're all invited to dinner at my mom's. You busy or something? I'd really like you to come too, she wants us to meet her new boyfriend.»

«She still calls them that?»

«That's exactly what I told her. But this one... I don't know. I only talked to him for a couple of minutes, but I couldn't bring myself to dislike him like the others.»

«No kidding, then something's definitely off» she laughed. «Anyway no, I've got no plans. I'd love to say hi to Fiamma.»

«No plans on a Saturday night? What's wrong, you got the plague?»

«No» she said teasingly, «just two perky boobs that both excite and scare the hell out of you guys.»

«O...K...» he drawled, relaxed by the wine. «On behalf of the entire male species, I formally apologize.»

«Apology accepted.»

They walked together for a while, Miranda lived alone not far from Teo's place. Her parents had bought her a small apartment in a particularly charming corner of *Sturla*. She hadn't told him right away, she was a little ashamed of it. That apartment was, in a sense, her compensation for choosing law school, or at least that's how he understood it. Not that she'd had any clear plans before graduation, it had been hard for her to make up her mind with her brother's desertion fueling her parents' pressure. Like everyone else, she wasn't exactly eager to work, but since she had to, she figured it'd better be something well paid eventually. The important thing, she decided, was not to sell out, never to become one of those adults who think of themselves only through their degree title.

They said goodbye outside Teo's building, and as Francesco got into the elevator, he realized he didn't even have pajamas or a change of underwear for the night.

Once inside, after closing the door behind him, he found himself face-to-face with Darth Vader, lightsaber raised (Teo), and an Imperial soldier with blaster in hand (Sergio), both waiting for him in the dark, dressed as if they were heading to the Comicon.

«You have no escape, you filthy rebel!» yelled Darth, switching on his lightsaber and giving him a near heart attack. «What have you done with Princess Layla?»

«Speak, scum!» the Imperial soldier shouted, firing randomly with his noisy blaster.

«Jesus Christ» Francesco burst out laughing, trapped in the hallway lit only by their weapons' glow. «You two really have been smoking caterpillars again.»

«The princess is already in his veins!» Darth bellowed, waving the saber and hitting the chandelier, which miraculously didn't break. «They're already using the same turns of phrase!»

«Damn smuggler!» roared the Imperial trooper. «What have you done with my sister? Speak!»

«Guys» he snapped, switching on the light, «have you started getting high again or what?»

They laughed, taking off those masks that didn't just feel tight by now but also smelled of mold.

«And really, Sergio, I'm surprised at you» Francesco went on. «You should study the trilogy better. If you wanted to defend your sister, you could've at least dressed as Skywalker. All you needed was a hooded bathrobe.»

«I thought about it, but we have only one lightsaber.»

What a strange day, he thought, looking at his friends, packed like sausages, at their age, in two carnival costumes they'd probably worn once in their lives, before they were even old enough to vote. It was utterly ridiculous, but he hadn't laughed like this in years, he had to give himself that much.

«Been a good boy?» Sergio asked, once he had shed his white armor, though he was still pointing the blaster he'd brought over to the couch.

«Miranda» Francesco admitted, distracted, «she's changed so much. I'm a little confused about it.»

«Teo, are you hearing what I'm hearing?»

«Loud and clear, brother. And from what deep, unexplored abyss rises the sound of his voice!»

«Right, this guy took five minutes to forget Anita, huh?»

«Anita who?» he asked.

They laughed, completely relaxed, happy to be together again.

«Jokes aside, guys, Randi made me realize that darkness is coming.»

«I wouldn't call it real darkness, more like a tremor in the Force.»

«That intensifies around the twenty-seventh of each month.»

«Or when that filthy Imperial warrior in Ikea colors delivers tedious missives stuffed with bank slips.»

«So you're broke, then?»

Sergio and Teo looked at each other and nodded.

«A bit» they concluded.

«But you must have some plan to get out of this mess, right?»

They exchanged another look.

«Of course, we were thinking of subletting a room.»

They laughed.

«So you still have no idea what to do?»

«Are we talking seriously now?» Teo asked.

«Do I look like I'm joking?»

«Okay, but look, we're not yet sharing tins of pet food with stray dogs...»

«Nor sucking up gasoline with a kitchen sponge» added Sergio.

«We've just become aware that our liquids...»

«Are evaporating fast.»

«We'll definitely take action soon.»

«We'll give some private lessons.»

«Do some odd jobs.»

«Sell a kidney. By the way, how are you feeling, still peeing regularly?»

«Go to hell, you two, it's impossible to be serious with you.»

«You either, sorry. You show up on a Friday the thirteenth, out of nowhere...»

«Like Jason.»

«Exactly, like Jason, and...»

«I know» Francesco cut in. «Instead of taking you out, I worry about you.»

«Yeah, great friend you are.»

«Speaking of friendship» he went on, «you guys should do me a favor tomorrow.»

«Here comes the scam.»

«You should swing by Anita's and pick up some of my clothes.»

«Wait, what do you take us for?»

«Your name's Francesco, not Penny...»

They laughed.

«And why the hell should we go there?»

«I just can't face her.»

«But you don't care anymore.»

«That's not true. And even if I realized I don't love her, it doesn't change what happened. Who knows how long it had been going on... Oh, and by the way» he added, «tomorrow night we're all invited to dinner at my mom's, remember?»

«For a thousand buffalo» Teo groaned, «bad news never rides alone.»

«I'll buy you a couple of drinks beforehand, like the old days. You pick the place.»

An aperitif before dinner at his mother's had always been mandatory. Fiamma had some remarkable qualities, chief among them the ability to bounce back from emotional wreckage, but cooking was not one of them.

Sergio and Teo exchanged a look and nodded, a wicked grin spreading across their faces. Those favors would cost him dearly.

Just before lunchtime, syncing with Anita's shifts at the hospital, Sergio and Teo managed to recover most of their friend's wardrobe. Francesco would deal with the books and the rest later, once he'd mustered the courage to face the chamber of horrors he still hadn't dared to enter.

Anita actually seemed sorry, not so much for the end of the relationship – which, she admitted, might never have really begun – but for the way it ended. She felt guilty for what had happened, for how it had happened, but not for her choices. About those, she claimed, there was nothing she could do. When an opportunity made her spine vibrate all the way down to the base of her pelvis, well, she simply had to take it. That was just how she was. Teo and Sergio nodded, thinking about her job.

The hipster Francesco had found clinging to her like a koala to a branch must have made her vibrate indeed, resonate even, Teo thought, studying the apartment walls where every photo of (or with) Francesco had already been replaced by an equal number of shots featuring Anita and that prototype of homo sapiens. Judging by the pictures, that relationship had been going on for over a year. There were some on the snow, and Francesco obviously didn't ski, some with backgrounds that clearly not in the city, places Francesco had never set foot in, and one that looked unmistakably like a tropical beach. Either Anita had a teleportation device hidden in her bedroom closet, or the poor guy had swallowed a mountain of lies.

When they finished loading the car trunk, the two didn't even feel the need to bring up the subject again. Their friend's naïveté was so glaring that it wouldn't have lent itself to mere irony, not

for at least a semester. They couldn't even focus on finding the most expensive place in town to have him buy them a couple of rounds. Empathy had knocked them out cold.

When Francesco learned they'd agreed to meet at the Blues House, the pub they usually went to, not far from Fiamma's place, he figured something that morning must have spoiled their mood somehow. But he was in such high spirits at the thought of seeing Miranda again that he didn't pry. The last time he'd offered to buy them drinks, Sergio and Teo had managed to book a table at some ridiculous place behind *Via Roma*, where they'd spent the whole night forcing down oysters and champagne just to drain his credit card. But by midnight, as Francesco had predicted, the mollusks had taken their revenge on the two pickpockets, devastating their intestines and sending them sprinting to the bathroom over and over again.

They sat outside. Francesco was finally updated on the success of the mission. His clothes were, more or less boxed up, piled by the door of the chamber of horrors he still hadn't found the courage to open.

For the occasion, Miranda ditched her tight outfits and showed up in flared jeans and a light green cotton sweater with a wide V-neck. Francesco found her irresistible. She looked like a young version of his mother, who really had been a hippie.

«Why the Blues House?» Miranda asked as she sat down. «I thought you'd want to skin him alive.»

«Yeah, but we figured it'd be wiser, given the circumstances, to let the reborn Frank help us in other financial ways.»

«Darkness is coming.»

«Yeah, and things were better when they were better.»

«Okay» Miranda said, sitting next to Francesco and greeting him with a nod, «so no caviar and champagne tonight, we're going with beer?»

«I've been craving a *Sbagliato* for days» Teo said.

«Not a bad idea, you know? With this heat.»

They ordered four *Sbagliati* and waited for the drinks, chatting about nothing in particular. Francesco didn't ask for details about the mission, and the other two didn't rub it in.

At first, Francesco felt a bit uneasy, he'd have preferred more privacy to talk with Randi like the night before, but with the whole gang there, and Bla, their bartender friend they hadn't seen in months, it wasn't possible. Besides, he didn't consider it either socially or morally acceptable to start flirting with one of his best friends' sisters. Especially considering that, to him, she was still little more than a kid.

But Miranda could be many things. She was young, yes. Intelligent too, she shared the same genes as her brother. She had a sharp sense of humor and a background more varied than a tin of Dutch cookies, but she was certainly no child. She also felt drawn to him, strangely enough, since until a few hours earlier she'd never felt anything of the sort, and she'd known him forever. For that reason she knew perfectly well she'd have to make the first move. If she waited for a sign from him she could grow old in the meantime.

Francesco and his friends were all perfectly confident when it came to technology, deductive reasoning, and talking among themselves, but otherwise none of them had an interface suited to communicating with the real world, especially the female one. Not that she herself felt particularly at ease out there, in the so-called real world, but she was a woman, and biologically that gave her an extra gear, not to mention a sort of hacking skill she'd recently developed and that was paying off nicely.

For a few months now, Miranda had begun to think of the clothes she wore for work as a kind of costume that gave her special powers, first among them the ability to deal with her colleagues without any embarrassment or fear. As if there were two of her: one Miranda, shy and reserved, whose approach to

the real world was not much more evolved than her brother's or his friends' and another Miranda, uninhibited, lively, and utterly confident. But whatever costume she happened to be wearing that moment – sipping her *Sbagliato* and lazily picking at the olives and other snacks – she knew she had to wait.

Francesco had just escaped a relationship that most people would've considered devastating, escaped through the window, no less, not the door. The prognosis was still uncertain.

After the second round, cheerful and full enough to face Fiamma's legendary delicacies, like the killer raw *peperonata*, the sandpaper couscous, or the fossilized *gnocchi*, they set off toward the scene of the massacre.

Fiamma had cooked for them before, and each time she was unable to limit herself to the simple, foolproof dishes that got her through everyday life. She already felt she'd disappointed her son enough by failing to provide him with a proper father and had to make up for it somehow. As if impressing him in the kitchen could magically fix everything.

Fiamma was a good person, no doubt about that, but she often enjoyed taking a stroll through dimensions that Teo could only hypothesize about.

It's hard to describe their astonishment when they found before them a perfectly laid table, from which rose the unmistakable aromas of Genoese cuisine: *polpettone*, chard pie, *peperonata*, and *pesto*. Fiamma, smiling at the door, clearly hadn't lifted a ladle that afternoon. But what shocked them most, Miranda excluded, was the T-shirt Walter was wearing as if it were nothing special: Robotron 2084, limited edition for the game's release.

Walter greeted them warmly, leaving Sergio and Teo on the doorstep massaging their crushed hands. He winked at Francesco, then greeted Miranda with more delicacy. Fiamma,

bursting with excitement, couldn't stand still and hugged everyone at least twice.

Miranda pointed at Walter and gave her mother a thumbs-up. Fiamma exploded in a radiant smile.

«He cooked everything» she immediately confessed. «Wouldn't let me near the stove.»

Thank God, they thought. If only they'd known earlier, they wouldn't have stuffed themselves with snacks at the bar.

«Come in, guys» she went on. «Make yourselves comfortable. What a pleasure to have you all here.»

Fiamma reintroduced Walter to everyone, a second time, just to be sure, then pulled Miranda aside to compliment her. It had been ages since they'd seen each other, and even she couldn't believe what that little girl had turned into.

Walter played host without a trace of irony, which Francesco would have expected, and offered them an aperitif before sitting down. It was their third *Sbagliato* in a couple of hours. Then, curious about the T-shirt, they asked, and he told them he'd owned a small arcade in the early eighties, before the rise of personal computers. That's why he still had countless vintage T-shirts and gadgets, freebies from rental companies back in the day. He kept all those relics in a chest. The Ark of the Covenant, they thought, imagining the treasures that might be hidden inside. And when he said that one day he'd show it to them, the three felt a disturbance in the Force.

The arcade story fueled the first part of the evening. They started talking about video games, from the first Space Invaders, through Pac-Man and Marcus Brigstocke's famous 1989 statement: *If Pac-man affected us as a kids, we'd all be running around in dark rooms, munching pills and listening to repetitive electronic music*, then Donkey Kong, of course, Galaga, Crazy Climber, Joust, all the way to the greatest of all time, which even the latest hyper-realistic consoles couldn't hold a candle to:

Robotron 2084, the very one honored by Walter's shirt, for which Francesco, this time, would've gladly run to the ATM.

Then Walter told them what they already knew, the rise of personal computers, but from an angle they'd never considered. By the time they, a little tipsy, found themselves facing a plate of *gnocchi al pesto* fragrant as spring, they had forgotten they'd already eaten.

Fiamma listened proudly to her boyfriend, watching the reactions of her audience. She had high hopes for that relationship, as she'd already confessed to Miranda. That man had something she couldn't quite define, something that made him special. Too special not to be completely fascinated, and a little terrified, by him.

Walter was about their age, he said, when he suddenly found himself back at square one. He thought he was settled, with a steady, fun job, surrounded by young people, something honest, really, and he worked hard to keep up with the latest trends while the kids repaid him with their enthusiasm.

«But like all good things» he said, his gaze drifting somewhere far away, «it couldn't last forever.» Then he focused on *gnocchi*.

Fiamma shivered. Miranda noticed and smiled, resting a hand on her knee.

Francesco couldn't help but notice the parallel with his own life. Maybe Walter had even prepared that speech, but the meaning was the same: sooner or later, everyone hits a point where the only thing left to do is roll up your sleeves and start over.

Walter had been lucky, he said, very lucky, because he was young. Just over thirty at the time, and although it was painful, financially and psychologically, he'd had the strength to endure that and much more. He closed the arcade and started working

in the theater as an electrician and when his boss retired, he took over the business.

With the *polpettone* came Fiamma's doubts. After a couple of glasses of red wine to build up courage, she tried to probe gently, wanting to know what her son planned to do now that he had neither a job nor a girlfriend. Fortunately, he too, dulled by the drinks and drunk on food, didn't react as sharply as usual. He'd think of something, sooner or later. Surely, he wasn't about to end up sleeping under a bridge.

He was already back sharing an apartment with two of the brightest minds he'd ever known: one of the most promising programmers, who was also a philosopher, and a brilliant theoretical physicist. The sum of their intellects had to produce something explosive.

«Yeah, like a hydrogen bomb» Miranda added. «You're drunk. You should never drink.»

«No, on the contrary» Francesco replied. «I think alcohol perfectly smooths the edges of an otherwise too-sharp reality. Right now, I see infinite possibilities. We could even open a used record store.»

Sergio and Teo shot him a look. As much as all three of them loved music, like everyone else, none of them had any real knowledge of it. Only Sergio, who had once dabbled in electronic music, could claim to know a few bands, calling them "underground" would've been generous, that made 8-bit compositions.

Walter laughed. «Sorry, but I just can't picture you running a record store.»

«Why not?»

«Come on. I've read High Fidelity too, it's a great book, but you don't strike me as the kind of guy who arranges his collection chronologically. Actually, I doubt you even have one.»

«No records, true. But there are mp3s.»

«That's straight-up blasphemy. All right then, tell me: what's the title of Dylan's electric turning point album? And what songs were Hotel California and Stairway to Heaven copied from?»

There was a brief silence, then:

«Highway 61 Revisited, We Used to Know, Taurus» he answered.

Sergio and Teo gaped, waiting for the jury's verdict. Walter smiled, and as he glanced at Fiamma – overflowing with pride for her boy who had taken thirty years to start speaking her language – a kind of warm sadness washed over him. He realized that Francesco had always known that language. He'd always listened to his mother's records in secret, from Elvis to Little Richard, from Dylan to Young, from the Stones to Zappa. Everything except the Beatles, the only ones he'd never been able to stomach. But he'd always done it in secret, partly out of spite, maybe, toward that girl who never hesitated to give herself to the first guy at a rock concert, and partly to protect her from her own restless urge to live, which so often needed reining in.

Walter tilted his head slightly toward him and squeezed Fiamma's hand on the table, as if to say that he no longer needed to wear any mask, that he would take care of her now.

Then he changed the subject.

«A theoretical physicist, really?»

«Yeah» Miranda said. «One of the hardest degrees around, and one of the most useless in our country.»

«Even Feltrinelli gives a damn» added Sergio.

«Thanks, guys. Sometimes I wonder what I'd do without you, and the answer's always the same: I'd be happy.»

They laughed.

«So, why physics, if I may ask?»

«Well» he said, tipsy himself, «the choice was almost forced. My father's a plumber.»

Walter looked puzzled.

«A plumber, you know? Someone who sometimes deals with water and leaking pipes, but usually works knee-deep in muck, or worse.»

«And?»

«And so I decided to study something that would keep me as far as possible from ending up knee-deep in a sewer wearing fishing waders. After some quick calculations, I realized that the physics department... was the closest to home.»

Walter was amused, he didn't burst out laughing only because he still sensed, however faintly, the possibility that Teo wasn't joking.

«You mean» he said, «you picked such a degree out of convenience?»

«No, to be honest, the medical school was a couple hundred meters closer, but I couldn't face it. I preferred analysis to pathological anatomy any day.»

At that point, no one could hold it in anymore. Walter, between laughs, said something about never letting him drink again. Even Francesco and the others had never quite figured out whether Teo was joking about that or not. They didn't really know the reason behind his choice, and it certainly wouldn't have been the first of his crazy bouts of pragmatism.

«I wish I understood something about physics» Walter went on. «Everyone talks about strings and subatomic theory, but there's something I just can't wrap my head around.»

Teo straightened up, alert. «Shoot» he said.

«So, from what little I get, you and your colleagues spend your time splitting atoms into smaller and smaller particles until there's nothing left to split.»

«Pretty much.»

«Only when they don't have women around» Sergio added.

«So, always» Miranda concluded with a snicker.

«So, correct me if I'm wrong: subatomic particles could actually be just waves of energy?»

«Exactly. Everything might be made of tiny vibrating strings of energy.»

«No mass, no matter...»

«No restaurants for miles» Sergio added.

«But then» Walter said, slightly excited, «everything could come from nothing? We could all be a pure illusion? Everything just floating in the void? Just like the Buddhists say.»

Teo refilled his wine glass, triggering a silent alarm in his friends' heads. The drunken monologue could hit any second now. When sober, he seemed to speak on power-saving mode, as if he had a limited number of words to use in a lifetime. But when he drank a little too much, he lost all semantic inhibition, revealing his state through the very expression he normally avoided like the plague.

«Theoretically» he said, prompting a chorus of ironic groans, «it's very simple. The problem comes from the need to unite the two great branches of physics: general relativity, which we use to explore the astronomical universe, and quantum physics, which deals with the infinitely small subatomic particles. On one side, we have gravity, on the other, electromagnetism and the strong and weak nuclear forces. The issue is that these two sets of laws don't seem to want to get along.»

Walter didn't look as lost as they expected, he'd probably already watched a few documentaries on YouTube. Quanta were the new science fiction, and people of a certain age loved the genre far more than the young. Maybe because they'd actually lived that July of '69.

«So, whenever we need to use both» he went on, «say, to understand what the hell might have happened at the origins of

the Big Bang, we run into enormous paradoxes. Now, without getting too technical, string theory suggests that the fundamental units of the universe aren't particles, but vibrating strings that create each particle depending on their frequency, just like guitar strings, which, when plucked, produce notes. The real mess is that, mathematically speaking, to make string theory work, we have to assume extra dimensions where these strings can vibrate...»

«Okay» Walter said, «without getting too technical, let's just say tiny strings of energy vibrate to create the universe as we know it. Not to mention all the dimensions you guys keep adding just to make your equations add up.»

«I'll pretend I didn't hear that last part.»

Walter laughed. «Come on, just talking here. So the strings create the particles, all the particles. Then those particles form bonds, atoms, matter, and so on.»

«Exactly.»

«But these strings aren't tangible.»

«We're talking about the infinitely small. Theoretically, if a particle were the size of our solar system, the string composing it would be no taller than a tree.»

«But these strings, big or small, aren't made of marzipan, right?»

«Nor of almond paste, for that matter.»

«It's just energy» he said, excited now, while Fiamma watched him argue with pride, so eloquent, even if she hadn't understood a single word. «Dimensions or no dimensions, membranes or no membranes...»

«You're already getting ahead of yourself with the membranes.»

«Sorry, I saw a documentary on the cable the other night. But what I mean is, you physicists are looking for irrefutable

evidence in a field that might not have any. Hear me out, I'm about to have one of my youthful, cannabinoid epiphanies...»

«I'm sure it'll be mind-blowing.»

They laughed.

«Given all the above, which I won't bother summarizing, what if we were only what we now, collectively, believe ourselves to be? That is, nothing more or less than the product of pure imagination?»

«The product of some kind of collective unconscious, like Jung proposed?» Fiamma interjected.

For the first time in years, Francesco remembered that his mother had actually studied psychology once, though she'd never graduated.

«Something like that, yeah. We might not even exist at all, just think we do. You get me?»

«Wow» said Teo dryly, dangerously close to the bottom of his glass. «You said cannabinoid, not lysergic.»

Walter and Fiamma smiled, holding back comments. They'd both had their share of experiences, and Fiamma wasn't about to advertise them in front of her son. Though sooner or later, she'd have to.

It had happened at that concert. She'd taken half of one of the last decent acid tabs still around, and she was floating inside a bubble of music she could actually see. The crowd around her was radiating beautiful, colorful vibrations, when just ahead, near the stage, she noticed someone emanating a completely different spectrum of energy. She didn't have to think, she couldn't think, nor was there any need to. She instinctively knew she'd found her soulmate, and as she moved toward him, almost gliding over the packed front rows, she felt as if she were traveling through time.

She saw her future as a spectator, step by step: she saw her son being born, felt time slowly wash over her, whitening her

hair without troubling her. Maybe not consciously, but she knew, even understood, that she would never find a soul more akin to hers. So she claimed that energy as her own, without the slightest concern for who possessed it, she couldn't even make out his face, his looks, his bearing. Those weren't the frequencies her brain chemistry, or her soul, was tuned to at that moment. The next day, as she slowly resurfaced to reality, or at least to what people commonly called reality, she knew she had conceived, without needing any confirmation. Her body belonged to her, and she knew it better than anyone else, especially in that state.

She had never told anyone about that experience. No one knew, no one but that mysterious, sublime man. The man who, according to her fleeting vision of the future, should have spent his life beside her, and whom Fiamma, for all those years, had waited for, more or less consciously. Where the hell had he gone? she'd asked herself for more than a decade, day after day, until she finally convinced herself that he must have passed away. Their union had been absolutely perfect, empathetic, transcendent...

That boy couldn't possibly have forgotten her, it simply wasn't humanly possible. She was sure she'd left a trace, something that would have led him back into her arms. She couldn't remember how, but she must have. She would never have tolerated such a mistake.

And then, almost thirty years later, when she was fully aware that she'd probably never again meet anyone capable of giving her the same kind of shiver, she was forced to change her mind, in the middle of an improbable rock concert.

«Yes, I understand it's not exactly an academic concept» Walter went on, «but we have to acknowledge that there are still things science just can't explain. Simple things, without having

to go all the way back to the beginning of the universe. But tell me, sorry if I insist, didn't an explosion start it all?»

«Theoretically» Teo replied, refilling half his glass.

«But how were the gases and the elements capable of combining and exploding before the Big Bang created? That's what trips me out.»

«Well, a lot of scientists are looking for the same answers you are, using gravitational wave detectors» he said, his voice slightly slurred. «For now, there are only different theories. The Earth, for instance, might exist inside a wormhole, a tunnel connecting two universes, the famous Einstein-Rosen bridge. Does that ring a bell?»

«Well, I've watched Eureka on the cable» Walter laughed.

«Right, remind me why I even asked you?»

«Come on, jokes aside, what I mean is that we use our brain to decode, to study, to define patterns, to solve equations, to understand. But what if there were nothing to understand? What if the brain itself were the origin of everything?»

Teo stared into his glass, debating whether to empty it and let the alcohol take over, or stay lucid just a bit longer to enjoy those entertaining, if slightly blasphemous, New Age theories. A bit hipster, maybe.

«It's a bit like when you have to make a decision» Walter went on. «Think about it. For example: Francesco lost his job, and that's not great. Now he's back to square one, he has to start over, right? Well, let's say he decides to open a clothing store. The markups are huge, and people will never stop buying clothes. Sure, he'd need a downtown location, which means financial and energetic commitment. He'll have to fill out tons of paperwork, deal with city offices, bureaucracy, all that. Francesco doesn't feel like it, does he?» he asked, looking at him. Francesco raised his glass in response. «But still, he thinks about it, he warms up to the idea. The next day, it doesn't sound

so far-fetched. Sure, there are plenty of things to face, equations to solve, variables to juggle, but at least by thinking about it, he's put his ideas in order. After a week, the project starts to feel almost doable. He makes a few inquiries, visits some agencies, some offices, maybe a bank or two, and after a few months, who knows, he might even own his own shop.»

«O...kay...» Teo drawled.

«What I'm saying is that his mind simply got used to the idea, and by doing so, it created the real conditions for it to happen. Exactly like what might have happened with 1940s science fiction.»

«Excuse me?» Teo asked, now more tempted than ever to surrender to his drink.

«Everything that literature of the time described came true: computers, flying cars, space travel. Back then, no one would've believed it. Now literature and science are preparing us for parallel dimensions and time travel. Maybe, when our minds finally get used to the idea, they'll shape the universe we move through accordingly.»

«In that case» Sergio cut in, attacking a slice of vegetable pie, «I would greatly appreciate it if my mind could shape a universe in which I'm ten centimeters taller.»

They laughed.

Teo emptied his glass, but before he could climb onto his metaphorical podium to lecture on the topic, Miranda steered the conversation elsewhere, asking Fiamma how she and Walter had met.

Genoa no longer hosted major music events, but Fiamma didn't give up easily. She'd been born and raised with rock in her veins, as she often liked to say, and she still sought in every concert that raw energy, so vivid in the seventies, now all but vanished. Baustelle, Marlene Kuntz, Afterhours, Subsonica, they were all talented, relatively speaking, but none of them could

hold a candle to the sacred monsters of old, whose songs and T-shirts Fiamma still proudly owned: Beatles, Hendrix, Dylan, Stones, Led Zeppelin, Jethro Tull, Zappa, Bowie, T-Rex, Iggy, Reed, Young...

She'd seen them all, literally all of them: from the Beatles and Hendrix – accompanied by her older cousin in '64 when she was only ten – to all the greatest legends, right up to Nirvana and Jane's Addiction, the only ones who had managed to stir something close to the thrill of those days.

And she kept at it, undaunted, almost sixty years old now – skipping only the longest trips – still convinced that sooner or later, from one of those battered, badly mic'd stages that concert organizers kept setting up at the Palasport, the sacred flame of rock and roll would ignite again.

And it was right there, she said, after a Subsonica concert, where the audience looked like they'd all escaped from kindergarten, that she met Walter. They were both surprised to recognize in each other two kindred spirits, same generation, out of place in that sea of kids. Walter, at least, had an excuse, it was his job.

She was just a dreamer.

Her meeting with Walter had restored her hope just when she thought she'd lost it for good. Of course, she didn't go into details about the sensations she'd felt that fateful night, the concert where she'd met the father of her son. There was no point in claiming she believed she'd traveled through time, or taken part in a perfectly, if lysergically, synchronized fusion of souls. She simply and sincerely confessed, with touching honesty, that she hadn't been expecting much anymore, at her age. And then she saw him, off to the side of the stage, pressing big buttons on the light mixer. His movements matched the bursts of laser light onstage. Hidden in the shadows, like a god on Olympus, he controlled the weather of the scene: explosions

of green light timed to the kick drum, cascades of blue spotlights flooding Boosta as he pushed his keyboards back and forth on the spring-mounted stand. What happened on stage faded into the background, the music disappeared along with its sing-songy nursery rhymes for kids. Only the colored explosions remained, and Fiamma could focus only on those, until Walter pressed a big red button that didn't flood the stage with light but her soul. The concert was over, and their story was about to begin.

Miranda was moved listening to her. Francesco wasn't. As much as he liked Walter, which was new for him, since he'd never liked any of his mother's boyfriends, to him the man was still just another stranger picked up at a concert. The fact that his mother seemed genuinely happy didn't comfort him as much as it should have. Fear was always lurking. He knew Fiamma had always paid dearly for her moments of happiness, and although she was strong, always able to recover from the most brutal blows, the older she got, the slower and more painful her recoveries became.

He felt a strange ambivalence toward the man. And the fact that, instinctively, he recognized Walter as somehow different from all his mother's past partners, and that he liked him before he'd earned it, had the opposite effect: it made him wary. Something didn't add up.

«But you don't actually work with Subsonica, right?» asked Miranda.

«No, we just provide the service. But we've built a good reputation, so some bands, if they're not doing a major production, rely on us. It's cheaper than moving trucks and tech crews. Medium-small bands, obviously, not U2. Mostly, though, I work in theater.»

«That doesn't sound bad at all, wow.»

«Yeah, it's fun. Well, not so much the theater part. At a rock concert I can relax, most of the lights are computer-controlled, I

just coordinate some effects in sync with the music and my own taste. I might get a few notes from the artists, but nothing serious. It's rock, nobody notices if I throw a blue beam instead of turning on the green spots. Theater's another story. There I have to follow the script perfectly, compensate for delays or jumps from the actors, and make sure everything runs flawlessly. Theater keeps me on my toes.»

«So you can get us in for free?» Sergio suggested.

«Oh, that's no problem. I usually have a bunch of passes that go unused, unless the artist's too big, then the comps get rationed like medicine. If there's a show you'd like to see, just let me know.»

«Thanks» he smiled, now tipsy himself. «But I never go to the theater. Those jeweled old ladies covered in furs freak me out. They look like overdressed zombies» he laughed.

The evening carried on light and pleasant until dessert, a beautiful, creamy *tiramisù* Walter had made himself, like everything else. Fiamma, unusually, didn't dominate the conversation. She preferred to observe the guests' reactions to her man's words, especially her son's. She hoped everything went smoothly. She wanted his full blessing.

Even Teo, usually a chatterbox after a few drinks, was quieter than usual, maybe entranced by Walter's theory, maybe lost imagining an alternate universe where girls could perfectly tell the difference between a nerd and a hipster, and preferred the former, naturally. But once they stumbled out into *Via Caprera*, in front of an Hemingway bar full of hipsters drinking rum and forest-like cocktails, he realized he hadn't been imagining hard enough. If it hadn't been for Miranda, who, despite herself, drew envious looks from women her age and awed stares from the bearded hipsters trying to figure out how three average guys were out with such a knockout, they would have gone more unnoticed than Frodo wearing the Ring.

«Goddamn it» Francesco burst out, trying to cool off from the dinner, «I can't, I just can't stand these people.»

«Relax, Frank» Miranda said, slipping an arm around his shoulder, instantly drying the throats of a few specimens by the door who, after millions of years of evolution, still hadn't figured out they were making the waitresses' lives hell by standing there. «It was actually a nice evening. Fiamma's doing great. You should be happy.»

«I am, I think. But you know how it is with her, right?»

«Trust me, this time it's different. We women can sense these things.»

«Let's hope so» he murmured, returning her hug.

«The problem» said Sergio, catching up with them, «is that with Fiamma settled, our friend here's out of excuses.»

«He'll have to think about his own life» said Miranda.

«Yeah, his life, and the Chamber of Horrors. He can't keep sleeping on that couch.»

«Goddamn, I'd almost forgotten about that.»

«Last night you were rambling, or is that thing about the particle the size of our solar system actually true?» Sergio asked as he filled his mug with café au lait at breakfast.

Teo lifted his eyes from a slice of buttered toast he couldn't decide whether to eat. He tried to remember what the hell he'd been talking about after that losing streak.

«The one about the particle as big as our solar system and the string as tall as a tree?» added Francesco, staring dreamily into his mug of long coffee.

«Theoretically, yes.»

Francesco and Sergio looked at each other in disbelief.

«Are you still drunk?!»

«Don't be ridiculous... it just slipped out. It's not even nine yet.»

«God damn it, he's right. We really need to stop waking up this early» said Francesco.

«Why do you ask, anyway?»

«Nothing special. I was just thinking about last night and, no offense, but Walter's theories sounded more believable than yours.»

«He's got a point. Something as big as a tree that vibrates and produces a speck the size of the solar system? Sometimes I really want to meet your dealer.»

«You don't even deserve an answer, you heretics. You both need fire and oil, that's what you need.»

«Come on, Teo, look me straight in the eye» Sergio went on. «String theory's fascinating, sure, but it's all a hoax. You

physicists just invented something incomprehensible to avoid getting a real job. You formed a cartel, plain and simple.»

Teo shook his head, still too groggy to respond to the morning heckling.

«I bet at CERN» Francesco began, «they don't even have a particle accelerator, just twenty-seven kilometers of Polistil tracks. Forget bosons.»

«Lancia Fulvia and go.»

«Eagle in front, flames on the sides.»

«Head down, Abarth brain.»

«Sometimes you two really amaze me, you know? How can anyone be this idiotic in the morning?»

They laughed.

«Anyway, if time travel were ever really possible» Sergio continued, still laughing, «shouldn't we already be seeing weird people bouncing around in our time?»

«I see weird people every day.»

«For a thousand bosons!» cried Teo. «If hipsters really came from another era, we'd be doomed.»

«Maybe even from another dimension.»

«I hate to admit it, guys» said Francesco, «but I don't think we'll ever see a technology like that. At least not within the time we've got in this life.»

«How can you be so sure?»

«Well, it's obvious. Otherwise, we'd already have made contact with ourselves somehow. I know I couldn't resist the chance to meet me, so why would you?»

At that point, each of them fell silent, trying to find a way to counter that sort of postulate. And though plenty of clever loopholes might exist, like the impossibility of coexisting in the same slice of space-time, none seemed able to overturn the greater truth: they were alone in the universe, and sooner or later they'd have to decide what to do with their lives.

Francesco finally made a decision. It wasn't one that would change his life, but it was a start, and when he opened the door to his old bedroom, with the other two already smirking behind him, he froze. He had expected the most atavistic kind of mess, that primordial chaos only his friends could generate, the same magma from which the universe itself might have exploded into being. He'd imagined one of those tabloid scenes from a waiting-room magazine: a wooden house somewhere deep in rural America, where a couple of hoarders – as they called them now – had been found dead, suffocated by the trash they'd never dreamed of throwing away. He'd imagined a plastic continent, like the Pacific Trash Vortex, as big as Canada but zipped, compressed, freeze-dried, and entirely packed inside his old room. Even finding a pair of wrecked car chassis, demolished and abandoned, teetering on what used to be his nightstand, wouldn't have surprised him as much. He knew perfectly well his friends were capable of anything. They'd even prepared him for it, feeding his conviction that he'd face something beyond his strength, his means, his reason.

He had expected to find anything – anything but something truly macabre – but never, ever would he have dreamed of finding just half a dozen cardboard boxes stacked neatly against the wall beside a window that hadn't been opened in ages.

His bed was perfectly accessible, the room perfectly usable, just heavily dusted. None of his fears had come true. His friends had fooled him again. He'd slept two nights on the couch just because he'd been afraid to open a simple door. A few thousand bonus points for Sergio and Teo, not only had they played him, but they'd even handed him an unexpected moment of self-reflection.

«Didn't see that coming, huh?» they laughed. «We can move the boxes into the hallway later, take a look and see what to toss.

Your room's just how you left it, we never had the guts to sublet it...»

«Yeah, the last thing we needed was a hipster roommate.»

They laughed again.

«You just need to clean up a bit... well, a lot. There must be dust mites the size of rats in here. After all, you've been gone three years, surely you didn't expect us to play butlers for you, did you?»

They laughed again, while Francesco, nodding absently, was still thinking about those two nights on the couch, just the tip of an iceberg he was beginning to glimpse, one he definitely didn't want to crash into. Suddenly, as if someone had turned on a stereo in his head, a song started echoing, one of those he used to play in secret when his mother went off to work: *then you better start swimmin' or you'll sink like a stone...*

Never had a verse felt so fitting.

Times really were changing.

Darkness fell only a few months later. Autumn was at the door, the leaves were changing color, and so were their bank statements. It was the worst possible time of year to be broke. Francesco, Sergio, and Teo had just readjusted to living together, with all its pros and cons, when they could no longer ignore the problem. They weren't completely destitute yet, but after a quick calculation, if they managed to cut out all aperitif, movies, any kind of shopping, and even groceries from the discount store, they could at least keep paying rent for the coming year. Of course, they wouldn't survive until the next autumn without food, and there was no way Miranda, with her five hundred euros a month, could support them on her take-out pizzas and the occasional vegetable pie she baked to justify owning a kitchen she otherwise never used. After all, as she liked to say: she'd gone to classical high, not culinary, school.

Francesco called an emergency meeting to discuss the situation, though he quickly discovered there was very little to discuss. He'd been everywhere, sent out résumés to every corner of the internet, only to slam headfirst into reality: the job of web designer seemed to be the exclusive property of the very subculture he despised most. No art director, project manager, or editor seemed remotely interested in his portfolio. What they did notice was that he had no tattoos, didn't flaunt sunglasses indoors, didn't wear cropped trousers or pointy shoes, nor did he show the slightest urge to speak in slang. To make matters worse, he even dared to shave. Not every day, perhaps, but at least once a week.

How could someone that boring possibly consider himself creative? they must have wondered behind their designer desks, those jaded interviewers waiting for some hybrid between Bruno Munari and Nick Wooster. Too bad Francesco wouldn't have been in that position even if he'd possessed a tenth of either man's fortune. In any possible dimension, of course.

Sergio, for his part, confirmed he'd never stopped looking for work, but Genoa didn't seem to have anything to offer. He could move again, maybe back to Milan, maybe abroad, but certainly not just to keep his friends afloat. He still hoped to reconnect with his family one day, his father especially, not for financial help but because he knew the situation couldn't drag on much longer without doing irreparable damage to his feelings toward the man. He had simply chosen a different field of study, he hadn't killed anyone, nor dishonored the family. His father would do well to realize that before it was too late.

As for Teo, with his specialization, he could only keep begging for tutoring gigs from young hipsters who couldn't grasp the principle of communicating vessels, let alone advanced physics. But apart from that, which, admittedly, worked in his favor, the school year had only just begun, and no student yet felt desperate enough to seek outside help. He'd have to wait until the end of the first semester to feed on their fear.

If there really was a light at the end of the tunnel, the one the three of them were staring at was coming straight toward them, attached to the hood of a speeding sports car.

Even Walter tried to throw them a lifeline. Theater was dying, like all culture in Italy, but political conventions were booming, and his services were in high demand. He knew everyone in the industry, too, and even if a job wasn't directly his, he could probably sneak someone in.

They even paid obscenely well. Hanging from a lighting truss, harnessed like climbers on Everest, you could make

something like six hundred euros a day. Sure, you had to stay tied up like a salami ten meters off the ground for half a day, but a couple of gigs like that could fix your finances for a while. It was an opportunity, a great one, especially for those who weren't terrified of heights and actually had biceps, deltoids, and lats strong enough to handle the strain.

That certainly wasn't their case, thought Francesco, mutilating a couple of chili pepper from Apocalypse Now. However illusory it was, as every nerd knew, it was still lunchtime, and more and more often he found himself turning to his beloved companion, as Miranda – perhaps a little jealous – called her. After all, garlic and oil strained their finances far less than a trio of seafood pizzas ever could.

They needed to make a decision, thought Francesco, as he poured extra virgin olive oil into the pan, and he was more aware of that than his friends. He had no one to fall back on, and his mother, even if she'd wanted to, couldn't possibly have helped him. Sure, there was Walter now, and their relationship – still going strong – seemed almost unbelievable to him, but he would sooner dig through McDonald's dumpsters after closing time than ask her for money.

After lunch, with his breath heavy and his esophagus still on fire – Apocalypse Now was getting dangerous enough to require a license – he decided to take what he used to call a reflective walk. But if, back in the day, his wandering had revolved around the mystery of his father, that fateful concert, and all the unanswered questions that came with it, this time his thoughts were elsewhere. In his youth, he'd worried about why he was born. Now, about how to stay alive.

Times had changed, he thought, walking down *Via Caprera*, alone in a sea of bearded hipsters who, despite the weather, were already flaunting updated versions of the eskimo coat, mostly updated in price, and oversized wooden-framed Ray-Bans. He

tried to find refuge in *Piazza Sturla*, without success. The two adjoining bars that had dominated the intersection since time immemorial were already packed. Bicycles were piled along the sidewalk, almost blocking the elderly folks dragging those little shopping trolleys behind them. There was even a Segway parked beside the flowerbed in the middle of the road.

Via Sturla, toward the station, was even worse. The science high school looked under siege by teenagers in cuffed pants and thick, unkempt hair stuffed into wool tubes. Not to mention the eskimos, of course, and the enormous glasses. They spoke in some alien dialect, incomprehensible, made up of abbreviations, acronyms, and grotesque Italianized slang. They stood there for hours after class, the only people in human history with no instinct to flee what had always been considered a place of torture.

At the end of the street, only the tobacconist and the bicycle shop still held out. The furniture store and the appliance repair shop, where the whole neighborhood once brought its blenders to be fixed, had long been shut down, judging by the faded for sale / for rent signs glued to the inside of their dusty windows. The only one without any trace of hipster chic was the bike shop owner himself, wearing a high-definition 16:9 smile and a gold GMT Master, one of those thirty-thousand-euro showpieces flaunted only by mob bosses and butchers, the two categories genetically incapable of feeling shame.

In the end, Walter had been right. If that poor guy – shut away for years in a fifteen-square-meter hole, changing inner tubes for eighty-year-old cyclists dressed like psychedelic queens – had managed to ride the fashion wave all the way to that half-paralysis most people mistook for good cheer, then maybe they could do it too.

Maybe after robbing a bank.

He kept walking, cutting through the Basko parking lot to avoid the crowd of pointy-shoed teenagers outside the pizzeria. Instead of continuing on *Via Isonzo*, he veered right toward the train tracks, and when a nearly empty regional train pulled in, he jumped aboard without a ticket, as if those kids were zombies whose only goal was to have him for dinner.

With, not alongside.

He got off in Camogli, moving mechanically, trying to calculate the steps, and above all, the costs, involved in starting any kind of business. Then he took the trail leading up to Portofino promontory, where Fiamma used to bring him as a child, and where he hadn't set foot in years. He remembered a particular spot, a tiny patch of land near a place called *Semaforo Vecchio*, which, if memory served, might be the perfect hideout for Apocalypse Now, should the need ever arise.

If Fiamma had finished her studies, she would have probably talked about some kind of subconscious premeditation, and maybe she would have been right. Maybe that really was the only solution: to leave a dying country behind and start over somewhere else. For the first time in years, his mother no longer worried him the way she used to, and Walter truly seemed intent on staying with her. If it weren't for Miranda and his friends, this would have been the perfect time to hop on a train, a real one this time.

He didn't even stop at Portofino *Vetta* to admire the view. He pressed on, heading toward something he thought he remembered well enough to check out before the sun went down. But when he reached the exact spot – that tiny ledge of land overlooking the sea, hidden just off the trail, the one he remembered for some absurd reason so vividly – he saw something he never could have imagined. Something that made him flinch.

A chili plant, similar to *Apocalypse Now* but much larger, was growing there, lush and wild, taking up the entire little hollow, hidden from tourists' eyes. Francesco froze, stunned, speechless, more shocked than the Friday he found Christ hanging behind his ex's door. Even witnessing an alien attack that wiped out Portofino *Kulm* and the surrounding area wouldn't have confused him as much.

Who on earth could have had the same idea as him?

And more importantly: why?

«Have you ever seen a chili plant growing on the Riviera?» he asked that evening at dinner, staring at the pizza Miranda still hadn't gotten tired of paying for.

«Careful, that's a trick question!» blurted Teo.

«Why?» asked Miranda.

Francesco told them about that strange afternoon, from his escape from the hipster invasion to the regional train he'd jumped without a ticket, yet another experience missing from his collection. He described his walk up to *Semaforo Vecchio* and the subconscious reasons, perhaps, behind his wandering. Reasons that seemed to dampen Miranda's mood.

«So» asked Sergio, «did I get that right? You're thinking about getting out of here?»

«Yeah, well, no... I don't even know myself, guys. But the thing is, there's nothing left to do here. We can't keep going like this much longer, and you know it.»

«I actually don't know anything» said Teo. «And I know that I don't know. You're the one who thinks he knows, and doesn't.»

«O...K... and what is it I supposedly don't know?»

«For starters, how to manage your anxiety» he laughed. «But really, since you're so worried, have you ever seen anyone die of hunger in this city?»

«What's that got to do with it? Come on...»

«It's just your nature, that's all. We know you.»

«Before, you were stressing over your mother and her love life, to what end, exactly? Now that your mother, at her tender

age, has finally shown she can stand on her own two feet, you're here worrying about how we'll make it to the end of the month.»

«We will make it to the end of the month, relax. We're smart, we can come up with hundreds of tricks.»

«Enlighten me, then.»

Teo sighed and shook his head.

«Okay, random order: we could go around all the vets in the area and offer ourselves as cat sitters. People with cats always have a hard time going on vacation. And we, with the right credentials, real or forged, would surely earn the trust of the whole neighborhood. We could even set up live-streaming services on rental phones, in case the owners wanted to watch what their cats get up to while they're away.»

«Or we could hang around outside nightclubs on weekends and drive drunk teenagers home for a few euros.»

«Not to mention home tech support. With twenty euros we could print thousands of business cards and stuff every mailbox in the neighborhood, hell, the whole city. You'd be surprised how many people pay just to have someone set up their computer, antivirus, or ADSL connection.»

«And all under the table, of course.»

«There are hundreds of possibilities...»

«We could also win the lottery.»

«If only we played.»

They laughed.

In truth, Sergio and Teo weren't wrong, with a bit of imagination, it really was possible to scrape by, even if at their age they should've had a right to something more stable than a makeshift job born out of desperation.

«Anyway» Sergio went on, «didn't Walter offer you some dream job? Something like six hundred a pop?»

«Yeah, well, he offered it to anyone, really. But could you spend half a day tied to a lighting rig?»

«Frank, seriously, how are you? For six hundred euros I'd go an be a lampshade at a fetish party.»

«Sure, but not hanging from the ceiling.»

«No, you're right. Not by the nipples, at least.»

They laughed again.

Sergio hadn't realized it was an opportunity he could actually take, he thought Walter was only talking about his partner's son. He asked Francesco to find out more, a job like that would do him good, not so much for the money, part of which he'd put toward rent, but to use it as leverage with his father, hoping to reconnect somehow. His father, so confident in a courtroom yet utterly terrified when lifted even a few centimeters off the ground, would probably have a heart attack seeing him dangling like a ham. Maybe the fear something might happen to him would shake him up a bit.

In a few days, they were supposed to meet Walter and Fiamma for drinks, and Francesco would bring it up then. If Sergio wanted to play Spider-Man climbing ten-meter towers, he wasn't going to stop him. The problem was, knowing him, he wouldn't be surprised if he showed up at the theater in full costume.

At the end of the evening, Francesco walked Miranda home, leaving the other two snickering on the couch as they did almost every night. It was getting harder and harder for him to cover those few hundred meters. He knew, he felt, that he had to take a stand, make a move, do something, because time was slipping away fast, and sooner or later she'd get tired of waiting for Prince Charming – assuming he could even be that – and she'd end up with someone else. Maybe not a hipster, but someone eventually.

What held him back was having seen her born, grow up, remembering her as a child. He felt uneasy about the desire he now felt for her, unaware that Miranda had perfectly understood

it, and that his embarrassment actually excited her. That was why she hadn't yet done anything to shake things up, she was playing the long game. She hoped to reach the point where mutual attraction would obliterate all rational thought. Miranda played hard, the way her job had taught her. But Francesco was the only one she didn't have to wear a suit for. He was hers, she knew it, and that was precisely why she was worried.

«Are you really thinking about leaving?» she asked.

«No, I don't know. I told you, it was a weird afternoon. I ended up, almost by accident, in the same place my mother used to take me, and I don't even know why it shook me so much to find a plant just like *Apocalypse Now* right there. Christ, it gave me goosebumps...»

Miranda smiled.

«Maybe Walter's right» he went on. «Maybe we really do shape the universe we move through. I'd thought about that spot so long, it became real. Although at that point, the contradiction's obvious: what even is reality, if imagination can alter it?»

«It would be nice if that were true, I suppose. But then wouldn't we all be beautiful, rich, healthy, and ridiculously happy? If reality could be shaped by imagination, how would you explain all the suffering out there?»

«Maybe people just don't imagine enough.»

«Good thing we've reached my door, this conversation was getting delirious, and all because of your plant's clone. It's weird enough that you even call it by name.»

«You're jealous, huh?» He couldn't resist.

«You caught me» she said in a low, sultry voice. «I want to be the only one to set your guts on fire.»

With that, she kissed him on the cheek and vanished into the doorway, leaving him on the street, flustered, aroused, amused, and even more uncertain than when he'd left home. Miranda

was playing with him like a cat with a mouse, and for the first time, he knew it.

Walter confirmed the offer still stood: he could easily place Sergio in one of the crews, but he doubted anyone would put him up on the towers right away. Usually, newcomers only loaded and unloaded flycases from the trucks. He had to learn the ropes, do some grunt work, and then, maybe, if he proved himself, he might get to climb a tower. It had to be earned, because it was both an important and an uncomfortable spot. The floodlights up there shone directly on the stage, and even the smallest mistake wouldn't go unnoticed. But beyond that, there were priorities. It was the most dangerous job, and therefore the best-paid. Those who could handle it took turns based on seniority, experience, and physical condition. They depended on that money, good money for a single day's work, but those days didn't come often. Only big concerts or high-end conventions needed a tech up top. Sergio couldn't expect to snag the best position right away.

And then there was the matter of safety. No one in their right mind would strap a rookie to a tower on his first days. Not out of conscience, but because, unfortunately, plenty of workers had already met their end that way, and inspections in the industry were now tight.

A little disappointed to see his plan for family reconciliation go up in smoke, Sergio decided to drown his sorrows in Negroni. Teo joined him, and Francesco, more to be noticed by Miranda than out of genuine desire, ordered a Bloody Mary. Fiamma, Walter, and Miranda, who didn't need to prove anything to anyone, each asked for a pint of beer.

«Damn» said Sergio, widening his eyes after the first sip, «I was hoping to get noticed hanging up there.»

Walter looked at the others, puzzled, trying to understand what the hell he meant. Teo filled him in on the colorful plan.

«Holy shit» barked Walter, «I've heard a lot of crap in my life, but this one's easily top five, no question.»

Fiamma tried to soften the tone. Walter was always brutally honest, a quality she loved about him, but Sergio had seen him grow up, just as his son had seen Miranda grow up, and she wanted to protect him. Francesco, meanwhile, wanted something entirely different from that girl.

«It was just an idea. And it might even have worked.»

«Bullshit. Maybe your father's a bit old-fashioned, or maybe he's just an asshole, sorry, but he surely believes he knows what's best for his son. Whatever mistakes he's made, he's made in good faith. Okay, maybe law school wasn't your thing, but you could've studied something else, right?» His friends nodded. «But you, correct me if I'm wrong, enrolled in philosophy. Well, you can't exactly be shocked that your father's worried about you. Where do you think a degree like that's going to take you? Don't get me wrong, I never studied, unfortunately, and I'm not saying graduating in your field isn't an achievement. It's just that you could've aimed higher. See, most likely your father, as an adult, knows that when you're young, you don't really have a full picture of existence, so to speak. When you're young, the idea that you'll grow old one day doesn't faze you, and following your ideals, even at the cost of comfort down the line, seems like the only right thing to do. You have to understand that in someone like your father, two forces are at play: on one hand, a kind of benign envy toward the youth you still have and he's lost, on the other, frustration at not being able to guide you the way he'd like. Adults know

something you'll learn in time, whether you like it or not, and it hurts them that they can't spare you that time.»

«Jesus Christ» blurted Francesco, «are you sure you didn't study philosophy too?»

«Maybe in another life» Walter smiled.

Sergio should have been annoyed, usually, he couldn't stand people trying to lecture him, but Walter didn't have that effect on him. It must have been something in his voice, something reassuring, as if he wasn't trying to give advice, which, in fact, he would never dream of doing, but rather telling him a story. A story as personal as it was universal. Sergio got that, he sensed that shade of melancholy common to everyone past fifty. Everyone, for better or worse, carried some regrets, only idiots claimed otherwise. To that, you could add the frustration of not being able to pass your hard-earned experience on to someone else. Sergio wished he could get to know him better. Walter seemed like a cool guy. Sure, he had his years, but he didn't show them, and above all, he didn't act like people his age, like his father, for example. He didn't walk around with his shoulders stiff, chin up, and a broom up his ass, as if the world beneath his feet belonged to him, but he wasn't the kind of man you could mess with either, not even on a dark street. Walter looked like the kind who didn't bow to anyone, and didn't let anyone bow in his presence. Sergio couldn't say he was thrilled to be the topic of conversation, but he didn't mind it either. Talking about his situation actually helped him see it more clearly.

«Okay, let's say you're right, what would you do in my place? My father, our father» he corrected himself, glancing at Miranda, «he's a tough one. Once he gets something into his head, he can really dig in, and this thing has been dragging on for too long. I don't want to patch things up for money, let's be

clear, but I also don't want to end up hating him, and right now...»

«You're out of patience.»

«Yeah.»

«Then» said Fiamma, wiping beer foam from her lips with the back of her hand, «you have to make him feel proud of you, not worried. Show him what you're capable of.»

«Easy to say. But in practice?»

«Oh, I don't know, but something will come to you.»

«You all need work» Walter said. «You've been friends forever, and you get along. Open something together.»

«Like a bank?» asked Francesco.

«Yeah, I can just see you in ski masks.»

Miranda laughed. In the meantime, Bla brought over some snacks and, since the bar was quiet, sat down with them for a bit.

«So, guys, how's life?»

«The usual mess, more or less. We're almost broke, but our man Walter here» Francesco said, introducing him, «was just sharing his theory.»

«What theory?» asked Bla, curious.

«Well, I was saying that since they all need jobs and have good brains, they could start something together.»

Bla burst out laughing.

«Sorry, but what's so funny?» Teo asked.

«Just picturing the three of you behind a counter, or worse, running a bar. That's priceless.»

«And we thought you were our friend» said Sergio.

Bla glanced toward the counter to make sure there were no customers. «Alright, let's picture it together, shall we?»

They nodded.

«Perfect. Blues House is yours. You split the day into shifts, doesn't matter how for now, and we won't even get into who

handles the accountant, the banks, and all those loan-shark types. I'm the customer. I've just turned eighteen, give or take. Behind the counter there's...» He thought for a moment. «Yeah, Teo's behind the counter. I walk in and order a Blue Angel.»

«What a crappy cocktail. How can anyone drink that?»

«Exactly my point» Bla said, laughing. «Sergio would only serve computer geeks and 1980s video game freaks, and Francesco would never pour beer for a hipster.»

«Of course not. Watching the foam cling to their beards makes me sick.»

Bla laughed again.

«They're good people» he said to Walter. «They're my friends, and I love them. They pretend to be misfits, but they're actually snobs. More hipster than the tattooed ones in bow ties.»

«Good God, what the hell are you saying?» Francesco asked, mock-offended.

«Yeah, they're a little snobbish, aren't they?» Walter asked Fiamma.

«A little, yeah» she agreed.

«Come on, guys, it was fun while it lasted, but let's not push it» Sergio said.

«No one's joking» said Miranda. «It's true, you think you're above others.»

«Not others, just hipsters.»

«But everyone's a hipster now.»

«Careful, Sergio» said Teo, «the lawyer's trying to trap you in one of her dialectical mazes.»

«Well, it's not my fault if everyone's lost their minds. People get high on riding bikes, getting tattoos, wearing shorts, and keeping their sunglasses on twenty-four seven.»

«Oh, listen, I love making fun of them too, especially with you guys. You're sharp, politically incorrect, and my dearest friends, well, except you» she laughed, looking at her brother,

«you've been a pain in the ass since birth. But you can't deny being a little snobbish. You're the last people on Earth without a Facebook profile.»

«Facebook?!» shouted Teo.

«Facebook?!» echoed Sergio.

«What's that?»

«A place where they worship cats.»

«Guys, you're hopeless» said Bla, standing up as a couple of hipsters climbed onto the stools at the counter. «This round's on me, you look like you could use a serious drink.»

They kept going in the same vein, laughing, joking, mostly drinking, and occasionally pretending to be offended by each other's remarks. Two teams faced off at the Blues House tables: Miranda, Fiamma, and Walter on one side; Sergio, Teo, and Francesco on the other. No matter how sharp the banter, the boys' team struggled to argue coherently, especially after the second round.

Fiamma didn't mind watching Francesco slowly surrender to the effects of alcohol. In fact, she found it rather sweet, she couldn't remember ever having a moment like this with her son. Walter seemed to have redrawn their relationship from scratch. Not to mention the occasional barbs he and Miranda exchanged, revealing a mutual attraction that was becoming hard to ignore.

As the place filled up for the usual *aperi-dinner* Francesco paused to reflect on that semantic monstrosity that disgusted him, and yet not enough to stop him from indulging in it. His had always been simple aperitif, long ones maybe, but at least they bore no linguistic relation to that trendy phonetic incest. Yes, maybe Bla was right, he thought to himself, they really were a bit snobbish.

«Guys, I've got a problem» said Bla, serving their third round. «I need your help.»

«What kind of problem?» asked Fiamma, concerned, she knew all too well the kind of «problems» Bla often got into behind the bar, though thankfully not lately.

«Those four semi-vegetarian hipsters at the table just asked if my vegetables are zero-kilometer.»

Fiamma smiled, not sure she'd heard correctly.

«And what did you tell them?» asked Francesco.

«I told them, honestly, that they're not exactly zero-kilometer, but they do come from a small farmer up in the San Fruttuoso hills, and that from here, we're talking maybe four kilometers tops.»

«O...kay...» drawled Teo. «And what did they say?»

«Well, they were satisfied and ordered four Extraterrestrial Orgies.»

«Huh?» said Fiamma.

«They're salads, Mom» Teo explained. «He calls them that «cause there's a ton of green stuff in them.»

«I see» she smiled. «So, what's the problem?»

«They're keeping a close eye on me, right in their line of sight...»

«He can't tell them who the producer is» Teo cut in.

«I still don't get it.»

«You're really out of touch, Mom. Those people only eat organic. They think they're saving the planet by keeping their asses glued to barstools during happy hour. Bla can't exactly let them in on who his farmer' is.»

«Why not?»

«Because his name's Penny and his last name's Market, if you catch my drift.»

Fiamma burst out laughing.

«Okay» said Miranda, taking off her sweater, «I'll handle this.»

«Thanks» Bla said, tripping over his words as his eyes briefly betrayed him, «but I think one of the four might be gay.»

Fiamma glanced toward the table. «How can you tell?»

«God, Mom, look at their feet.»

«So?»

«Three of them are barefoot, standard uniform. The fourth's wearing the weirdest socks. See?»

«Yes, well, they're colorful.»

«Exactly.»

«You're right» said Miranda, putting her sweater back on. «Plan B. Go back to the bar, I'll be there in a sec.»

«You're a lifesaver, I don't know what I'd do without you.»

Bla went back behind the counter, blending in behind the beer tap. A few minutes later Miranda joined him. «Hey, did you see the guy who just passed by with the camera?» she asked, loud enough for the four hipsters to hear.

«No, why?» he said, fiddling with a pint.

«I'm almost sure it was Scott Schuman.»

«No way!» he exclaimed, having no idea who that was.

The four immediately perked up.

«Wow, I read he was supposed to come to Genoa, but he didn't say when on his blog...»

«Sorry» one of them asked, «when did you see him?»

«Just now. He turned onto Viale Pio VII. I'm not a hundred percent sure it was him, but he looked exactly like him, square jaw, great shape, dandy style, Canon EOS 5D in hand...»

Before she could finish, the four bolted out the door, and Bla swiftly poured two bags of supermarket salad into a terracotta bowl that looked suitably hipster-friendly.

«Did you see him?» he asked when the poor souls came back, tails between their legs.

«Maybe just a glimpse» one of them said, improvising. «He must've left in a Jaguar E-Type.»

Bla barely managed to keep a straight face, the only E-Type in the neighborhood, if they'd really seen one, was the one the mechanic next door had been restoring for years.

«Mission accomplished» said Fiamma as she returned to the table.

«What did you use?» her brother asked.

«Scott Schuman.»

«In Genoa?!»

«Well, it worked, didn't it?»

«Wow, Walter» said Fiamma, «is it the beer, or am I developing Alzheimer's? Because tonight, I honestly don't understand these kids at all.»

«Thank God» he reassured her. «They really do look more hipster than Nick Wooster. Although, undoubtedly...» He paused to take a sip of beer. «They dress way worse.»

«Nick who?! Oh, don't you start too!»

By the third round of drinks, the conversation had taken on a thin glaze of philosophical dementia and bargain-bin hipster critique. Fiamma, who knew almost nothing about this new invasive species, was having a blast discovering its habits and neuroses. She knew every era had always been defined by some dominant cultural trend, which inevitably spilled over into fashion. Of course, she'd lived through the most fertile one, she'd surfed the crest of that huge wave that really seemed like it could change the world, and that, unfortunately, against all predictions, crashed against the rocks and rolled back, leaving behind a pile of music, a few miniskirts, and, alas, the awareness of defeat.

That was why everything she'd seen since then she interpreted purely in stylistic terms. For a few years, some subcultures had still managed to preserve a distinct musical identity. But now, those bearded, mustached, thick-glassed, bow-tied boys were nothing but well-dressed marionettes,

whose only art form was to disguise the price of what they wore so it wouldn't show. The punks had been right, thought Fiamma: her generation had believed it could change the world, all the ones that followed knew perfectly well they never would.

«Are we snobs?» asked Francesco, wobbling slightly once they got home. «Do you really think we are?»

«I wouldn't say snobs» said Sergio. «Right now, I feel more like Superman.»

«Sure, you downed three Negronis, you'll be a cripple by morning.»

«Says the guy who drank three tomato juices with vodka.»

«They're called Bloody Marys.»

«Oh, I don't care. Still tomato juice. I feel sick just thinking about it.»

«Come on, guys, I'm serious. Do you think my mom's right?»

«I don't see the problem, Frank. Even if she is?»

«I don't know. Curiosity, I guess... I mean, I don't think I'd like to be thought of as a snob.»

«Why do you care what other people think? We're not like they see us, we're...»

«Drunk?!»

«Yeah, well... that's not what I meant. We're people aware of the world. Reasonably aware, at least.»

«Aware?» slurred Sergio. «More like misfits.»

«Misfits? That's a big word. Don't exaggerate.»

«Come on, Teo, let's face it. We're not kids anymore. We're smart, sure, but honestly, apart from studying, none of us has really accomplished much. We even have to live together just to make ends meet.»

«But it's fun, isn't it?»

«Yeah, of course it is. But don't you ever think maybe it's time to jump into the fray, get our hands dirty, and see what happens?»

«Hey, I did jump into the fray. Look what happened, I lost my job, my house and my girlfriend.»

«Yeah, but she was a nurse» they shouted almost in unison.

Francesco threw his arms to the sky, shaking his head. That theory still didn't satisfy him.

«Okay, jokes aside» he said, «what if Walter's right?»

«About being snobs, or about starting something together?»

«Well, both...»

«In Italian, please.»

«All right, let's be honest: we feel superior to this epidemic that's spread from TriBeCa to the whole world. We've studied it, dissected it, tried to isolate the pathogen. But working so closely with it, we can't help having been infected ourselves...»

«Wait, Frank, are you coming out of the closet?»

«Are you saying you're gonna grow a beard?»

«You're both idiots, you know that? What I'm saying is, we've metabolized the virus somehow. We're experts on the subject, we know its origins, its symptoms, its course...»

«Hey, what the hell are you talking about, Willis? I'm a physicist, he's a philosopher.»

«Yeah, but beyond that, we're also experts on the habits and customs of the enemy. We've mocked them and avoided them for so long that we're basically honorary graduates in hipster semiotics and ethnology. We're modern anthropologists, that's what we are. Don't you think?»

«What exactly do they put in a Bloody Mary?» Teo asked his friend.

«Vodka, vodka, and tomato juice. An absurd amount of vodka, judging by what I'm hearing.»

They laughed.

«You really don't get it, do you?» Francesco went on, kicking off his shoes and stretching out on the couch. «How great would it be if we pulled the ultimate trick, blending into the herd just to pluck them clean?»

«Only vodka, are we sure?»

«Yes, I'd say so, if you want I'll check on Wikipedia.»

«Christ, guys, come on, I'm not kidding.»

«Yes, we get it, that's what scares us.»

«What we haven't understood is where the hell you're going with this.»

«A shop.»

«A shop?» Teo asked.

«A shop» Sergio emphasized.

«But not just...»

«Ah, I see.»

«A workshop, a reference point, an icon. Think what Harry's Bar was for Hemingway, the Factory for Pop Art, the Dragun Pub for the existentialists of Camogli in the last century. If we put our minds to it we could really open something grand, an appealing space, hipster but not too much, with cultured crossovers more or less hidden, to lure even the hardest core. It would be an undercover mission, of course: we'd have to infiltrate, speak their language, laugh at their jokes, sure, but by doing so we'd open a path to their bank accounts. We could get back on our feet, have fun, be our own bosses, and derive great satisfaction.»

«What kind of satisfaction, exactly?»

«I mean, don't I alone get the big-picture vision when I drink? You two just don't see it.»

Sergio and Teo looked at each other skeptically.

«Okay.» He got up with great effort from the sofa and fetched a rectangular block of wood, found who-knows-where,

which they used in summer to prop the living-room door so it wouldn't slam. «What's this?» he asked.

The two looked even more puzzled.

«A piece of wood?» Teo asked in turn.

«Hold on» Sergio shouted, «are you quoting Twin Peaks?»

Francesco spread his arms, ran to the kitchen and came back with a glass. He placed the wide end of the glass on the largest face of the wooden block and traced the circle with a pencil. Then he stood the block upright on the coffee table and drew a rectangle about six by one centimeters near the top.

«You still don't get it?»

«Have you drunk your brain tonight?»

«You really don't see it, huh?» he smiled. «If we make a hole here with a hole saw» he indicated the circle traced by the glass, «and dig from here» he pointed to the small rectangle, «until we reach the hole, what do we get?»

Sergio and Teo, baffled, preferred not to comment. They had never seen him like this, and it wasn't the first long aperitif or *aperi-dinner* they'd shared. They were starting to worry.

Francesco put his hand in his pocket, took his phone and stood it up, slightly angled, on top of the block of wood aligned with that little rectangle, and waited a few seconds in that position. The others waited too, wondering if they should call a neurologist or just let the Bloody Marys wear off.

«A fucking natural amplifier, biological, ecological, eco-friendly and perfectly in the hipster style. Fifty or sixty euros at least, branded and sold in appropriately cool packaging. Production cost, with the right tools, half an hour of sweat at most.»

«For God's sake» Teo blurted, relieved he didn't have to strap his friend to the bed, «where did that come from, it's...»

«Brilliant» Sergio continued, «but you know they'd actually buy such a piece of crap.»

«Of course I know, that's what I've been trying to explain.»

«Wow» Teo went on, now on the same wavelength, «we could really make them in every size and height, from a desk model to a free-standing one in fine wood.»

«Two-hundred euros and up easy, with a brushed-steel base» even Sergio chimed in.

«It makes a great contrast with dark wood. But not only that...»

«Go on» they said in unison.

«We could create demand before we even sell them.»

«And how?»

«Websites, articles, fake news piled on fake. We know how to position ourselves on search engines, put in the right tags, we can make every hipster in the city drool for one before we've even produced them. We can build a brand, register the trademark, create sites overseas and make everyone think it's a must-have that's still unknown here. Join Facebook, obviously, exploit every channel at our disposal. That's what they used to pay me for till recently.»

«Yes, but we can't open a shop selling only pieces of perforated wood» Teo said.

«Well, we can sell anything, really.»

Sergio ran to his room and came back with a clear pack of Bic pens. He emptied the pens from the box, went to the kitchen and shoved a few carrots into it.

«With an eye-catching label and a little dirt rubbed on them first, we could, like Bla, peddle Penny Market carrots as zero-kilometre organic veg.»

«Exactly» Francesco shouted, «packaging is everything, not the contents.»

«Yes, but that's fraud, come on.»

«No way, Teo, this isn't fraud. This is war, we just have to decide whether to fight it or not.»

«Okay, but we could get in trouble for something like that.»

«Trouble? We're already in trouble, what's wrong with providing the product the customers want? We have the skills, the ideas, the know-how and even legal assistance. Miranda could advise us step by step. Think about it, I even know where to open it: two vacant shops on *Via Sturla* would be perfect, between the bike shop and the science high school, a den of hipsters with fat wallets. It's only the capital we lack, actually, soon we won't even have rent money, let alone funds to open a shop.»

«We would need a license, so to speak, a flexible one. I don't think you can sell vegetables and clothing together, for example.»

«With all due respect, at this point I don't care much about what you can and can't do. After all, it's the State itself that has declared war on the poor, that has declared war on us. It's time to return fire. I mean, it would be time, if we had the money for the ammunition.»

«Right» the two nodded.

They stayed a while longer in the living room, flopped on the sofas without speaking, each trying in his own way to figure out what they could sell in a shop like that, how they could lighten the wallets of those healthy carriers of unkempt beards and cash and, most importantly, how they could blend in among them. Francesco seemed so hyped that night he would have gotten tattooed from head to toe if it would have helped. Softened by alcohol that refused to evaporate, they realized endless possibilities. Without resorting to scamming customers with vegetables, they found dozens and dozens of ideas for that hypothetical business: T-shirts, gadgets, lamps made from recycled materials, even organic cosmetics. Only with the contents of the boxes still piled in the hallway they could have furnished the place. Inside there must still be absolutely vintage

computers and consoles that most hipsters would drool over. From an original IBM 8086, now useful only to run the original Tetris, to an Atari 2600 with a few cartridges left. Not to mention an old Macintosh SE, a couple of first-edition PlayStations and a BBC Model B that Teo still sometimes used to play Elite. With all those gadgets and Walter's T-shirts, if he lent them for display, they could furnish the paradise of the older hipster crowd: those who, unwillingly or not, could no longer hide at least their age, if not their old nerdish nature. For the younger ones, immune to the vintage charm of certain curiosities or even theoretically hostile to technology, they could set up a more cultural space, made of bookshelves reclaimed from the trash or, better still, made to look reclaimed, full of ethical, ecological, organic, organoleptic, vegan publications and strictly in English. With some obvious exceptions for a few bestsellers dear both to early nerds and hardcore hipsters, such as *The Hitchhiker's Guide to the Galaxy*, *Ready Player One*, *Fool on the Hill* and *Still Life with Woodpecker*. Of course, always in the original language.

Letting their imagination run, Teo, the one most into male grooming, also imagined a proper area for caring for and maintaining the hipster symbol par excellence, the beard, and for body care in general. Because hipsters, it had to be said, would never mark their era like the punks did, for example, but you couldn't say they weren't clean. Expensive Marseille soaps, vegetable sponges, renowned essences as natural as they were obscure, UNESCO-certified toothpastes, Linetti hair tonic and hair nets. Hipsters went wild for anything that used to give ordinary people the shivers.

Sergio, since dreaming cost nothing, flew even higher: he imagined resuming composition of some lo-fi electronic tracks, the category's favorite standard, attributed to non-existent niche artists who, according to websites Francesco could create ad

hoc, were already cult overseas. If they wanted, they could even produce records in vinyl, the non plus ultra for purists. All they needed was a 3D printer or, better yet, a simple Vinylrecorder T-560, like the one he'd already fiddled with in the old recording studio: a toy costing a couple of thousand euros they could amortize in five or six months at most.

Under the influence of wine they became fertile in ideas and intuitions, more or less feasible and certainly interesting for the target audience: for instance, boycotting shop background music in favor of snippets of film dialogue in the original language borrowed from Woody Allen, John Landis, the Monty Python, Wes Anderson and the Coen brothers. They could also offer hardware, software help and small peripherals for all Apple devices, especially the older ones, for which emotional value and vintage charm justified the ridiculous sums asked for repairs or upgrades, and offer every customer, paying or not, a good glass of wine and some snacks. An investment laughably small compared to the benefits it would bring. Francesco even had the name clear in mind for the place, a name that said it all: ironic but not obvious, cultured in its reference and catchy in its literal meaning: Radical Choc. Hipsters all over Genoa would queue to photograph themselves inside holding a glass of red: a little mist from the Barolo region, at its fourteen-and-a-half degrees, would hand out beatings like a skinhead at the stadium, exponentially increasing purchase propensity. And if Miranda happened to agree to help behind the counter sometimes, well, in a couple of months they could open branches around the world. Teo was already imagining the thick cardboard bags with a deliberately recycled look and hemp handles that quite a few would smoke:

Radical Choc

Genova – New York – Miami - Chicago – Mosca

It finally seemed that all roads had stopped leading to Rome and were now converging toward a future as rosy as a baby's bottom, as rich as Mr. Heisenberg's warehouse, and as ethereal, alas, as the hangover that would sooner or later evaporate, restoring to reality its sharp edges. Unfortunately, unless they managed to cobble together a time machine overnight to go back to 2001 and buy a few kilos of Apple stock, they'd better call it a night with a good Aspirin to ease the morning after. Though, for Francesco, after three Bloody Marys, an Imodium might have been more appropriate.

He'd never consumed that much tomato without a single strand of spaghetti.

Francesco opened his eyes past noon. The sun was already high, cutting through the slats of the half-closed blinds, casting parallel streaks of light and shadow from floor to ceiling. It was even hot, too hot for mid-October. The climate was changing, just like everything else. The planet itself seemed to show the first signs of fatigue. After all, at over four and a half billion years old, it had earned the right to be tired. So was he, though barely past thirty-oddly tired for someone who had just woken up, but he blamed the vodka.

What bothered him most about hangovers was the blank slate they left in place of dreams. He dreamed every night, like everyone else, and usually remembered a good portion of his nocturnal repertoire, but after a triple round of cocktails or a few glasses of wine, it became impossible to retain anything. All that remained was the feeling of having thrown away an entire night. He liked to imagine sleep as one of those parallel dimensions Teo and his colleagues tried to prove with absurd mathematical formulas: a world unto itself, where time and the common laws of physics meant nothing, but instinct, desire, and will could reshape the universe at will. Exactly the opposite of what waking life allowed, a kind of decompression chamber from the real world. No wonder, he thought, that sleep deprivation led to all sorts of pathologies, even madness.

All those dreams of entrepreneurial glory, with the dawn of a new day, no longer seemed so appealing. After all, if a bit of imagination were enough to make a decent living, the world would look quite different.

In the shower, the image of the chili plant on the Portofino promontory came back to him, what he'd always considered the perfect patch of land to free *Apocalypse Now* from its pot, and how little attention his friends had paid to such a singularity. Teo usually never missed a chance to theorize about strange events, breaking them down into particles, strings, photons, and other such ingredients. Of course, there probably wasn't much to theorize about in a chili plant, not even for someone who claimed, without a shadow of doubt, that all advanced civilizations were doomed to extinction within a couple of millennia. Otherwise, he often said, citing some theory or other, it was impossible that we'd never had any alien contact. A theory Francesco had never liked. There was nothing particularly cool about believing, with absolute certainty, that we were alone, not just in the world, which one could get used to, willingly or not, but in the entire universe.

Still, when his mother's face lit up on his phone screen at lunchtime, glowing like a psychedelic holy card, for a moment he almost envied that total solitude.

«Hello?»

«Hi, Frank, how are you feeling? Recovered?»

«Of course I have, what did you think, that I can't handle a couple of drinks?»

«Oh, don't crucify me, I wasn't talking about the vodka! You should've seen how much I drank at your age. It was the tomato juice that worried me» she laughed.

«Well, I survived that too, luckily. Can't say the same for the others though, I haven't seen them yet.»

«They went out for Negronis. The Bla leaves them pale as sheets. I doubt you'll see them before mid-afternoon. Listen, Walter and I were thinking, Tom Waits is playing in Rome in a couple of weeks. Would you and your friends like to come with us? You'd be our guests, of course. Walter's got an old

Volkswagen minibus, we could be away for three, maybe four days tops. A friend's lending us his place for a couple of nights, it could be our personal Woodstock.»

«Oh my god, Mom, Tom Waits, Rome, what, did Walter win the lottery?»

«I wish! We wanted to tell you yesterday, but we weren't sure Walter would get the tickets, they've been sold out for months. But he just got confirmation. An acquaintance of his works at the Sistina, and you know how it is... They're great seats too, not an opportunity to miss! It's been ages since we've done something like that. I used to take you to concerts when you were little, but then at some point...»

«I know, Mom. I stopped going.»

«Come on, Frank, just this once. Do it for me, as a birthday present.»

«Mom, your birthday's in December.»

«Of course, like all the greats. Waits, Hendrix, Zappa... So, can I count on you?»

«I don't know, not just like that, off the cuff.»

«Frank, you'll have to stop overthinking everything sooner or later. Sometimes you just have to jump. And really, I'm asking you for a favor. It's been years, decades, since I've felt this good, and I want to spend a few days with my son and the people I love. You know your friends will have a blast, they're a riot.»

«Yeah, I know. I'm the boring one.»

«That's not what I said, and you know it. Listen, I need an answer to lock down the tickets, tomorrow, the day after at the latest. Will you let me know?»

«Sure, Mom. I'll see what the others say and call you.»

«Perfect, thanks...»

Fiamma knew his friends would jump at the chance, he was always the hesitant one. Though this time he had no doubts.

He'd have sold his soul to spend three days near Miranda. Keeping his mother on edge was just an old habit he now, in light of this new and strange relationship looming on the horizon, felt slightly ashamed of.

He lingered in the bathroom, even giving himself an unscheduled midweek shave, just to prove, to himself and to his mother, that he wasn't only not boring, but downright unpredictable.

«Jesus Christ, Frank» said Sergio, stepping into the kitchen, drawn by the smell of coffee. «Who died?»

«Died?!» he echoed.

«You shaved. And it's not Saturday.»

Right, he thought.

«Fiamma called.»

«We heard» said Teo, shuffling in wearing pajamas. «Your ringtone makes more noise than a selector at a rave.»

«Selector? Damn, what do we owe this semantic demonstration to?» asked Francesco.

«If you play gabba tracks at a rave party, I'm sorry, but I'm not calling you a DJ.»

They laughed.

«So, who died?» asked Teo. «And, more importantly, do we need to shave too?»

«No, definitely not.» The two sighed in relief. «My mom just invited us to go to Rome with her and Walter, in a hippie van, to a Tom Waits concert. All expenses paid for three, maybe four, days.»

«I love that MILF» said Teo.

«Beautifully put» added Sergio.

«So, should I confirm?»

«What kind of question is that? Tom Waits, Rome, no money... what more could we want?»

«Well, it's not a bad offer. Maybe I was expecting a compliment or two from you guys.»

«Why?» asked Sergio.

«I don't know, I just wouldn't feel that comfortable if your dad invited me to»

«Neither would I, for that matter. But Fiamma is Fiamma. That woman's a force of nature, and if she invited us, it means she wants us there. We want it, she wants it...»

«Is there anything else we need to explain to you?» Teo concluded.

They were right.

«We need to check with Miranda before confirming. She's the only one with a job, it might not be that simple.»

«Obviously. We didn't expect you to abandon Genoa for a few days without her.»

«What the hell are you talking about, Willis? I was in Camogli a few days ago. Alone.»

They laughed.

«Luckily» Sergio said, phone in hand, «though we still lack time machines, teleporters, and all those great gadgets TV got us used to, we live in the age of compulsive messaging. Exact dates, please.»

«October thirtieth to November second. The concert's on Halloween night.»

«Halloween, the dead... great omen. Remember what a mess you got into last Friday the thirteenth.»

He typed:

*Oct 30 – Nov 2, roughly. Rome. VW van. House. Tom Waits and hipster hunt. No money @ all (Fiamma & Walter).
Maximum hygiene. Time wasters keep out.*

«Come on, what's she supposed to make of that? At least ask if she can go, if she needs time off.»

«They're siblings, man» said Teo.

Ten seconds later Sergio's phone buzzed:

I love that woman.

Only that evening, after making sure Miranda was free, did Francesco give his mother the go-ahead. He couldn't remember seeing her that happy since that time, at a Bruce Springsteen concert, when she'd managed to get pulled up on stage by the Boss himself, leaving him in the care of a security giant who held him by the barriers. He wasn't even ten yet, but at that moment he started to understand life would be tough. By the end of the show, he was sure of it.

The Boss had played for something like four straight hours.

Although Francesco had never been particularly fond of any specific means of transportation, when Walter pulled an old Volkswagen minibus out of the garage, older than he was, he shivered. His instinct would have been to conceal any hint of emotion in front of his mother. Showing admiration or wonder at one of the greatest hippie symbols, until just a few months earlier, would have exposed him too much. It would have been like admitting that he understood, at least in part, an ideal Fiamma had never turned her back on.

His mother, unlike so-called ordinary people, had always lived freely, thought freely, and, of course, made mistakes even more freely, without restraint or inhibition of any kind, for better or worse.

But that day, seeing her squeezed into a pair of jeans that seemed to strangle her thighs before flaring out at the ankles, in a tight black T-shirt with the Rolling Stones' tongue on the front and the tour dates of the '80s Emotional Rescue tour on the back, as she caressed the side of that two-toned beauty, slowly, as if her fingertips could reconnect her with the twenty-year-old she once was, his eyes grew moist.

Walter was helping the others load the bags, telling small anecdotes about that glorious vehicle. Francesco heard him mention time, how it had a knack for reshuffling the deck as it passed. That van had once been a symbol of freedom, carrying a very clear meaning, whereas now it was just an investment, something to keep safe behind a garage door and show only to other enthusiasts: respected professionals, lawyers, architects, interior designers, and, of course, endless hipsters. People who

had no problem spending almost thirty thousand euros on a vehicle they'd hardly ever use on the road, and certainly not at more than a hundred kilometers an hour.

Once all the backpacks were crammed inside, Fiamma disappeared for a moment and came back with a small bunch of daisies, which she placed in a special holder wedged into the dashboard.

Only then did Francesco remember that habit of hers. Fiamma never left for a trip, long or short, without a bunch of flowers. She had always done it, but for some reason he seemed to have completely forgotten. Strange, he thought, considering how, as a kid, he used to spend all his time playing with those dashboard bouquets, even torturing them, in the classic preadolescent attempt at divination. How could he have forgotten something like that? he wondered. But the question went unanswered.

The engine coughed, hoarse and noisy, drowning out Francesco's doubts about that sudden blank space in his memory. But before shifting into first gear with the van's anachronistic, spindly gear lever, Walter turned to them:

«This won't be just a trip. Soon you'll understand women better too.»

Fiamma nodded from the front seat without even turning around. The three of them looked at each other, trying to figure out if anyone had caught the meaning of that remark, and before they could ask Miranda, the scenery outside the windows began to move.

«Are we sure this thing can even make it to Rome?» Teo asked.

«Don't worry. This baby's never let me down. She burned though Lebanon, Morocco, Pakistan, even India and Nepal.»

The three in the back burst out laughing.

«Did I say something wrong?» he asked Fiamma under his breath, smiling.

«You can't use the verb *burn*' with countries like that's, come on.»

Walter nodded, relaxed, as if nothing had happened. Anyone else might have felt a twinge of embarrassment at such an innocent slip, but not him. He didn't care in the least, in fact, he seemed pleased to have sparked a bit of laughter.

They hadn't even reached the highway when Francesco began to grasp the meaning of Walter's comment about understanding women. The attention of passersby, across almost the entire species, was focused entirely on them. Everyone admired that German masterpiece in its perfect, lovingly preserved condition. Everyone wanted to own it, drive it, take it for a spin. Especially those who quickly looked away, resisting curiosity just to avoid giving satisfaction to the man behind the wheel. Francesco already felt uneasy being, even indirectly, the focus of all that attention.

At least the curiosity of the onlookers was mechanical, ideological, historical, or purely aesthetic, not sexual. Women weren't so lucky, he thought with a shiver, ashamed of all the times he had zoned out daydreaming about some stranger's gaze.

Even on the highway, all eyes were still on them, though mostly because of the line of cars the van caused on steeper climbs. Fortunately, drivers knew full well that a vehicle like that couldn't do better, and those who lingered before overtaking did so only to fully admire its beauty. They weren't used to chrome trims, curved lines, rounded details, the total lack of accessories, the simplicity of hubcaps or those little sun-curtain windows. That van embodied all the best feminine qualities of the past, the kind no one was used to appreciating

anymore, the kind that left you speechless when you were lucky enough to encounter them.

What amazed Teo, instead, was the complete absence of a stereo system. When he asked why, especially coming from a guy like him, Walter simply replied, without any trace of rhetoric or snobbery, that the vehicle was approved for seven passengers, and he had always thought that so many friends together would rather talk to each other than listen to music.

They'd do that too, of course, that was one of the reasons for the trip, though perhaps not the main one. Everyone had already figured that out, everyone except Francesco. The real reason, Walter's gift to Fiamma, was to give her a chance to spend some time with her son, as she hadn't done in far too long. And if everything went the way Fiamma hoped, if it all flowed smoothly, maybe she'd even get to enjoy the big final surprise, the one only Miranda had guessed, and hadn't told a soul about.

The trip was long, and there was plenty of time to talk, tease each other, sing, and even get bored. Every now and then, Francesco gazed out the window at the slow-moving scenery, watching the coastline and beaches he knew so well fade into the distance. He was surprised, checking his phone, at how far they had traveled in such a short time. He didn't mean in actual kilometers, any modern car could have done twice the distance in half the time, but in a more conceptual sense.

In less than half an hour they had reached Chiavari, the same amount of time he'd usually spend after coffee checking his emails and deleting spam. In just over an hour they had left Liguria behind, and so on. By the time they finally reached Rome, he realized that back home he wouldn't have accomplished much anyway, maybe just decided where to go for an aperitif. And while the Bla bar couldn't possibly be missing him yet, he was already far away, lost in time and space, at the gates of the capital, with a dry throat from impromptu karaoke,

sore buttocks from those far-from-ergonomic seats, a dull headache from fatigue, vibration, and engine noise, but with the clear feeling of being truly far from home.

Fiamma loosened up too, and during the trip, careful not to go into too much detail, she talked about the concerts she'd been to, or at least the ones she could still remember. She explained why certain musicians meant so much more to her than others and even tried to make that old ideal of peace and love intelligible to the younger generation – the one Kurt Cobain had added empathy to – borrowed and shared from across the ocean, but which she had never imagined would fade so quickly. She was a dreamer, had always been one - her son knew that all too well – and she believed that somewhere, under the ashes of that cultural explosion that had quickly turned into something else, there must still be a glowing ember worth blowing on. It was probably too hard a job for one person, especially for a mother.

Walter talked a little about his past, about the old days, about music in general, but only when prompted. He didn't seem interested in recounting his adventures like most of his peers, those convinced their anecdotes still held some great lesson for the younger generation and who, at every chance, burned to recite the latest installment of their personal autobiography. Walter was the complete opposite of that kind of man. Maybe that was one of the reasons Francesco liked him so much.

Teo had everyone in stitches with his usual theories, quantum physics, treated with the right amount of irony, lent itself to hilarious paradoxes. Fiamma understood very little of his jokes, but sitting next to her son, hearing him laugh and banter in their peculiar language, filled her heart with joy. Every so often Miranda would lean forward from the third row of seats to rest a hand on Fiamma's shoulder, and Fiamma, without turning, so no one would see her teary eyes, would stroke her hand in return.

For all their differences, they understood each other perfectly. They were women, after all.

They reached Rome in the late afternoon, unloaded the bags, and parked the van in a guarded garage near the apartment, a spacious three-room flat with plenty of beds but a tiny kitchenette. Luckily, in Trastevere, there was no chance they'd be doing any cooking.

The sun was setting when Francesco, waiting for his turn in the bathroom, looked out the window at the shapeless crowd of hipsters sitting at café tables below. For a brief moment, he had hoped that the capital had already metabolized and moved past that ridiculous, senseless trend, but once his feet touched Roman ground, one of those manhole covers still stamped *SPQR* by the city administration, he realized how naïve that hope was. The invasion was nearly total. Maybe Ethiopia, parts of Africa, or the most remote corners of Vietnam, those mud-and-tin shack settlements near the Chinese border, were still spared from such colonization, but everywhere else, the world was the same. Hipsters were everywhere, and the Roman ones, he had to admit, wore an arrogance even greater than those back home. Still, from the little he overheard of their conversations, they at least seemed to have a sense of humor, something utterly missing from that strip of land he'd just left behind.

«Holy hell, where's all this going to end?» he asked rhetorically.

«The future» Miranda said, joining him at the window, «isn't what it used to be.»

Francesco smiled, then noticed a strange-looking man sitting alone at one of the tables below, staring in his direction from behind a pair of oversized '70s Ray-Bans, the kind with yellow, almost transparent lenses. He was wearing a worn but finely tailored light-brown coat with a burgundy velvet collar, the kind English lords used to wear during fox hunts. His hair was long

and white, tied back in a ponytail, not thinning at all, which surprised Francesco for someone his age. He must have been past sixty, maybe more, it was hard to tell from that distance, but even up close, Francesco doubted he'd have been able to guess. There was something about that man's gaze that gave him chills, a sort of animal magnetism that kept him from calling Miranda's attention, her eyes were scanning a wider horizon anyway.

He wished he had binoculars, a telescope, even a simple camera with a bit of zoom to get a better look at those blurred, distant features that, for some absurd reason, were giving him goosebumps. But before he could act, the stranger stood up, stayed still for a few seconds, staring at him with a strange, almost painful smile, and then vanished into the crowd.

«Hey, did you zone out?» asked Miranda.

«A bit, yeah, there was this weird guy down there, an old man, with a strange coat. Didn't you see him?»

«No way, I was watching the sunset, not the hipsters.»

«He wasn't a hipster» he said, surprised by his own words, «he was... original.»

«Original?!»

«Yeah, I don't know... a quirky old man, wearing glasses like Johnny Depp's in Fear and Loathing in Las Vegas and some kind of coat with a velvet collar, or something like that.»

«Well» Miranda said with a smile, «sounds pretty hipster to me.»

«Yeah, maybe you're right» he said, avoiding further comment.

They stayed by the window for a few minutes, lost in thought. Francesco wished he could focus better on that strange sensation, understand its cause, while Miranda wondered if she should have prepared him for what would probably happen over

the next few days. She knew she shouldn't get involved, and in the end, decided not to, but it wasn't easy.

They managed to head out past nine, wandered a bit around the neighborhood, then slipped into a small restaurant where, luckily, there wasn't a trace of flannel shirts, beards, tattoos, or any of that nonsense. Even in the capital, hipsters preferred open-air spots or bars with wide glass fronts. They dressed that way because they were dying to be admired, to be considered original (quite the contradiction in terms), or stylish – another of those absurd semantic atrocities they'd spawned – and they certainly wouldn't want to hide in a dimly lit place overflowing with bunches of fresh garlic and strings of red chili peppers hanging everywhere, from the ceiling almost to the floor.

They had an absolutely stellar dinner: *tonnarelli cacio e pepe*, *amatriciana*, spaghetti with clams, *carciofi alla giudia* and *saltimbocca alla romana*. All washed down with a couple of flasks of red from *Castelli Romani*, a thirteen-and-a-half-degree bullet that helped everyone momentarily subdue their fatigue, only to present the bill come digestif time.

Fiamma and Walter had already been to Rome many times. All the great concerts, they'd seen there, and they'd roamed the city far and wide. But for Francesco, Sergio, and Teo it was the first time, so they decided to play tourists. Miranda, too, had been there three or four times already and would have gladly slept till noon, but preferred joining the group rather than invading the privacy of the couple they were meeting in the center for a couple of pre-concert drinks.

Reluctantly, she improvised as a tour guide, leading her friends to the Trevi Fountain, the Spanish Steps, Piazza Navona, Campo de' Fiori, the Colosseum of course, and even Porta Portese, where they stopped to eat in a typical little restaurant slightly off the tourist track. There, as Francesco sought relief from the pepper burning his palate with a sip of wine, he suddenly felt he was being watched. Before turning around to see who the hell could be staring holes into his back, he tried to catch a reflection in the restaurant window, just like he'd seen in hundreds of spy movies, and his blood ran cold at the thought he'd just glimpsed behind him the same old man from the night before. But it lasted only a second, a fleeting impression maybe, because when he turned around, sharply, there was nothing strange to focus on, not even a single hipster. No one seemed interested in him, no one except his friends and the waiter who occasionally checked if everything was to their liking.

They reached aperitif hour still a bit tipsy. Fiamma was radiant and fragrant, while Walter, freshly shaved and smiling, looked like an overgrown kid. If not for the gray hair, he could've passed for twenty years younger. He'd already seen

Tom Waits, four or five times, he couldn't even remember, and it was clear he was buzzing with excitement.

«That man's not human» he said, «he's a higher being sent to Earth to enlighten us mere mortals.»

Teo almost burst out laughing but held it in out of respect.

«Concerts like that» Walter went on, «they change your life.»

«Good God, so yours has changed, what, four or five times already?»

«Luckily» Walter smiled at Fiamma, «my life keeps changing all the time.»

The message was clear: the man could've twisted the knife, but he hadn't. He'd simply pointed to the wound, as if to remind him not to forget it. Francesco wanted to turn toward Miranda right then, to finally make plain what everyone already knew, to risk, to expose himself, but he couldn't. His embarrassment, red as a summer sunset, was, as usual, carefully ignored.

«Didn't we say something about a couple of aperitifs?» Sergio came to his rescue.

«Absolutely.»

They found a bar not far from the theater and ordered drinks, doing their best to avoid the buffet swarmed by hipsters buzzing like manic bees. Rome was certainly no TriBeCa, let alone New York, but the dress code still seemed pushed to the extreme, and when Sergio spotted some absurd character completely tattooed, with beard and mustache, a plaid shirt, bow tie, and a tartan jacket worn under denim overalls, he nearly choked on an olive.

«My God» said Fiamma, after making sure he could breathe again, «I'm starting to see why you're all so sarcastic.»

They laughed.

«Come on, though» Walter said, «they're not all ridiculous, that old guy in the covert coat is actually super chic.»

«Covert coat?» asked Francesco.

«Yeah, the English horseman's coat.»

Francesco shuddered, turned around, but saw no one wearing anything like that.

«Where?»

«Behind you» Walter said, pointing over his shoulder after setting down his glass, «I mean, he was right there a second ago.»

Francesco searched for a while among the crowd at the counter, without success, then turned to his glass, hoping not to get paranoid. Fiamma steered the conversation away from hipsters and toward the future, trying to find out whether her son and his friends had finally come up with some idea about what to do next. They admitted they had something in the works but didn't go into details. They didn't mention the shop, which wasn't really an idea yet anyway, and only said they had too many options and too little capital to make any of them real. Walter said money wouldn't be a problem, they were smart, and they'd come up with something. In his opinion, great ideas weren't even that necessary, what mattered were great imaginations. Then he mentioned some American guy who had run a Kickstarter campaign to make a potato salad and ended up raising something like sixty thousand dollars.

«In these cases, the whole world's the same» said Sergio, who knew about the story, «potatoes always sell.»

They laughed, knowing full well that a stunt like that would never work in Italy. Their fellow citizens were unlikely to invest a single euro just for the fun of it, just to be able to say they did and leave a funny comment on the project's page. In that sense, America really was on the other side of the moon. For Teo, it would have been easier to build a time machine and go back to play the stock market, or the lottery.

«Okay» said Walter, amused, «but traveling back and forth, assuming it's even possible, wouldn't that mess with the space-time continuum?»

«You mean, like if I existed in two places at once or, worse, ran into myself on the same timeline?»

«Yeah, something like that.»

«There are no definite answers to that kind of question. There are several schools of thought. Some believe the universe, as we know it, would implode. Others think it might create a temporal fracture. Others still say it could split into multiple timelines, while some believe time behaves like a liquid, instantly filling in any cracks caused by a stunt like that.»

«In short, nobody knows a damn thing?»

Teo thought about it for a few seconds.

«Exactly» he said, softened by the beer, «even though the greatest physicists have been fighting over it for years, it's hard to draw any tangible, verifiable conclusion. You know, if you go too fast, the whole thing collapses.»

«Come again?»

«The speed of light.»

«Oh right, if you go too fast, you stop aging.»

«More or less.»

«Like Keith Richards» said Fiamma with a smile.

«Well, he has aged, and not too well, aesthetically speaking. But I get what you mean.»

«I think he's a beautiful man.»

«There you go» said Sergio, «that's relativity.»

They laughed.

After a couple of beers, they got up to head into the theater, resisting the urge to comment, at the box office, on a pair of hipsters asking about the ingredients in the buffet. The planet was falling apart, there was a popular uprising in Egypt, war against the Tuareg and Islamic militias in Mali, civil war in South Sudan, fighting against Islamic militants in Nigeria, Somalia, the Philippines, Afghanistan, Iraq, Yemen, and Chechnya, secession in Ukraine, the usual massacre in Gaza,

and civil war in Syria, to name a few, but they seemed worried only about where the salad came from. As if an organic diet and a regular bowel movement could cure all ills. Then again, the humanitarian caravan they were joining was headed to the Teatro Sistina for a Tom Waits concert, not a conflict zone. Their only redeeming quality, if they had one, wasn't even being omnivores, just slightly less suffocating toward the waitstaff.

The concert was magnificent. Francesco knew the man's caliber, but not how far he could push that voice. He walked on stage dressed in black, wearing the bowler hat that had replaced his old Stetson, alone, under a storm of applause, before the band even came out. He stepped onto a small round platform at center stage, where the techs had arranged all his paraphernalia, a chair, and the microphone, of course. He waited for the applause to fade and, in the meantime, calmly lit a cigarette, drawing a long puff as a single spotlight followed him, probably operated by the same friend of Walter's who had gotten them the tickets. Then, when the crowd finally quieted, with that unique voice of his, hoarse, vibrating, full of pain, he announced the musicians one by one as they emerged from the wings and took their places, bowing briefly to the audience. Francesco loved that gesture, that way of presenting himself not as a rock star but as a true professional who, after forty years of honorable service, could afford to drop the usual pretensions and take care of his band. The fact that, if he'd wanted, he could have done without musicians altogether only made that simple act more powerful.

With that voice, he could have transcended the piano, the marimba, the guitar, the accordion, any drumbeat. Had he gone on stage armed only with that pack of unfiltered darks, telling his stories while moving like live wire in a cloud of his own smoke, gripping the microphone stand as if it were charged with electricity, well, no one would have moved from their seat. And

if, by some spell, he could have sung until the end of time, no one would have moved then, either. They'd have all died right there, in those dark velvet seats, one by one, to the sound of *Cold, Cold Ground*, the soundtrack of every respectable drunken homecoming. And when they finally descended into hell, they wouldn't have been surprised to find him there, wearing the same rumpled suit, the same worn-out shoes, the same bowler hat, but sitting on the throne of the king of the underworld. And it would have finally been clear to everyone that a voice like that could only belong to the devil himself. Walter had been right all along: he was a higher being, sent to enlighten mere mortals, those poor fools still convinced that somewhere below, human souls were roasting for skipping mass, spilling their seed, or other such nonsense.

While down there, in those caverns warmed by magma and hazy with the dark smoke of millions upon millions of unfiltered cigarettes, all they ever did was play great jazz and make love all together. Everyone, without distinctions. The underworld was an achievement, not a punishment.

After almost a couple of hours, when the lights came up, extinguishing the audience's hope for a third encore, Francesco awoke to the real world, finally understanding why his mother, despite her age, kept chasing in every rock concert, even in those barely deserving the name, that moment of perfection he had just experienced. Two hours of absolute, complete detachment from what would soon go back to being his problems, big or small. If everyone on the planet could stop for a while and witness something like that, maybe they'd no longer feel the urge to kill each other, he thought for a moment, until, on his way to the restroom, once again fully grounded on planet Earth, he realized that, no matter how great and talented, Tom Waits could hardly be the answer to mankind's utter stupidity. Even though trying wouldn't hurt anyone.

Francesco was washing his hands when, with a shiver, he saw reflected in the large mirror before him that strange man in the rider's coat and yellow-lensed glasses. The initial shock made him grab the edge of the sink, then, seeing the man enter one of the stalls, he calmed down and lingered before the mirror, wondering what could frighten him so much about that poor old man guilty only of smiling at him one evening. There was something in that gaze he couldn't quite grasp, something that, in a way, frightened him, though without any rational reason. Fiamma had always tried, since he was a child, to teach him how to face his fears, but theorizing about them was one thing, living with a mother who contradicted her own theories by example was another. It wasn't Fiamma's fault, he guessed, though he'd only understand it fully when his turn came. So he waited for the man to come out of the stall, determined to exorcise that strange unease.

«Nice coat» he said, as the man went to wash his hands in the sink beside him.

«Thanks, I bought it today» the man said in a calm voice.

«Today?» Francesco asked, blurting it out, suddenly free of fear and wondering why he was lying.

«Yes, well... a *today*' the man said, checking his wristwatch, a very expensive model that clashed with his worn-out clothes as much as those of the artist who had just performed, «by a few years ago, let's say this is its anniversary. I bought it on a very, very special day.»

«Ah» said Francesco, not probing further, embarrassed to find it hard to meet his eyes, maybe because of those sunglasses.

«It was my final gesture» the man went on, staring into the mirror as though rewinding the film of his life to recall the details.

«Pardon?»

«My extreme gesture» he repeated without turning, «I was young and broke, couldn't even make it to the end of the month, but when I saw it in that shop window, I fell in love. I didn't mean to buy it, but the girl next to me insisted I try it on, and that was my ruin. It fit me so well it looked tailor-made, and despite the price, I couldn't resist.»

«Well, it still looks great on you.»

«Please, don't call me sir» he said, turning toward him and provoking yet another shiver. «I'm old, I know that, but there's no need to remind me» he laughed.

Francesco nodded, looking for a polite way to say goodbye and leave when he noticed a detail, a small round black pin on the old man's lapel, with something drawn on it that he couldn't make out.

«If I'd spent that same money on Tesla, I could've made a fortune, you know what I mean.»

«Tesla?»

«Tesla, Tesla Motors. Stocks.»

Francesco nodded, avoiding the effort of figuring out how Tesla could've existed in his time. «I never really got the hang of the stock market» he said.

«There's nothing to get, kid» the man said after drying his hands. «You buy, and if you're lucky, they go up in value. You know what I mean.» He finished with that strange smile, passing in front of him.

He stopped for a moment at the door and, before leaving, turned back toward him: «You know what I mean» he repeated.

Francesco nodded again, wearing a polite smile for the poor old man, clearly too far gone in years and probably with no one left to talk to, a smile that turned into a grimace of shock, almost fear, when he realized what the pin showed: a red chili pepper on a black background. Just a moment before the man left the restroom.

«Wait!» he shouted, running after him, but in the corridor beyond the two restroom doors, there was no one but his friends.

«We thought you'd fallen in» said Miranda. «You okay? You're pale as a ghost.»

«Yeah, sure» he whispered. «That old man who just came out, which way did he go?»

«What old man? Are you sure you're all right?»

«Of course» he said. «Must've been my mistake.»

«O...k...» Miranda drawled.

They went out. Fiamma was elated, and Walter was glowing too. It must've been at least the fifth time he'd seen him live, and surely this was the best, though, as he confided to Sergio, the fact that he'd watched it stone-cold sober might've made a difference.

After grabbing pizza together, Fiamma and Walter said goodnight, reminding them not to stay out all night. Only one more day remained in the capital, and it was best to make the most of it. Before they left, Fiamma handed Miranda a business card with the address of the restaurant where they had booked for the next day at 2:00 p.m., a sort of farmhouse just outside the city, which they'd better reach by taxi. If they didn't meet in the morning, they'd see each other there. It was important, she said, and Miranda nodded, perfectly understanding the situation.

Francesco woke up at dawn. He had slept terribly. That damn old man seemed intent on torturing him like the monkeys in that cheerful Zen parable about enlightenment. Not to mention the absurd fantasies he couldn't help elaborating, thoughts that would've suited Teo's synapses better than his own. Was it really possible that the old man was him, come back in time to tip himself off like that? He wouldn't have minded, actually, it would've given him not just a financial parachute but also the feeling of not being alone in the world, adrift in time and space. Although, on second thought, being able to travel back and forth through time to trade insider information and chili plants wouldn't have meant much in the end. He would still have been himself, always alone and increasingly at the mercy of that chain of events commonly called destiny, which most people never bother to handle personally and which he, apparently, was even trying to manipulate: a damn full-time job.

After a cup of coffee, while everyone else was still asleep, he burst out laughing, thinking how easily he had let himself get lost, even for a moment, in such a ridiculous hypothesis as the one he had just constructed. All it had taken was a chili plant and a strange character, and suddenly he was not only believing time travel possible but casting himself as the protagonist, the very first of the first. Not to mention that if someone, in any time or space, had ever discovered the secret of time travel or immortality, they'd hardly have shared it. Those weren't topics for public disclosure. The first to have that kind of power would've surely kept it for themselves, and he doubted HTML5 or graphic design could get anyone that far. How the hell would

he manage it, when time was something he had only ever known how to waste?

By the time the others woke up, Francesco had already filed away his most folkloric theories, handing control of his psyche, reluctantly, back to pure rationality. That evening he would tell his friends about it, and together they'd have a good laugh. Teo and Sergio would definitely throw fuel on the fire, while Miranda would accuse him of wanting attention like a child. Because deep down, like a child, he must have been jealous of Walter in some way, and the fact that Fiamma was finally ready to take on the role of mother instead of sister, older or younger depending on the period, must've really messed with his head.

«Fiamma and Walter, still asleep?» Teo asked.

«I think so» Francesco said.

«No way» Miranda cut in. «They didn't come back last night. They're expecting us at two, though. I know where.»

«What do you mean, they didn't come back?»

«I mean they're adults, probably wanted a night alone. What do you think?»

«Well, they could've at least told us, instead of making us worry.»

«I'm not worried» said Teo.

«Me neither» said Miranda.

«I am» shouted Sergio from the bedroom, «but for your health! Keep it down, for God's sake, it's dawn.»

«Dawn, my ass» thought Miranda, checking the time. They had to wash, get dressed, and find the cheapest way to drag themselves out of the city, and the day would surely turn out to be a long one. Especially for Francesco.

And it was, though not in the way she meant, or not entirely, because once they were out on the street, past eleven and a half but still in time to reach their destination, Francesco froze before a shop window downtown.

«Holy God» he said, standing there with goosebumps.

«Wow» said Miranda. «Not exactly your style, but it's gorgeous. Go on, try it on, let's see how it looks on you, we've got a bit of time.»

Francesco felt something strange, as if his skull had suddenly filled with jelly. The thought patterns he was trying to form, to file yet another coincidence neatly into its folder, in the cabinet maintained by Mrs. Rationality, his personal secretary, came out muffled, distant, almost alien. When he finally managed to push back that sticky mass he felt oozing from his ears, down his neck and over his whole body, slowing his movements, he found himself inside the store. The clerk was already in front of him while Miranda was asking to see the coat from the window.

«The Covert Coat, certainly, miss. An excellent choice» said the clerk, taking Francesco's measurements with his eyes. «A forty-eight, I suppose?»

«Yes, I'd say so.»

Sergio and Teo waited, surprised by the sudden fashion statement, especially in a shop like that, where the wooden mannequins were dressed like English lords and the clerks, buttoned up like penguins, shook hands with anyone crossing the threshold. Francesco stood motionless before the mirror, waiting, repeating an improvised mantra for the occasion, four words, not even particularly harmonious, meant to lift him toward some understanding of that bizarre day: *It can't be true, it can't be true, it can't be true...* The phrase kept bouncing in his head like the wild ball of a '70s pinball machine, while in the mirror before him, now and then, the outlines of the old man overlapped his reflection, until, once he had the coat on, they completely replaced it.

«Holy hell» he muttered, barely able to move.

«Wow, it really suits you» said Miranda.

Sergio and Teo couldn't help nodding. That coat, with its odd burgundy velvet collar and four stitched corners, was indeed a thoroughly hipster garment, yet it seemed tailored exactly for him.

«This isn't possible» Francesco said, unable to take his eyes off himself, struggling to rationalize what felt like the most absurd coincidence of all.

«In fact» said Miranda, glancing at the price tag, which casually read something like seven hundred euros.

«It's an original Covert» the salesman said, stepping in right on cue like a professional musician. «It was used in the UK for hunting. The large inside pocket, in fact, was meant to hold cartridges. Nowadays the English mostly use it for their Sunday paper. And it's fifty percent off, quite the opportunity. It's a very distinctive piece. Besides, it looks excellent on you.»

He was right, the coat fit him perfectly and would probably last a lifetime. Francesco thought of the old man's words in the bathroom: *an extreme gesture*, he had said, before adding that it would be wiser to invest that money in the American stock market. That very evening he would tell his friends everything, accept the inevitable ridicule, but surely they'd find a way to invest something. They couldn't just let such a chance, as absurd as it sounded, slip away, and three hundred and fifty euros more or less wouldn't make much difference.

In a sort of trance, he handed his bank card to the salesman.

Miranda smiled. She liked the way that coat suited him, and she was glad that, for once, Francesco was letting himself go. He deserved it. Even Sergio and Teo refrained from reminding him of the financial hole they were already in, they were too busy savoring the teasing they would inflict on him for at least a week. The coat did look good on him, no question about that, all he needed was a bit of beard to complete the transformation.

Technically, he wasn't a full hipster yet, but to them he was already a perfect anti-stress doll.

Francesco tore off the price tag and put the Covert on, slipping his old jacket into the branded shopping bag. Then, still feeling slightly drunk on the moment, he followed Miranda and the others out of the store toward the metro entrance. They got off at the last stop on the red line, where they planned to take a taxi to the *Castelli Romani* parking lot, but before they could find one, crossing through a small street market, Francesco froze again in front of a makeshift stall full of what looked like stolen junk.

Among battered shoes, quartz watches, old CDs, and immersion blenders, he spotted a pair of 1970s Ray-Ban Shooter Kalichrome sunglasses, perfectly preserved, unlike the rest of the merchandise. Miranda and the others watched him, not so much surprised that he had stopped to stare at all that trash, but that he picked up the glasses without saying a word to the vendor, who, not the least bit bothered, handed him a chipped mirror and smiled.

Francesco studied his reflection. All he was missing now were the white hair. He had no idea what exactly was happening to him, but it was stronger than him. Miranda circled around him, inspecting him from every angle. He looked completely different, and with that coat and the arrogance of those thick, almost transparent lenses, she had to admit she found him even more attractive.

After giving the mirror back, Francesco handed the branded bag to the street vendor, who pulled out the jacket he had been wearing half an hour earlier, a designer piece Anita had given him. The guy laid it on the counter, checked the lining, the pockets, the zipper, and the cuffs. «It's genuine» he said finally, a bit surprised.

«Of course it is. We good?» Francesco asked, adjusting the glasses on his nose.

«We're good, my friend» the vendor said, shaking his hand, convinced he had just scored a deal.

«Jesus, Frank, what's gotten into you?» Sergio asked as they walked away. «You just swapped a three-hundred-euro jacket for a pair of sunglasses.»

«Anita gave me that jacket» he said. «And these are worth no less. They're originals too.»

«Maybe so, you poor fool, but wait till you see the bats.»

They laughed.

«And you» he said quietly to his sister, «aren't you going to say anything?»

«Why?» she replied, glancing back at him. «Look at him, he actually looks good for once.»

«I don't know, he just seems... off to me this morning.»

Miranda smiled, tilting her head slightly. She had the same feeling.

«Hey, Gonzo» Teo said, «is there something we should know?»

«Absolutely» Francesco replied, stopping and staring into space. «But I'll tell you everything later.»

«O...K...» Teo drawled. «Now I am worried.»

Francesco smiled, trying to look like his usual self. «Tonight I'll make you laugh your asses off. But for now, let's go, or we'll be late.»

«With all this mystery, I wouldn't be surprised to find *Ruggeri* at the farmhouse.»

«Better him than *Giacobbo*.»

«No. Not *Giacobbo*...»

They burst out laughing.

The taxi took them to the park, stopping at the cobblestone path leading up to a farmhouse on the hill. From the gate below,

they could see white drapes fluttering in the distance, confirming what Miranda had already begun to suspect, while the only thing that crossed the guys' minds was Game of Thrones.

«Seriously» Sergio said, «they could've picked a more convenient place to eat, with all the restaurants in Trastevere...»

Miranda silenced him with a look only siblings understand. Then he too realized that this was something very different from a simple countryside lunch.

At the top of the drive, in the meadow in front of a large, perfectly restored stone farmhouse, Francesco saw a huge white gazebo sheltering a lavish buffet. To the side, under the shade of a majestic tree, about thirty white chairs were lined up facing a kind of stand decorated with flowers and wrapped in the Italian tricolor.

«Holy shit, we've walked straight into a fucking wedding.»

«Well, hey, maybe we can liven up the party, if they're nice people.»

«As long as they're pouring drinks. Plenty of them.»

«That» said Miranda, snatching a bottle of champagne from a passing waiter's ice bucket without provoking any protest, «won't be a problem. My guess is we're the witnesses.»

Francesco tried to rationalize that last sentence. It wasn't easy to rearrange the whole system of linear thinking he'd relied on up to that day, but before he could grasp its real meaning he heard Fiamma's voice shouting a welcome. He turned and saw her, stunning, her hair loose with a couple of daisies tucked in, just like she used to wear as a girl, and a long, simple dress, no frills, but damn it, completely white.

Walter appeared behind her, smiling, his eyes glistening. He wore a dark blue double-breasted suit, beautifully cut, with black derby shoes and, under the jacket, a V-neck T-shirt

showing the old Commodore Amiga logo. Either he hadn't been ready yet, or the man was a legend.

Fiamma was as stunned as he was, staring at her boy transformed into something she couldn't even categorize. That coat and those sunglasses gave him an entirely different air. Walter, standing behind her, raised both thumbs in full approval.

«You... you're getting married?» he stammered.

«Exactly, my love, in less than an hour» she smiled.

«But... why didn't you tell me? I could've dressed up, I could've found something to wear...»

«You're perfect as you are, look at you! I almost didn't recognize you.»

Miranda and the others joined in a group hug.

«Admit it, you were afraid he'd lose it, huh?»

«We wanted it to be a surprise. And to spend a few days with you all before we leave.»

«Leave? How wonderful» Miranda said. «Where are you going?»

«To Lisbon for a couple of weeks, stopping in Madrid for the Stones concert.»

«Again?» Francesco smiled.

«Well, this time will be different» Fiamma said, taking Walter's hand and pulling him close. «This time it's just us. Together.»

Miranda, visibly moved, popped the champagne, took a swig straight from the bottle, and passed it to Fiamma, who did the same, then to the others, until Sergio, last in line, found only the dregs.

Then Fiamma walked away with Miranda. «I was worried about Frank, you know?» she said. «I didn't think he'd take it so well. He seems calm, or am I wrong?»

«I don't know, honestly he's been acting a bit strange this morning. He bought that coat...»

«It looks amazing on him.»

«Yeah, we all agree on that. But then he traded his jacket for those sunglasses. I don't know, he just seems... different.»

«True. But other than that, he had no idea?»

«None at all. At the gate he was still wondering why you'd booked this place, with all the restaurants we had near home.»

Fiamma laughed. «But you figured it out, didn't you?»

«Pretty much right away» Miranda smiled. «And I'm so happy for you.»

They hugged.

«Listen» Fiamma said, «I know Frank's not a kid anymore, but this is a weird time for him. A lot's changing around him. Can I count on you?»

«You want me to keep an eye on him?»

«He's more mature than I am, I've always known that. I've even taken advantage of it, whether I meant to or not. But he's a special soul, very sensitive, and I've often neglected him. I only realize it now that I finally have someone who takes care of me, too.»

«Don't worry, Fiamma, I adore your son» she said, winking. «If you know what I mean.»

«No way, that's wonderful news!» Fiamma crushed her in a hug. «And him?»

«He's behaving like a gentleman. The fact that he's known me since I was born puts him in a tough spot.»

«Bloody gentleman» Fiamma laughed. «He still hasn't realized that even etiquette allows you to use your hands when the food calls for it.»

Miranda laughed, thinking that maybe it was finally time to let him know.

When the speakers hidden among the trees began to play the intro to *You Can't Always Get What You Want*, the guests, about thirty friends of the couple, most of whom Francesco didn't even know existed, all moved toward the chairs. They, too, having just found out they were the witnesses, took their seats in the front row: Francesco and Miranda on Fiamma's side, Sergio and Teo on Walter's.

The bride and groom, with no relatives left to accompany them, arrived together, hand in hand, while Mick Jagger's voice kept repeating that in life you had to at least give it a try. And who better than his mother, thought Francesco, moved, had done just that. She'd taken her share of beatings, plenty of them, some so hard even an elephant wouldn't have gotten back up. Yet there she was, glowing at last, even if a little late to the party. She'd tried all right, in every possible way, without ever giving in to fatigue or disillusion. Sure, he thought, catching himself laughing quietly, she still hadn't managed to get Walter to wear a shirt under that double-breasted suit, but that only made the man more admirable. A shame they hadn't met sooner, he thought.

Then, spurred on by Mick Jagger's verses as Fiamma and Walter slowly walked down a path strewn with rose petals, he grabbed Miranda's hand, squeezed it, and intertwined his fingers with hers, realizing he couldn't wait as long as his mother had, that he wasn't nearly as strong as she was.

«I love you, Randi» he said, pulling her closer and looking straight into her eyes.

She moved aside, pushing him to the edge of the ceremony and drawing everyone's attention. «And that's what you come up with now, at a moment like this?» she said.

The ground was about to give way beneath his feet, he was ready to curse Mick Jagger and all of rock music for leading him to that point, at that exact moment.

«And now» Miranda went on, before terror could take hold of him at the thought of having interrupted or ruined the ceremony, «you tell me how the hell I'm supposed to resist wanting you all this time?» And she kissed him, deeply, before he could even process the meaning of her words.

Fiamma let out a joyful scream that drowned out Richards's guitar solo, then pulled her future husband close and kissed him too, with passion, love, and even gratitude. Without him, things would have turned out very differently, and she knew it.

Sergio and Teo, their mouths hanging open like almost everyone else's, shifted their gaze between the bride and groom and the two witnesses, amused, trying to guess who would pull away from their partner's lips first.

«Usually» thundered the officiant through the loudspeakers, lowering the music, «this part comes after the ceremony, but honestly, this way is much more fun! Long live the newlyweds!» he shouted, raising a flute of champagne he'd brought to the podium. He had to be a friend delegated by the city, not a real clerk, because, once he'd finished his glass, he bent down and picked up a whole bottle.

The crowd broke into loud applause. Then, gradually, all four of them returned to their seats, smiling.

When the murmur died down, the man behind the lectern set down the bottle and began reading the official text: «By the power vested in me, blah blah blah... we are gathered here to unite in marriage the present Fiamma Cattaneo and the present Walter Morasso, blah blah blah...»

Then came the endless reading of civil code articles, the duty to raise and educate children (required by law, though Fiamma had obviously already done her part), up to the classic question, to which both answered yes without hesitation, setting off a roar of approval and a standing ovation.

When the moment came for them to exchange rings, Francesco shivered. Until a short while ago, he hadn't even known his mother planned to get married, let alone that he'd be her witness, or that there would be rings involved. Luckily, a very young girl in white appeared, carrying the bands on a kind of tray, and as soon as the fateful words were spoken, «*By the power vested in me... I now pronounce you husband and wife*», the opening riff of *Back in Black* blasted through the speakers, triggering general mayhem.

After everyone had had their turn kissing the bride, Fiamma and Walter introduced Francesco and the others to their friends. Francesco recognized some of them, vaguely perhaps, but their faces rang a bell. They, on the other hand, were stunned to find a grown man standing where a boy they once knew had been. Then, to the sound of *Heartattack and Vine*, they all moved en masse under the gazebo to claim the champagne.

Fiamma was radiant. She had never even come close to looking her age as a single woman, and now that she no longer was, she looked ten years younger. Francesco, though his mind was cluttered with darker thoughts, felt both happy and sad. Happy that his mother was finally happy, sad that it had taken her so long to get there. It wasn't fair, not everyone could hold out that long.

Fortunately, Miranda was beside him now, close, pressed against him, and their mutual attraction had to be restrained somehow, since neither of them wanted their first time to be a quickie in the men's room at Fiamma's wedding, even if that would've been far more rock'n'roll than any bedroom. They

drained the champagne, searching in it for temporary anesthesia, but got the opposite effect instead.

They resisted as long as they could, teasing, brushing against each other, inseparable even through the buffet, but in the end they couldn't hold back any longer and fled to the fields behind the hill, risking being caught at any moment, to carve out what Francesco realized, without a shred of doubt, was a moment of absolute perfection.

His three years with Anita had never even come close to making him feel what he felt for Miranda now: an explosive mix of affection, love, passion, admiration, complicity, and empathy. He would've had children with her right then and there, without a second thought, because she was the one. He knew it. And, unlike his mother, he'd actually found her.

Only one question kept bouncing around in his head: what the hell could Miranda possibly see in someone like him?

They got back to the reception just in time for lunch. Fiamma hugged them again and, with a knowing smile, brushed a couple of blades of grass from Miranda's hair. Then she led them to their seats, explaining that she and Walter would of course leave at the end of the day, and not in the van. Walter trusted them to drive it back home, to his garage, and he'd give them all the directions later. That evening all four of them could sleep at the farmhouse, the rooms had already been booked, two doubles, Fiamma pointed out, so they wouldn't have to hold back with the wine during the party or worry about subway schedules.

«Oh, for God's sake» said Francesco as soon as Fiamma walked away, «couldn't she have told us before that we had a room booked?»

«Relax» Miranda laughed, grabbing one last glass of champagne before lunch, «we'll make the most of it later.»

They met again at breakfast the next morning, Sergio and Teo nursing hangovers, and Francesco and Miranda with dark circles under their eyes from a sleepless night. Luckily, it was a perfect day: the sun was shining, the sky was clear, immaculate, the kind of blue you only ever saw in comic books. That shade of blue that sometimes caught them off guard, stripping the landscape – the whole world – of its usual veneer of seriousness, tinting its outlines with unfamiliar tones, lightening its weight. Everyday problems, big or small, aside from that throbbing headache that would fade by early afternoon, felt light-years away. Yet soon enough, they'd have to head straight back in that direction.

Everyone was thinking more or less the same thing, wondering why they couldn't just live simply, in a place like that, surrounded by nature, without having to answer to alarm clocks, routines, and that damned hipster invasion that, after just one day of peace, they had almost forgotten about. Francesco had something else on his mind too, too many strange things had happened to him, and he needed to find the right moment to talk to his friends, hoping he wouldn't sound insane.

He managed to do it late in the afternoon, after they'd returned to Rome, tidied up the apartment, dropped the keys off at the bar downstairs as Walter had asked, and spent over half an hour figuring out who would take responsibility for driving a thing like that for more than five hundred kilometers.

Miranda took the wheel, she didn't trust her brother or Teo, and said she'd swap with Francesco if she got tired. She drove

that little gem onto the *Grande Raccordo Anulare*, then onto the highway, toward the end of that wonderful interlude.

That's when Francesco, after taking off his coat and those odd sunglasses, set the stage to confide in his friends. «You're going to think I'm crazy» he said, «but something really strange happened to me yesterday.»

«I knew there was something off» said Teo.

«Stranger than hitting on my sister?»

«Oh, much... much stranger» he said, stroking Miranda's knee. She turned briefly toward him, curious to hear the rest.

«I saw this old man the other night, kind of peculiar, from the window, just after we got to Rome, when we were getting ready to go out for dinner.»

«O... K...»

«An old man wearing that coat» he pointed at the seat, «and those sunglasses.»

The three of them waited to see where this was going.

«That coat and those sunglasses» he repeated, absentmindedly.

«Yeah, well... so?»

«That guy gave me the creeps, I don't know why. That night he just smiled at me. I was by the window, when you came up behind me» he said to Miranda, «and told me that the future isn't what it used to be, remember?»

«Of course.»

«Well, he was down there, he'd gotten up from one of the tables at the bar, and he was staring at me, smiling.»

«What a story» Teo said sarcastically. «Stephen King would write a book about it.»

«Exactly» Francesco nodded, «and there's more...» He stopped.

«What are you waiting for, to get home? Come on, finish the story.»

«I thought I caught sight of him a couple more times, maybe three, just out of the corner of my eye. And every time, something would shake me up for no reason, until we went to the Tom Waits concert. When I went to the restroom, he showed up there too...» He paused, trying to steady the shiver that had run through him, one his friends had clearly noticed.

«And what happened?»

«He went to the bathroom...»

Sergio and Teo burst out laughing. «Really? To the bathroom? I didn't think people still did that» Sergio said, amused.

Miranda, who hadn't laughed at all, turned toward him and calmed him down with a look.

«I couldn't figure out why that guy made me so nervous, so when he came out, I decided to face him, so to speak, and I complimented him on his coat. That coat» he said again, pointing at the seat where it was resting. «He said he'd bought it that day, and when he saw my surprise, he corrected himself, saying yes, that day, but many years ago, on an absolutely special day. He said he hadn't wanted to buy it, but the girl he was with», he turned again to Miranda, «talked him into trying it on, and he couldn't help but get it. He said it was, as he put it, his extreme gesture. And then he added, emphasizing it a couple of times, that it would've been much better if he'd invested that money in Tesla instead.»

«Tesla, Tesla Motors?!»

«Exactly.»

«Interesting» said Teo, «interesting and annoying.»

«Annoying?!»

«Absolutely. Correct me if I'm wrong, but you're suggesting that somehow you managed to go back in time to do some insider trading?!»

«I don't know what to think. But the next day, or the same day, technically, since my meeting happened after midnight, I found myself standing in front of that shop, with the same coat in the window and Miranda pushing me to try it on. Then the street stall with the sunglasses, the only thing in perfect condition among all that junk... You have to admit, it's pretty weird.»

«One thing's for sure» said Sergio, «joke or not, we can't risk not buying a few shares. Yesterday they dropped to an all-time low» he said, checking the quotes on his phone, «after a Chinese investment pullout.»

«All-time low?!»

«As low as it gets.»

«Dear God, the perfect time to buy.»

«And throw away money we don't even have. Besides» Teo went on, «why you? If anyone should be jumping through time, it should be me... No offense, but how exactly would you have done it?»

«Teo, how the hell should I know? Maybe it's just a massive coincidence, maybe that old guy owns the shop and he's trying to unload leftover stock in the most creative way possible. You think I haven't thought of that?»

«Could've been Walter, in on it with your mom, they might've set the whole thing up to give you a push, get you to take a little risk for once, you know, put yourself out there...»

«So they'd get their kicks by making me gamble on the stock market with money I don't even have?»

«Well, it wouldn't be Fiamma's first odd idea.»

That was true.

«And the chili plant on Portofino promontory? Have you forgotten about that?»

«Well, come on... that might really not count.»

«Or maybe it was planted there on purpose to prepare me for this situation. But that's nothing, you know what's even crazier?»

«Even crazier?» Teo laughed, more inclined to think it was a prank.

«The old man had a pin on his coat lapel, one of those classic round ones.»

Miranda swerved slightly, though the road was straight.

«You okay?» asked Francesco.

«I don't know, I'm pulling over for a second» she said, pointing to a rest area.

«So?»

«The pin, you were saying» said Teo, stepping out of the van to stretch his legs, though they'd left barely an hour earlier.

«A round, black pin, with a drawing of...»

«A chili pepper» Miranda finished, goosebumps rising on her arms.

«And how the hell do you know that?»

«Because I made it» she said, rummaging in her backpack, «it's just that with everything that's happened these past few days, I forgot to give it to you.»

«Oh... Christ!» he exclaimed, taking the forgotten pin from her hands. «It's the exact same one. I'm officially confused now.»

«Confused? I'm terrified» Miranda admitted, «even though I can't explain why. I mean, if this isn't some elaborate prank, then it should be a good thing, right?»

«I have no idea» said Francesco, pulling her into his arms.

«Who knows? Moving back and forth through time, if that's ever actually possible, could cause unimaginable consequences. The world as we know it could start falling apart.»

«Thanks a lot for the pep talk, Teo.»

«Okay, guys» said Sergio, «let's not jump to crazy conclusions. Obviously you didn't travel through time. First of all, did the old guy look like you? Same face?»

«I don't know, he was old, had long hair, I didn't even really notice.»

«You didn't notice, huh? Too bad... because I'd think that if we ever ran into ourselves, even a few years older, we'd recognize each other right away.»

«Not necessarily» said Teo, «the psyche might protect us from facing such a paradox and plunging into irrationality.»

«I know you'd love to believe our friend here actually traveled through time, even though that should, from your point of view, piss you off, but let's be rational. The solution to any problem is always the simplest one, we don't even need Occam's razor this time. Walter and Fiamma must've cooked up a little prank to make these days even more memorable. Think about it: Walter works in theater, he could've hired someone to play a part, lead you straight to that shop where, surprise, the coat just happened to be fifty percent off even though it's not sale season. Then there are the sunglasses, exactly like the old guy's and in perfect condition. And let me see» he said, examining them closely, «they're genuine '70s originals, look, it says «Made in USA», we make Ray-Bans here now...»

«So?»

«So, I think the coat and the sunglasses were wedding gifts. I'd bet anything it was them.»

«And the pin?» asked Miranda.

«Well, that's obvious. You must've shown it to Fiamma or Walter at some point, right?»

Miranda thought for a moment. «Yes, I think I showed the drawing to Fiamma one evening. Maybe Walter was there too, I can't remember.»

«See? It all fits. Forget time travel, those two are probably laughing their heads off right now.»

No one was entirely convinced by Sergio's theory, not even Sergio himself, but they all needed a shot of rationality, at least long enough to park that ridiculously expensive toy that was supposed to take them home. Once they were safe, they could let their minds wander in any direction they wanted.

For now, the only journey that mattered was the one back home.

It was Francesco who took responsibility for the drive back. The trip was quiet, intimate, even a little dull. They didn't talk much, and they cursed the absence of a car radio more than once. The ride there had been cheerful and carefree, the way back was something else entirely. Aside from that absurd story they all still needed to digest, and which, in a way, encouraged the silence, it was the very idea of returning that had crushed everyone's spirits. Even Francesco and Miranda, who every now and then exchanged glances that should have been overflowing with joy, couldn't quite relax as they wanted to. Just the thought, remote as it was, of possibly running into someone who already knew what their future held didn't sound nearly as cool as it did in a Marvel comic strip.

Miranda had been right: the future wasn't what it used to be.

Only after parking the Volkswagen, safe and sound, in Walter's garage up in the hills of *San Fruttuoso* did the four realize they hadn't had lunch. They were exhausted, worn out from the drive, from the hangover, from doubt, and from their now almost chronic lack of cash. They walked down to the Blues House to cure their hunger in perfect hipster fashion. An aperitif, maybe two, was about all they could afford.

When the Bla saw Francesco walk in with that coat and those sunglasses, an outfit he'd apparently made his own in record time, he dove headfirst into a drawer beside the counter, rummaging through old phone books, scissors, balls of string, and stacks of invoices, until he triumphantly emerged with an old crucifix. The kind his younger customers regularly *borrowed* from school walls and replaced with the classic back soon sign. He rushed to the door, waving the cross like Father Damien Karras:

«Get out of that body!» he shouted, «Out of that body...»

Francesco played along for a few seconds, convulsing like a breakdancer hit by a jolt of electricity, but Sergio was tired, maybe a bit jealous too, and above all, he wanted a drink, so he cut it short:

«Fiamma got married yesterday.»

«Fiamma?!» said the Bla. «You're kidding...» Then, tossing the crucifix into the trash, he hugged Francesco tightly. «What news! And you didn't tell me?»

«Well, for what it's worth, we didn't know either.»

«What do you mean?»

«We found out yesterday. We thought we were going to lunch at a farmhouse, and it turned out to be a wedding.»

«I adore that woman, your mother's a legend. I'm happy for her. First round's on the house, then. Sit down.»

They told the Bla everything, the trip, the van, the concert, the wedding. Everything except that crazy story, the one they'd decided to keep to themselves, at least until they figured out how to live with it.

The Bla thought they seemed a little off, tired, but he guessed, correctly, that something had finally sparked between Miranda and Francesco. Then, once they'd eaten a little and the moment felt right, he returned to their table.

«By the way» he said to Francesco, «did you know that last night, during aperitif, there was this old guy dressed exactly like you?»

Miranda spilled half her beer on herself.

«Dressed like me, how do you mean?» Francesco asked, trying not to tremble.

«Well, with a coat like yours, actually, I'd say identical, and those same Fear and Loathing-style sunglasses...»

«Go on» said Teo.

«That's it, really. Not much more to say. I'd never seen him before. He stopped by for a drink, had a couple of Bloody Marys. Seemed odd, kind of dazed. I swear he scanned the whole place like he was taking inventory, his eyes were everywhere. I figured he must've lived around here once, that's the vibe I got. He had that *Ragazzo della via Gluck* melancholy in his eyes, you know what I mean?»

«Perfectly» said Sergio.

The Bla, being a pro, was quick to size up whoever was sitting across his counter.

«Go on, did he tell you anything else? What was he like? Give us some details.»

«You guys really care about this?» he asked, glancing back at the bar to make sure no one was waiting.

«Of course we do. If there's someone walking around dressed like me, I wanna know who he is» Francesco said, trying to sound casual.

«Well, let's just say you're the one walking around dressed like him. He must've been around seventy, give or take, but he looked damn good for his age. Still had all his hair, white, though. At first, I thought he was some kind of fucking hipster way past his expiration date» he whispered, careful not to be overheard by his bearded clientele, «but then I realized he didn't have anything in common with them. He spoke in proper Italian, old-fashioned, maybe» he smiled, «and said weird things, half sentences, stuff like that.»

«Like what?»

«He said he'd had a full life, fun, hard, and that he was damn glad to have made it where he was.»

«And where was that?»

«I asked him the same thing» the Bla laughed, «and you know what he said?»

«What?»

«Here.»

«Here?!»

«Yeah. That's why I figured he must've been an old local. But why are you so interested, anyway? If I told you about all the weirdos that come in here, we'd be here all week.» He checked the bar again.

«Just curiosity» said Miranda. «Bar characters can be wonderful... please, go on.»

«Okay, but it's not like we stood around chatting all night. At one point, when I brought him his second drink, he told me that some trains only pass once in a lifetime, but that it doesn't really mean anything...»

«What do you mean?»

«Exactly what I thought! Then he said that if you really wanted to, you could just walk the whole way instead. I figured I must've made his first Bloody Mary too strong, and the second one, since I liked the guy, was even stiffer» he chuckled.

«Did he lose it?»

«Absolutely not. Not even a flicker of marbles missing. When he left, he walked straight as an arrow, though he did say another weird thing as he went. He told me there was electricity in the air, that I should remember it, and...»

«And?»

«And that I should tell my friends. What a guy. I walked him to the door, looked up at the sky to see what the hell he meant, maybe a storm was coming, the season's right for it, but he just laughed and walked off.»

«And that's it? He didn't say anything else?»

«I said goodbye and yelled for him to come back sometime, like I do with the nice customers. Not with the pain-in-the-ass ones.»

«So?»

«I don't know, I didn't really get it. He didn't even turn around. I heard him chuckle a bit and then mutter something to himself, but I'm not sure.»

«Something like what?»

«Hell, I don't know... I thought I heard him say something like, «But I do it all the time, I do it all the time.' But obviously, I'm not sure. I swear it was the first time I'd ever seen him. What's going on with you four, anyway? You been recruited by the secret services or something?»

«I wish» said Miranda. «Wouldn't even be that weird.»

The Bla laughed. «You guys in the secret services? Wouldn't be weird? It'd be hilarious! I can see it now, MI6, hipster division. A riot.»

They all laughed.

«Hey, do you remember if on the lapel of his coat, right here»
Francesco said, pointing to his own, «he had a round pin?»

«No, nothing.»

«You mean you don't remember, or he didn't have one?»

«He didn't have one. No pin, nothing at all.»

«You sure?»

«Listen, Frank, there's only one thing in life I can be sure of, unfortunately, but I looked at him closely, and I don't recall or remember seeing any pin. Sorry» he said, then went back to the bar to catch up on orders.

«Okay» said Miranda, «does anyone have any idea what the hell's going on?»

«A fucking well-orchestrated prank?» said Sergio.

«Yeah, but who could possibly have a mind that twisted? Do we even know anyone like that?»

«Someone who'd know we were going to Rome to see Tom Waits? And the wedding, we didn't even know about that ourselves. I don't know about you, but I didn't tell a soul» said Miranda.

«Me neither.»

«Same» said Sergio and Francesco together.

They sat in silence for a while, wrapped in that strange kind of bubble that seemed to have swallowed them, like in a '70s TV show, where the sounds of the real world reached them muffled, soft, almost unreal. After years of monotonous routine, in the span of just a few days – or maybe a few months, if you started counting from the day they'd moved back in together – their lives seemed to have changed drastically. And if everything they'd believed in up to that point could wobble in such a ridiculously short time, an eye blink, anthropologically speaking, then what could possibly happen next?

Now that even the simplest laws of physics seemed up for debate, whether it was an insanely clever prank or the future biting its own tail didn't matter much. What mattered was the change itself, and one way or another, they were all ready to embrace it. Cautiously, but ready.

«Alright» said Teo, motioning to the Bla to refill his mug, «let's go with the most absurd hypothesis. Let's assume our friend here, without worrying about how, really did follow in Marty McFly's footsteps. Taking that as our premise, aside from the unspeakable envy I'll try not to show on-site, what I'm thinking is that, since he's the old hipster-looking guy himself» Teo was getting tipsy, «he must subconsciously know the reasons for this trip of his and the details we're missing right now...»

«Yeah» said Sergio, «he may not have formed the specific thought patterns behind his future choices yet, but since they're his own...»

«He just needs to hypothesize them, trying not to get distracted by the present.»

«Guys, I didn't understand a word» said Francesco.

«It's simple. We're trying to piece things together, and you just hypothesize without overthinking. Let's start from the chili plant.»

«So?»

«You found one on Portofino promontory, right?»

«Yes, in what I've always thought was the perfect spot for it, so?»

«You tell us, assuming one could travel through time, luggage and all (though Kyle Reese might disagree), why the hell would you take a plant along?»

«Because I never go anywhere without it?»

«Exactly. That's true. But maybe there's more?»

«To use it as a signal, to prepare for my arrival?»

«Okay. Then you saw yourself at the window with Miranda, you were spying on yourself, in a way. Why that moment, specifically?»

«I don't know. Maybe because it was an important one. Maybe that's when I realized I wanted her more than anything in the world. And maybe, if I hadn't been distracted, we would've kissed that night, right there, at that window.»

Miranda shivered.

«So your, his, presence might have altered the course of events. Then the concert, the real contact, and here there's not much to theorize about. You must've left clues for yourself, maybe trying not to screw up our timeline» he laughed, «and so far, all good, or, well, as good as it gets.»

«But why the hell would you come all the way here, to the Blues House, just to mess around with the Bla?» said Sergio.

«Exactly. Why?»

«Melancholy?»

«Could be. But there's got to be more to it. You told Bla the same thing, didn't you? You said there was electricity in the air...»

«Knowing us, you must've known that, even if we thought it was some kind of brilliant setup, we wouldn't have ignored a clue like that. Especially considering the current price of Tesla stock.»

«But we don't have any money» Francesco said with a shiver. «We're broke. And Bla's probably the only one who could help us.»

Sergio and Teo fell silent for a moment.

«You mean we should ask Bla for money?»

«Ask him to join in» said Miranda. «Maybe without too many details. No need to sound like lunatics. We'll just tell him we've got a tip, one of those once-in-a-lifetime tips, and see how he reacts.»

When the aperitif crowd thinned out, they invited Bla over to their table. Adrenaline had flushed away most of the alcohol, leaving them almost sober and completely uneasy. None of them had ever asked a friend for money before. Luckily, Miranda took the lead.

She began explaining that the strange man Bla had seen the night before was actually a distant relative of hers, someone high up in the world of finance, who had once told her that something very profitable was about to happen to a specific stock. They had talked in person, never on the phone, of course, and she made Bla promise to keep it quiet. For something like that, her *relative* could not only lose his job but end up in jail without passing Go. He was a big shot, chauffeur, secretaries, the whole deal, but when the time came, he'd find a way to get the message to her. He had no children and adored her, she said.

Bla didn't flinch. He listened carefully, trying to figure out, friends or not, why they wanted to share a tip like that with him. Miranda continued: the problem was, the opportunity was about to happen within a couple of days, right when they were broke. They barely had anything to invest, and that's why she was telling him.

«So, you're asking for a loan?»

«A loan, or a partner. We hate asking you for money, honestly. But we'd feel way less embarrassed if we could make you a profit in return.»

«I don't know, guys» Bla said, rubbing his beard. «I've never liked that whole stock-market circus. And it's weird thinking of you mixed up in it. No, I'm not interested in investing. But you're my friends. Of course I'll help however I can. Just don't expect miracles, I'm not exactly swimming in gold myself.»

«Thanks, Bla» said Miranda, hugging him. «I'll vouch for them» she whispered. «Worst case, I'll bring my father into it.»

Bla refilled everyone's glasses, and they all toasted together. Then, without asking another question, he took out his checkbook and scribbled down a check for eight thousand euros.

«I'm making it out to Miranda, though» he said.

«You don't trust us, huh?»

«Not even a little.»

They laughed.

«Sorry, guys, that's all I can do. I've got to keep something in the bank.»

«Are you kidding? That's a lot of money! We'll pay you back soon.»

«Alright, but tonight's you're paying me these drink, right?»

«Well, that's the least we can do» said Teo. «You cash checks here, don't you?»

Bla grinned, and for once, he was almost happy to be single. If he'd had someone waiting at home, he probably couldn't have even considered helping his friends like that.

The next morning, Miranda went to the bank and deposited the check. Then she checked her balance and decided she could invest the same amount herself. Sergio, who had stayed up late, had already dug up the trading software he'd used months earlier to simulate a basic €20,000 investment, one that had earned him ten times that amount in under six months, before he'd lost it all over two nights.

He had set up the market parameters, picked the stock, set the automatic buy and sell limits, the alerts, everything. All that was left was to transfer the funds and hit «Start.»

Scraping the bottom of every barrel, keeping just enough for a month's rent and survival, they managed to pull together about twenty thousand euros. It was a risky sum, sure, but Miranda and Bla were the ones most exposed.

A couple of days later, right at Tesla's all-time low, waiting, according to *Il Sole 24 Ore*, for a major Chinese investment (the paper itself was practically unreadable), Sergio pressed Enter.

On the glowing computer screen, a slow, inscrutable graph began to crawl upward and downward, decorated like a Christmas tree with blinking colored candles. For a few days, it felt like time outside that chart, and the occasional beeps of the computer, had completely stopped.

Miranda worked in a daze, detached, struggling even with the simplest tasks. Francesco, Sergio, and Teo stayed holed up at home, hypnotized by those tiny market fluctuations. What weighed on everyone wasn't just the financial risk. They all knew money was just money, meant to move, to be used. The real weight was having dragged Bla into it.

Eight thousand euros more or less wouldn't make much difference in the grand scheme, but still, if they hadn't been drinking that night, they probably wouldn't have asked him at all.

On the fifth day, with autumn now in full swing, the Chinese must have done something, because that afternoon Sergio's computer suddenly erupted in a volley of beeps that nearly gave the three of them a collective heart attack. They'd just been talking about finally stopping by the Blues House for a drink – if only to prove to Bla they hadn't fled town – even though their stomachs were knotted shut and their wallets were empty.

Sergio lunged for the keyboard, expanding the chart to full screen. The thin green line of the stock price had shot upward, climbing past the top of his 27-inch monitor, forcing him to scroll down to see it all, and what he saw made his heart drop and soar at the same time: they'd just gained sixty percent in one go. A surge like that would've triggered a trading halt for excessive rise on the Italian markets.

Sergio, Teo, and Francesco instantly snapped into action. After a quick, adrenaline-charged consultation, they adjusted a few automatic buy and sell thresholds to at least secure Bla's money, then the three of them burst into a triumphant wave, even breaking into a ridiculous Crash Bandicoot-style dance.

Then they hugged.

Francesco called Miranda to tell her they'd meet that evening at the Blues House to reassure the bartender, and that afterward he'd finally go sleep at her place, if she wanted him to.

Miranda, buried in the file of a lawsuit dumber than a checkered shirt with a matching bow tie, something about drops of laundry water dripping onto a downstairs balcony, shuddered. They'd agreed not to sleep together until things calmed down, and at that moment she felt as if she were surfacing for air after a week spent deep underwater. She slammed the folder shut,

told her colleagues she was leaving early, and walked out. That poor woman's balcony wasn't going to collapse just because her neighbor didn't wring her clothes properly.

She walked home along *Corso Italia*, past the beach clubs that, in the off-season, reinvented themselves as trendy bars packed with young hipsters who looked immune to any kind of real problem. She passed through *Boccadasse*, the old fishing village the whole world envied, a place where the fishermen had long since vanished, leaving their damp little apartments to the next generation of *Genova bene*, the well-to-do kind who'd really hire a law firm over a few drops of water on a balcony that could be wiped out by a single rogue wave.

But that was part of the beauty of that damned city, squeezed between sea and mountains, a city where you could never really get lost, because there were only two main directions and one road slicing it from east to west. Buildings thrown together like a game of Tetris on the hills, where the top floor windows might overlook the main street while the ground floor opened onto a dizzying drop, an invisible horizon on the other side of the landing.

She stopped at *Capo Santa Chiara*, sitting on the benches below the castle, taking in the view, happy about what was happening to her, meeting Francesco, falling in love, but also afraid. Because, as smart, modern, and open-minded as she thought she was, this story was too absurd even for her. Sure, those three had accustomed her to all sorts of strangeness since childhood, but their quirks had always been harmless, born from flashes of genius or bouts of inspired idiocy. They were nerds, they always had been, and most importantly, unlike many others, they'd always loved being nerds.

But actually managing to go back in time, that was something else entirely. It was insane. Dangerous, probably. Impossible, most likely. And what scared her most was this: if Francesco

really had come back from some distant future, then what the hell would happen to her? Where would she be when he decided to take that kind of vacation?

Just the thought that someone, somewhere, might have answers to those questions was enough to drive her crazy.

She was almost home, had just passed the Hemingway Pub, thankfully still closed, when she spotted two older, well-dressed people wearing that same coat that had caused so much confusion before, though in different shades. She quickened her pace, afraid they'd slip into a doorway on *Via Arnaldo da Brescia*.

«Excuse me!» she called out before they disappeared inside. «Excuse me» she repeated, breathless, «I was wondering where you bought your coats.»

They both smiled.

«I got mine in Rome last year» said one, «but I'm afraid I don't remember the name of the shop.»

«Oh, I bought mine right here on *Via XX Settembre*, at *Ghiglino*.»

«*Ghiglino*, perfect» she smiled. «I wanted to get one for my partner, but I had no idea where to find them. Thank you so much.»

«Oh, not at all» they said, and vanished.

Ghiglino, she thought, crossing the street, and caught a bus back downtown, she had plenty of time.

In the men's department, she found a rack full of coats just like theirs, in various shades and with collars in different colors.

«May I help you?» asked a saleswoman.

«Thanks, I just wanted to take a look at these coats.»

«Ah, the Coverts» the woman said. «Aren't they beautiful? We've sold so many lately.»

«Yes, they're lovely» Miranda said. «But tell me, do they all have these stitches?» she asked, pointing to the seams.

«Of course! That's what defines an original Covert. It was originally a hunting or riding coat, but later became everyday wear in England. The four rows of stitching are its trademark.»

«I see. And how much do they go for?»

«They're around seven hundred euros, though I'd have to check, but I think there's still a forty percent discount. It's not sale season, but Coverts sell best in late spring and early autumn. In winter, especially with our humidity, people prefer heavier fabrics. Shall I check for you?»

«No, please, don't bother» she said. «I just wanted to get an idea. Do you always keep them in stock?»

«For the past year, yes. They used to be worn mostly by older gentlemen, but lately they've become popular among younger people too, that's why we went wild with the colors.»

«Perfect, thank you. That's all for now.»

When she stepped out of the store, she could finally breathe again. The outlines of what she liked to call "the real world" were coming back into focus. So instead of heading home to change for the evening, she hurried down *Corso Buenos Aires* toward *Isolani*, one of those optical chains swallowing up every small shop in the city, spreading their signs like a contagion.

«Hello» she said to the saleswoman. «I'm looking for a pair of sunglasses, Ray-Bans, preferably, with yellow lenses.»

The woman smiled and pulled a catalog from under the counter. «Kalichrome lenses, I imagine» she said, flipping through the pages. «You mean the ones Johnny Depp wears in *Fear and Loathing in Las Vegas*?»

«Exactly.»

«Here they are» she said, pointing. «Ray-Ban Shooters with Kalichrome lenses, available in photochromic or standard versions. And if you want them just like in the movie, you'll need the larger gauge.»

«Gauge?»

«Yes, it's the lens size. Ray-Bans have always come in three sizes. To get that proper '70s effect, like in the film, you need the biggest one, though for your face, maybe...»

«Oh, they're not for me. My boyfriend's obsessed with them. Honestly, I don't even like them» she lied, trying to sound casual, relatable.

The clerk looked tired, ready to clock out. But realizing the woman probably wasn't going to buy anything, and that she still had ten minutes left before closing, she relaxed.

«Listen, these glasses were all the rage in the '70s, though I can't for the life of me tell you why» she said, taking out a pair. «Even though they've got UV protection, these lenses actually amplify light instead of dimming it. They're useful at dusk or even at night, on dimly lit roads or in fog. In sunlight, as you can see for yourself» she handed them over, «they're pure madness. I dare you to wear them at the beach.»

«Wow» Miranda said, slipping them on. «Now I understand.»

«Right?» The clerk chuckled. «But ever since that movie came out, everyone's been asking for them. Ray-Ban had actually stopped making these lenses, but they had to put them back in production because of the demand.»

«All that for a movie?»

«Oh, absolutely. That's how young people are. I can always tell when *Easy Rider* has been on TV, hordes of kids show up asking for Peter Fonda's Caravan De Luxe. We still sell those, they've never gone out of production, but the kids want them with light lenses like in the movie. And you just can't explain to them that a director has to show the actor's eyes on camera, except, of course, for *The Blues Brothers*.»

Miranda laughed, she'd never thought of that. «So Belushi and Aykroyd drive you crazy too?»

«Oh no, not them. Wayfarers sell constantly. That style never has highs or lows, they fly off the shelves year-round.»

«So, going back to my boyfriend's glasses, you do have them?»

«Absolutely.»

«And tell me» she whispered, as if sharing a secret, «do you sell a lot of them?»

«A lot? We sell tons. But don't worry, you won't see many around. Not in this city. Like I said, kids get caught up in the hype, buy them, and two days later they understand why the movie's protagonist was always so high» she grinned. «They might wear them at night, maybe. Definitely not on the beach.»

«I see. I'll try to drag my boyfriend here then, maybe I'll make him change his mind. Thank you so much for your help.»

«Oh, not at all. Have a good evening» the woman said, finally slipping off her lab coat.

Miranda sat at the bus stop in *Piazza Tommaseo*, late, but at last completely at peace.

Rationality had won. She'd managed to send that absurd chain of coincidences back to wherever it came from, all those tiny shocks that had rattled her in such a short time. Tonight, finally, she would hold her friend, her man, the way she'd wanted to for a while now. Tonight, their relationship would officially begin.

She took a quick shower and changed, a business suit wasn't exactly the look she wanted for the Blues House. For the occasion, she picked the tightest, sexiest outfit in her closet. Tonight wouldn't be about a quickie on the grass or a drunken, awkward night, tonight they would make love, and she wanted Francesco to want her as much as she wanted him.

As she left, rummaging in her bag for her keys, she found the chili-pepper pin, the one she'd Photoshopped from a Red Hot Chili Peppers logo she'd found online and had pressed in a little

shop downtown. She hadn't given it to him yet. It couldn't possibly exist in the future, she thought with a sigh of relief. So, just to be safe, she set it on the floor and stepped on it. Then she folded it in half and crushed it again.

Finally, once she was out on the street, she tossed it into a drain.

«If you can» she whispered, «go back in time.»

Then, smiling, she hurried off toward the pub.

«Wow, I thought you guys had run off to the tropics» said Bla when he saw Sergio, Teo, and Francesco walk in.

«Yeah, the tropics» said Teo. «With your money we couldn't even make it to *Bargagli*.»

«Especially now that we've invested it.»

«*In-vestiti*» added Francesco, showing off his coat and strutting like a model, earning laughs from a couple of amused hipsters nearby.

Bla didn't dig deeper. If they were in such good spirits, it meant there was no bad news. Not that he regretted writing that check, not exactly, but after sobering up from the buzz he usually took to bed, the thought of having lent out almost all his savings didn't seem quite so brilliant. In fact, the next morning he'd nearly had a panic attack and only resisted canceling the check because Miranda had vouched for them.

«So, guys, what'll it be?»

«For me, a Bloody Mary, sixty percent vodka, if you know what I mean.»

«Eh?!» Bla frowned.

«Sixty percent!» they shouted in unison.

Bla sat down at their table. «In Italian, please.»

«The Chinese invested this afternoon» Sergio whispered. «We made sixty percent profit. Sure, on twenty grand it doesn't change your life, but it's still good money. You sure you don't want in?»

«No, thanks. I'm happy to help, but be careful, okay? The market's tricky, one day it's fine, the next...»

«Relax, your capital's safe» Sergio cut in. «We can pay you back anytime, even tomorrow. The software's automated now, so only our funds are at risk, your money can't vanish, guaranteed. Of course, we plan to pay you back with interest, the best on the market. Naturally, we'd all make more if we could still use your funds, but if you need them tomorrow, no problem. We can even put it in writing.»

«No need for that. So, you're telling me my eight thousand can't disappear?»

«Your nine thousand, actually» said Teo. «They're not going anywhere. Sure, we might wake up tomorrow broke and unable to pay for this beer, but your money's locked up tighter than Fort Knox.»

«Nine thousand» Bla repeated, standing up. «Nine thousand in less than a week. How the hell am I supposed to make you guys pay for drinks tonight? How the hell?»

They burst out laughing.

«So, Radical Chic» Bla said, nodding toward Francesco. «You really want that Bloody Mary?»

«No, no thanks. Let's go with beer tonight, what do you say?»

«Beer.»

«Beer» they echoed.

«Let's make it red, for the occasion?»

«Fine by me.»

«Done.»

«Three pints of bitter, then, and hurry up, the world's ending.»

They laughed again. Bla got busy behind the beer taps, and when he spotted Miranda on the sidewalk, wrapped in tight blue pants that left little to the imagination, a snug green V-neck sweater, and a trench coat draped over her shoulders, he rushed

to the CD player, skipped to track four, set the volume to zero, and hit play.

When Miranda stepped inside, before Francesco or the others even noticed, Bla cranked the volume, and a very young John Travolta exploded from the speakers:

*I got chills, they're multiplying
And I'm losing control
'Cause the power you're supplying
It's electrifying!*

By then, Francesco had jumped to his feet, shrugged off his coat and tossed it just like in the movie, then dropped to one knee, mock-convulsing.

Miranda, delighted, seized the moment, handed her coat to her brother, pushed Francesco to the floor with her foot, and came in perfectly on cue with Olivia Newton-John:

*You better shape up, 'cause I need a man
And my heart is set on you
You better shape up, you better understand
To my heart I must be true!*

Meanwhile, the three hipsters at the next table, one of them obviously gay, leapt off their stools to join in, singing and dancing right on the refrain, which they apparently knew by heart:

*Nothing left, nothing left for me to do
You're the one that I want
You are the one I want
Oo, oo, oo, honey!*

At that point, Miranda couldn't hold back anymore. She pulled Francesco up and kissed him hard, while the three kids faded out the chorus along with Bla, who lowered the volume again. Then everyone burst into applause, for that perfect, unexpected little musical number.

«Dancing with you» she whispered in his ear, «was the last thing I ever expected.»

«I'm good, huh?»

«Oh, sure. John Travolta must be rolling over in some hotel room right now.»

They laughed.

The three hipsters congratulated Bla for the perfect timing and applauded the impromptu dancers, first toward the bar, then toward their table. Francesco, happier than he'd been in ages, shouted to Bla to buy everyone a drink. The three kids thanked them, shaking hands and each giving Miranda a quick kiss before raising their beers to Bla, the best bartender and DJ in town, as they declared. Miranda and the others joined in. It was the first time they'd ever toasted with the enemy.

It took Francesco a good half hour to come down from the adrenaline rush of that scene, and only after the first refill did he manage to update Miranda on the investment's progress.

They staggered out of the bar a couple of hours later, with three pints of red beer behind them, happy, perfectly relaxed, almost younger again. When Miranda and Francesco said goodbye to the others at her front door, Sergio was surprised to realize he no longer felt any hesitation about their relationship. Maybe once he sobered up it would all come back to him, but that night, he didn't feel an ounce of jealousy, only affection.

Once inside Miranda's apartment, with the door closed behind him, Francesco looked around, taking in his friend's sister, his lifelong friend, now his partner, in her own space. He watched her undress, walk barefoot in her underwear, take a

swig of milk straight from the carton and spill it down her chest. He watched her brush her teeth, climb into bed, and beckon him with a gesture, and for the first time in his life, he felt like the luckiest man in the world.

What followed was a wild stretch of time, full of happy hours, laughter, and friendship. No one bothered checking the economic situation, no one cared what the Chinese, or whoever was behind them, were up to. Nobody lifted a finger in that direction. Yet, apart from a few laughable dips, that thin green line kept climbing, almost without interruption, during every trading session.

Maybe the world really was changing. Maybe some kind of collective environmental consciousness was taking shape. Maybe the hipsters were right all along, and all that organic eating, despite the all the Marlboros they smoke, was paying off. Maybe it was fear itself, the fear that bicycles might truly become the most common mode of transport, that forced corporations to rethink their policies on renewables, clean energy, and more hipster-friendly electric engines. Around that time, strange electric charging stations began to pop up downtown, meant for tiny single-seaters that looked more like bumper cars than actual vehicles.

And if even Italy – the first Third World country of the Western world, decaying and dragged to its knees by a political class that only Battiato could describe clearly – was starting, timidly, to move in that direction, it could only mean that out there, in the real world, beyond those borders held up by the faint glue of historical memory, something huge had already happened. The world had already changed, they just didn't know it yet.

What they did know was that when Fiamma and Walter returned from their honeymoon three weeks later, their capital

(even after a ridiculous twenty-six percent tax bite) had nearly quintupled. Now, as the saying went on the stock exchange, they had to decide whether to sell and cry or wait and hope, perfectly aware that in the markets, anything that rises must eventually fall.

They chose a middle road. On December 13th, Fiamma's birthday, they liquidated seventy percent of their shares, keeping just above their initial capital, and decided to pay Bla back that same evening, with a full hundred percent return. With fifty-five thousand euros in hand, they could easily start a joint venture of some kind. Not bad, considering that just a month earlier they'd been flat broke.

Then, unanimously, they decided to delete the automatic selling thresholds and shut down Sergio's computer. They'd leave the remaining thirty thousand invested and try to forget about it, just as they were still trying to forget the whole absurd time-travel episode. They'd check on it again, barring disasters, in about ten years, hoping Tesla would follow the example of Apple from 2001 onward. It would be something, they thought, finding themselves forty but rich. And they promised each other they wouldn't just sit around waiting for that day to come, even if the future didn't seem quite what it used to be.

Only after lunch, as had been his habit for years, did Francesco realize he hadn't yet decided what to get his mother for her birthday, and having all that cash only made things worse. A couple of concert tickets would've been perfect for her sixtieth, if not for the fact that she and Walter had just given him the same gift, and there were no decent shows scheduled for the coming months.

«Guys, I've got a problem» he said.

«December thirteenth...»

«Two-thirty p.m.»

«Punctual as Swiss mail.»

«It's coming...»

«The fear!» the other two chimed in, still giddy from their gains, though they couldn't quite shake the surreal feeling of floating inside a bubble, one that could pop at any moment and fling them back into reality at three hundred kilometers per second.

«Come on, I'm serious.»

«So are we, for that matter.»

«You can't keep waiting until the last minute every year, you realize that?»

«Especially after what just happened.»

«What do you mean?» he asked.

«What do I mean? Did my sister short-circuit your neural receptors or something?»

«She got married, remember? She got married and took us all on a field trip.»

«Holy Christ» said Sergio, waving the bank statement they'd just had printed. «If it hadn't been for Fiamma, we'd be picking out the kind of rope to hang ourselves with right now.»

«And you still haven't thought of anything.»

«Okay, okay... I'm terrible, but I've got extenuating circumstances.»

«Then use them, call her.»

«We're not joining you in another one of your *Amore Tossico*-style gift hunts.»

«You've got extenuating circumstances, make the most of them.»

They laughed.

«By the way» said Teo, «think a little bigger this time.»

«Why? What was wrong with last year's gifts?»

«Last year's fallbacks, you mean.»

«Who even remembers them.»

«This year though» he went on, still waving the statement, «we can afford it.»

«We?» asked Francesco.

«Well, it's the least we can do, considering what she's done for us.»

«We're all pitching in, obviously.»

«You'd better get moving.»

«She's turning sixty this year.»

Francesco picked up his phone to call Miranda.

«Put it on speaker, please» said Sergio.

Francesco gave him a puzzled look.

«Please» Sergio repeated.

So he set the phone down on the coffee table and switched on the speaker.

«December thirteenth, two-thirty p.m. Is it my turn this year?» Miranda answered without even saying hello.

Sergio and Teo collapsed onto the floor, convulsing with laughter.

«God almighty, am I really that predictable?» Francesco asked, after grabbing the phone back.

«No, don't get depressed, love. They trained me.»

«Ah» he sighed in relief. «So... are you busy today?»

«I'm home, actually.»

«At home? How come?»

«I was waiting for your call. Took the day off last month» she laughed.

The expression on his face sent his friends into another fit of hysterics. When he finally left, they were still on the floor beside the couch, each new attempt to stand triggering another round of uncontrollable laughter.

The sun was shining, not a cloud in the sky, and even though it was mid-December, his coat still kept him perfectly warm. It would probably carry him straight through to spring, since real cold hadn't shown up since his high school finals. The hipsters on the street, wrapped in their colorful parkas, were starting to look at him with interest, thanks to the velvet collar and the yellow Ray-Bans. They couldn't quite tell if those stylish touches were meant to spice up otherwise ordinary (if not shabby) clothing, or if they belonged to a trend they hadn't yet caught on to. Some even seemed to give him shy nods of approval, which, out of politeness, he returned, thus reinforcing the second theory. It felt as if the world, in all its absurdity, had finally noticed he existed.

«Hey, you're not ready yet» he said once he'd climbed up to Miranda's apartment.

«Relax» she said, handing him a plastic-wrapped package. «We took care of it this time, early, for once. Hope you don't mind.»

«What's this?» he asked, leaning on the kitchen table to peek inside. «*Hot Rats*?»

«First edition, original, framed and signed by Zappa himself, as you can see.»

«Oh, fuck!» he burst out.

«You like it?»

«It's... it's fantastic, damn. My mother's gonna lose her mind. But how did you get it?»

«Walter put us in touch with a collector friend of his. We just had it framed. Besides the record's value, we figured it was the

perfect way to show Fiamma you've finally gotten over that story.»

«Have I?» he asked, smiling.

«I really hope so» he said, then they kissed.

«By the way, how much is this little stunt setting me back?»

«Setting us back.»

«Okay, how much is it setting us back?»

«A little over a hundred each. Walter's friend gave us a killer deal.»

«Well, I don't know the market value, but that doesn't sound bad at all.»

«Yeah, well... now that it all worked out. When we bought it, it was a bit of a shot in the dark, but we thought, who cares.»

«Wow, Miranda, I don't know...» he stopped mid-sentence.

«You don't know?»

«I don't know what I ever did to deserve you» he smiled. «I love you.»

«I love you too, baby... and I'm really glad your mother went to that concert.»

That afternoon, so was he.

They got to the Blues House early. While Francesco sat at their usual table, Miranda casually slipped a folded bank check to the Bla. He didn't quite catch what was going on, busy pouring a couple of one-liter beers for two kids who clearly didn't fear growing tadpoles in their stomachs, and when he finally opened it to see what it was, he forgot to close the tap.

«Sixteen thousand euros... Is this a joke?»

«The tap!» shouted Francesco.

Miranda was smiling.

«Okay, it's Fiamma's birthday» Bla said, coming out from behind the counter, «but why are you trying to mess with me?»

«The tap!» Francesco said again.

«So what kind of joke is this supposed to be?»

«The tap!» they both yelled together.

«Oh» he said, noticing the blond beer pouring down the bar.

He served the two kids and came back.

«All right» he said, setting the check on the counter, «what am I supposed to do with this?»

«Cash it?» Francesco suggested.

«Cash it?» he echoed.

«Cash it» Miranda confirmed.

That's when he realized they weren't kidding. «So let me get this straight, I lend you eight thousand euros, and after a month you give me back double?»

«Well, things went well.»

«Damn» he grinned, «Christmas really has come early. Now that's good news. What'll it be?»

«Bubbles?» asked Francesco.

«Bubbles» confirmed Miranda.

The Bla pulled out the ice bucket and a bottle of Moët. Not the best, but plenty good for a beer joint.

«By the way, Bla» Miranda added, «Fiamma doesn't know anything about this whole story...»

«O...K...»

«And we'd rather she stayed in the dark for now» Miranda continued.

«No worries, I'll keep my mouth shut» he said. Then they raised their glasses in a toast.

«Sixteen thousand euros» he muttered to himself as he went back behind the counter, «sixteen thousand... that's insane.»

«It's gonna be hard for him to keep quiet, I bet.»

«Relax, Bla's a pro. But why don't you want to tell her? There's nothing wrong with it.»

«No, but I'd rather we figure out exactly what to do with the money first. The shop idea isn't bad, I'm warming up to it, but

there are four of us, kind of a lot to think we can all make a living off one business.»

«You've got to think a little bigger» she smiled.

«You think so?»

«Of course. What's the saying? Shoot for the moon, and if you miss...»

«Yeah, I'll crash into some asteroid instead.»

They laughed.

«Come on, seriously. We don't need to aim for riches right now. I've got a job...»

«Underpaid.»

«True, but it won't be forever. And unlike you three, I don't even pay rent, keep that in mind, in case those two ever drive you crazy.»

Francesco nearly choked on his champagne.

«Are you asking me to move in with you?»

«I'm not asking anything, I'm just stating a fact. Because knowing you, knowing my brother and Teo, I know some things are better said out loud. I don't have your mother's patience, you know. Speaking of which...»

Fiamma walked into the place glowing, wrapped in green flared jeans, a cashmere sweater in the same shade, and a long embroidered coat full of buttons she must've stolen from Jimi Hendrix, or maybe Jack Sparrow. Walter, behind her, was dressed more or less as usual.

Sergio and Teo showed up a few minutes later, still laughing about the afternoon scene.

«So» Sergio asked, «did you find anything decent this year?»

Francesco told him to go to hell, but half-heartedly. His mind was light-years away from that table, that counter, that beer tap, the champagne bucket, and all his friends. He was drifting somewhere in a nameless galaxy, lost in the fog of Uranus, trying to figure out whether that woman, the girl, really, who

even shared a name with one of the planet's moons, had just declared herself willing to live with him.

«Hey, kiddo, you with us?»

«Of course» he came to, «happy birthday, Ma» and hugged her.

«Fiamma» said the Bla, stepping out from behind the counter, «you're more gorgeous every year. Happy birthday.»

«You're such a gentleman» she said. «Careful, one of these days I might even believe you.»

«You should believe me, don't I have a point?» Everyone nodded.

After the greetings, they sat down. Bla brought out two more ice buckets and a couple more bottles so they could all toast together before the real aperitif began. Champagne was fine for the kickoff, but afterward they needed something serious in bigger glasses. Holding a flute didn't even feel like drinking. They weren't hipsters, after all.

Once everyone had settled in and finished their bubbles, they ordered something more fitting, and Fiamma and Walter started talking about their trip, especially the Stones concert, the sheer energy those four still had despite age and excess, going into long details about the setlist, which had slightly disappointed them. They'd have preferred Mick and the others to give more room to the classics instead of newer songs that couldn't hold a candle to their greatest hits. They hadn't even played *Paint It Black*, they said, something that had never happened in all the shows they'd attended. Mick, they joked, half serious, shouldn't have done that to them.

Walter went on about all the places they'd visited in Madrid and Portugal, where they'd stayed in a *quinta*, a room in a stunning manor house surrounded by nature, moving around on a vintage Triumph Bonneville the hosts had at guests' disposal. The motorcycle gave the whole trip the scent of a bygone era,

though Fiamma had to admit she'd lately developed a taste for a certain level of comfort. And at her age, she'd certainly earned it.

Francesco, once he'd recovered from Miranda's earlier jab, listened to his mother's story with a particular calm, a composure he'd never experienced in moments like these. Usually, when she recounted her adventures, glorious or disastrous, he always felt a faint unease. His mother had never really fit the traditional mold of motherhood, and though she'd never truly neglected him, he'd long resented the freedom she gave him, since it demanded responsibilities he hadn't been ready to take on. But now everything felt different. In those three weeks, Fiamma and her husband, because by now Walter really was her husband, had seen the Stones yet again, toured Madrid and almost all of Portugal on a vintage bike, but he, for once, hadn't been idle. He hadn't spent that time curled up on the couch eating cold pizza and gaming. A lot had happened to him, and, delirious stories and coincidences aside, he'd learned to take risks, to the point of realizing that even the most worn-out proverbs, the ones turned into clichés, still hid real truths.

When Fiamma excused herself to go to the restroom, Francesco pulled Walter aside. «Can I ask you a favor? One that should stay between us for now, if you get my drift...»

«Depends» said Walter. «What are we talking about?»

«I'd like you to come with me somewhere tomorrow, nearby. I could use some advice. But I don't want Fiamma to know, I want to surprise her.»

«Okay, I'll die of curiosity till then, but sure. Give me a few more details.»

«The high school on *Via Sturla*, you know it?»

«Sure, that hipster hive. Why, you planning to go back to school?» he laughed.

«No, definitely not. Is three okay for you?»

«Yeah, shouldn't be a problem.»

«Perfect. See you there then. But please...»

«Don't worry» Walter cut him off. «I won't say a word.»

Fiamma came back to the table, picked up her empty glass and handed it to Bla to refill. «Enough chit-chat» she said. «I bet someone here has something for me, right?»

«Mom, you can't just demand your gift like that! What if I hadn't gotten you anything? What if I'd had trouble and couldn't? How do you think I'd feel right now?»

«My, how dramatic you are, son. You know I never expected a Ferrari or anything like that. A daisy plucked from a flowerbed would be a gift fit for a princess if it came from her son's hands.»

Miranda got teary-eyed.

«Okay» said Francesco, taking the package Bla had hidden behind the counter. «From all of us, of course.»

«Now we're talking» joked Fiamma, setting it on the table. «I may be sixty, but I still feel like a kid whenever there's something to unwrap» she added, shooting her husband a playful look.

«Mamma!» exclaimed Francesco.

They laughed.

«Oh my God!» she cried, spotting the cover beneath the bubble wrap. «Oh my God... *Hot Rats*. Original and...»

«Signed» Francesco finished.

«No way. You're kidding me.»

«You really think we'd do that?» said Sergio.

«But it can't be real, Frank Zappa?»

«Frank Zappa» said Miranda with a grin.

Fiamma squeezed her son tight, then hugged everyone else in turn.

«I can't believe it, *Hot Rats*, framed and signed by the man himself! This is the best gift I've ever received, except...»

«Except?!» they all cried together.

«Well, except for my boy» she said, hugging Francesco again. «Because it was during one of his concerts, back in '84, that...»

«Eighty-three» Walter said under his breath.

«Yeah, yeah... Mom, we know the story.»

«Okay» she said, clutching the record to her chest. «He doesn't like me talking about it, I've figured that out by now.»

Miranda pulled Walter aside, she was the only one who'd caught his comment. «What did you mean by that?» she whispered.

«What do you mean, what did I mean?»

Using her empty glass as an excuse, she drew him toward the bar. «Did you say 1983, or did I mishear?»

«I did. Fiamma keeps talking about that concert, it's very important to her, I can tell, but it was '83, not '84. I remember it perfectly. Frank Zappa didn't exactly play in Genoa every day.»

«You were there?»

«Hell yes, front row. Fantastic concert, except for a slightly restless crowd.»

«How so?»

«Well, Frank was tired of playing his more commercial stuff, *Dinah Moe Humm*, *Baby Snakes*, *Camarillo Brillo* and so on. He wanted to improvise, to make music, and a lot of people were disappointed by the performance. Frank sat cross-legged on stage and started these long guitar improvisations on some of his lesser-loved tracks, *King Kong*, *Sofa No.1*, *Peaches En Regalia*... The younger crowd wasn't too thrilled, and things got a little rowdy in the front rows.»

«I wonder how Fiamma managed to conceive in a situation like that.»

Walter laughed. «Well, you have to understand, people our age back then, those of us who'd lived through the seventies, we were trying to hold on to the tail end of that beautiful era...»

«Yeah, I get it, you were all high as kites.»

«Yeah, well... Let's say we were lucky enough to steer clear of heroin, but we still tried to keep Timothy Leary's teachings alive somehow, even though finding good stuff was getting harder and harder. The last acid I ever took was in '84, at an Elvis Costello concert.»

«And after that, nothing?»

«Nothing.»

«Because of the quality?»

«No, not that. I mean, it was getting hard to find decent tabs, but you could still manage. It's just that that day on acid... Come on, let's step outside, I need a smoke.»

«I didn't even know you smoked.»

«Yeah, just one every now and then, not even daily.»

«So why did you quit, because you realized you couldn't keep going around with your brain fried?»

«Oh, no... Look, it's not like people think, or like you probably think. Acid back then was serious stuff. Sure, it was dangerous and could mess you up, but with the right precautions it could show you your place in the Universe, with a capital U. It's hard to explain. And, for the record, I'm only telling you this because I know you're smart enough to take it the right way.»

«Relax, I'm not about to go tripping if that's what's worrying you. I just want to understand better, to help Francesco, you know?»

Walter nodded, taking a long drag.

«So I'm curious about that concert story. Growing up without a father, he's mostly made peace with that. What still bothers

him, I think, is believing his mother hooked up with a complete stranger during a rock concert.»

«A stranger?» Walter smiled. «Who says he was a stranger?»

«Well, that's what she told me.»

«Then she probably told you what she told me, Fiamma never gives two versions of a story.»

«No, of course not, but...»

«She never said she slept with a stranger. She said she met him there, saw him for the first time. Not that he was a stranger.»

«You're kidding me, right?»

«No, I mean, you have to understand, in those conditions perception changes, the senses shift. You can see music, smell words, sense life in an inanimate object, and what you feel is completely real. Okay, I get your skepticism, but those are abilities we all have. Think about instinct, you've met someone you instantly liked or disliked, right?»

«Well, sure.»

«Okay, now imagine what you could sense if your instincts were totally unleashed, like animals, for instance. A dog sniffs you and knows whether it can trust you or not, that kind of thing.»

«So she would've sensed someone's energy, let's call it that, and realized that was the right person for her.»

«Exactly.»

«And that story about the time travel, seeing herself in the future with a husband and a kid?»

«Well» he smiled, «who knows. It's still a drug, after all. Heightened senses aside, I can't deny she might've been...»

«Tripping balls?»

They laughed.

«So tell me, has something like that ever happened to you?»

«I mean, picking someone up at a concert? Well» he said, glancing inside, «always... even at that Subsonica gig, thank God» he smiled, «but back then it was different, you know? We didn't overthink things, if you liked someone, you just told them, and if they felt the same, that was it. No taboos, no fears. You know what I mean.»

Miranda nodded. «No, I meant something like what happened to Fiamma, a perfect meeting of souls.»

«Well, aside from Subsonica, where I was perfectly sober, by the way, once I did experience something like that, but sadly, my memories of that amazing night are a bit fuzzy.»

«What happened?»

«Good question» he said, checking again to make sure Fiamma wasn't coming. «You know, I never told her about it. I didn't want to make her jealous or spoil her memory of that concert by saying something similar had happened to me too, even though I barely remember anything, just a few sensations.»

«You didn't happen to take a little trip to the future too, did you?»

«No, nothing like that. Just... once I had this feeling that I'd met someone important. Not in the biblical sense, at least, I don't remember that part. Actually, I don't remember anything.»

«Wow, you guys really went hard on the tabs.»

Walter tried to smile. It was clear that, somehow, he still hadn't quite digested that story.

«So what happened after?» Miranda pressed.

«Nothing. The next morning I found the concert ticket in my pocket, the one where we must have met. There was a phone number scribbled on it, and it wasn't my handwriting.»

«You didn't call?»

«Are you kidding? Of course I did, but the number didn't exist.»

«Oh, man! So you never found out if she gave you the wrong one on purpose or not.»

«Exactly» he said, stepping back inside, «but luckily, it doesn't matter anymore.»

«No, of course not.»

At the bar, Fiamma was trying to convince Bla to change the CD in the player and turn up the volume. He kept stalling, teasing her by brushing his finger over the play button without pressing it, dragging out the suspense before kicking off the party.

It was Fiamma's birthday, and everyone adored her, especially Bla, who had just made around eight thousand euros without lifting a finger, and was already deep into the Belvedere bottle. So when he finally hit play on the mix he'd made for the occasion, the speakers nearly exploded under the opening synths of *Tainted Love*.

Sure, Fiamma would've preferred something rougher and more distorted, but for dancing, the «70s and «80s were unbeatable. Everyone got up from their tables, even the hipsters, and threw themselves into the past with cheerful clumsiness. From the outside, apart from the two women and the gay hipster, they looked more like the zombies from *Thriller* than Tony Manero or Danny Zuko, but nobody cared.

It was the first time the three of them had jumped up to dance together, even mingling with the hipsters, who suddenly seemed almost like regular people, more so than Francesco at least, who had been wearing sunglasses for a month (yellow ones, granted) and still hadn't taken off his coat.

By half past eleven, they all looked like they'd just finished the New York Marathon. Bla had been going hard, avoiding every slow song, but by the end of *YMCA*, everyone's tongues were hanging out, except Fiamma, Miranda, and the hipster with the colorful socks. For them, dancing was effortless, like

breathing, while for the others it felt more like a P.E. exam: fun and exhausting at once.

Fiamma couldn't remember ever dancing with her son before.

Walter arrived right on time, heralded by the thunder rolling out of the exhaust pipes of a vintage Triumph Bonneville with foreign plates.

Francesco circled around him as he parked. «Let me guess, you bought the bike you rode through Portugal?»

«Deep down, I'm a romantic, I know» he said, pulling off his helmet.

«And you had it shipped here?»

«Well, of course. It's a beautiful bike, but it's still a damn beast. No way I'd ride two thousand kilometers on it, especially with your mom on the back.»

They both laughed.

«Yeah, I figured she wasn't too fond of two wheels.»

«No, not really, but with Fiamma, you never know.»

Francesco nodded.

«So» Walter went on, «what are we doing here?»

Francesco told him everything that had happened while he was away, how they'd decided to invest in Tesla stock on a friend's advice, how Bla had lent them the money, and how much they'd made in such a short time. He left out the more delirious parts, the string of absurd coincidences that even Walter might've teased him for.

«Wow» Walter said when he finished. «I never would've guessed you two would start playing the market, and with those returns! You've been blessed by some market god, seriously. You have no idea how many people get eaten alive by the stock exchange every day.»

«Yeah, we got really lucky, and now we'd like to invest.»

«O...K...»

«Relax, not in the market.»

Walter exhaled in relief. «Good. You had me worried there for a second.»

«With stocks, we're done» he said, carefully omitting the fact that some money was still tied up. «We were thinking of opening a shop, just like you once suggested.»

«Well, that was just a wild guess on my part, I'm hardly an expert in the field. How could I help you?»

«I want to show you a place.» He pointed at the old furniture store a few meters ahead. «It's for rent. I've got an appointment with the real estate agent in about ten minutes. I'd like your opinion, I have a feeling it's a bit too big for what we have in mind.»

«It was a furniture store, so I doubt it's small. But can you really afford rent in this area?»

«It's been empty for ages. The owner's offering a good deal for the first years, then we'd renegotiate.»

The agent arrived on a bicycle. They saw him coming from the end of *Via Sturla*, a slim guy in a dark blue fitted suit, cropped trousers, a thick beard, and a trendy shoulder bag. Only when he got close did they recognize him as the gay guy who'd danced all night with Fiamma and Miranda. He, on the other hand, had recognized them right away, which explained the high-definition smile he wore as he stopped.

«Hi» he said. «You're my three o'clock, right?»

«In the flesh.»

«Wow, small world, especially in Genoa» he laughed. «Anyway, I'm Giacomo.»

«Francesco, nice to meet you» he said, shaking his hand.

«Yeah, I know. And Walter, right?»

«Exactly.»

«You're Bla's friends. He talks about you all the time, you're kind of famous.» He smiled.

Famous. That, Francesco hadn't expected, but he let it slide.

«Come on, I'll show you the place. The issue with this property» he said, unlocking the electric shutter, «is the size. It's one huge open space with just a bathroom. That's probably why it's still on the market. Not many people open furniture stores these days.»

The place really was enormous, four shops could have fit inside it, but, strangely, the rent was only slightly higher than that of any average commercial space. It had been vacant too long. The floors, a dark brown acid-stained concrete, gleamed faintly, the walls were white, and three big display windows opened onto the street, where hundreds of hipsters passed by every day on their way to school. It was almost too good to be true, though neither Francesco nor his friends had any idea how to furnish such a vast space without burning through all the money they'd miraculously made.

Walter walked the place from end to end. He checked the electrical wiring, the heating system, asked to have all three shutters opened to test the light, and was surprised to find a small bathroom, tiny but complete with bidet and shower. The systems seemed up to code, the shutters only needed cleaning and oiling, and the walls, save for a few mold stains from poor ventilation, could almost get away without a fresh coat of paint.

«What do you think?» Francesco asked.

«It's in good shape and...»

«Massive.»

«Yeah, massive.»

Giacomo had stepped aside to take a phone call.

«And the rent? What kind of figure are we talking about?»

«Shouldn't be more than eight hundred.»

«You sure?»

«Of course. It's a tough market.»

«Okay, then what are you waiting for?»

«Well, come on, how the hell are we supposed to furnish a place like this? It's not about buying a counter and a few shelves, we'd have to fill, what, how much would you say?»

«Four hundred square meters at least.»

«Exactly! Filling four hundred square meters isn't a joke, we're not opening a car dealership.»

«Hey» Walter said, putting a hand on his shoulders, «Fiamma and I will help you.»

«What do you mean?»

«Don't worry about it. Call your friends, and if they're in, sign. But one thing.»

«Which is?»

«I don't want to keep Fiamma in the dark, she could give you tons of great ideas. I've already got a few myself.»

«Then shoot.»

«Not here» he said, glancing toward Giacomo, still on the phone with a client. «We'll talk later, calmly.»

They decided to take their time. Giacomo promised he wouldn't let anyone else sign before calling them the next day. The place had been empty for so long that there was no risk of a waiting line.

Once outside, after Giacomo pedaled off on his bike, Walter explained why, in his opinion, the place had enormous potential. In an open space like that, they could build a huge movable counter on wheels, easy to shift around and reshape week after week. The shop could constantly reinvent itself, looking new every time.

Inside, they could carve out cozy corners, a reading nook, a mini living room, all minimalistic and assembled from reclaimed pieces. A single armchair and a lamp beside a stand with an electric guitar could already make up a storefront

display. They could even do something weird, like put a bed in the middle of the room and use it to display T-shirts, things like that. With all that space, they could even sell surfboards if they wanted.

All that room wasn't a problem at all, it was a resource. Something to unleash imagination on.

«And besides» Walter said as he climbed back onto the bike, «with a place like that I could even save on garage rent.»

«What do you mean?» Francesco asked, trying to raise his voice over the roar of the engine.

«Well, imagine how good this baby would look» he said, patting the tank repeatedly, «parked in there next to the Volkswagen, you could use that as a wardrobe.»

And off he went, leaving Francesco on the sidewalk, picturing a shop like that, completely out of line for a city like his.

After signing the lease, finding a reliable accountant, a contradiction in terms, and opening a VAT account, an explosive week began. Walter had opened the doors of perception, so to speak, and the possibilities for how to use the space, and the shop itself, were expanding wildly, along with the growing number of quotes arriving in the inbox of the newborn *Radical Choc sas*.

Fifty-five thousand euros, as much as they might seem to someone who didn't have them, didn't actually buy all that much in the end.

Francesco designed a logo that could serve both as a mural for the shop's interior and for the sign and business cards, taking inspiration from a poster made by a musician friend who had moved to Fuerteventura. Thanks to the internet, he still kept them updated on his gigs, though the four of them were hardly about to hop on a plane to attend a jazz concert. Normally Francesco wasn't one to copy, especially for work, but the color palette of that flyer had struck him immediately: a red circle, which he turned into a vinyl record, on a dark gray, almost black rectangle, shifted slightly upward, with gray text below it in classic Arial Black, overlapping the lower part of the vinyl:

RADICAL CHOC

hipster, quanti & rock and roll

Simple and effective, because, as Francesco often told himself when working, the most elegant things are the least

flashy. In fact, it looked more like the cover of a book, but it perfectly captured the spirit of what they wanted to do.

Hipsters were their target clientele, the group they were slowly approaching, partly for business, partly as a cover, and partly for reasons still unclear. Their reputation in that circle was growing dangerously fast: partly thanks to Giacomo, who had probably told people what they were up to, partly due to the antics they'd pulled at Blues House, and partly because of Miranda's constant presence, she was impossible to overlook. Not to mention what Bla was cooking up at the bar right then, without them having the slightest clue.

Quanti was simply a tribute to what had happened to them, to that still half-digested, absurd chain of coincidences that had, for a moment, led Francesco to believe he had traveled, or could travel (the grammar was always the tricky part), through time.

Rock and roll, meanwhile, though by now a term even hipsters used loosely, meant everything, it wasn't just a kind of music, but a cry, an attitude, depending on the tone and context. Its roots went far deeper than rolled-up trousers and checkered shirts. The logo was simple yet ambiguous enough, not to reveal the nature of the store too soon, but to wink at the audience and spark curiosity.

Fiamma had been told, and Francesco had agreed. It was impossible to keep everything secret until the grand opening. Proud as ever, she convinced Walter to step back. He had already contributed, the van, the motorbike, but she didn't want him to help directly with the work or the setup. She didn't want to interfere, unless explicitly asked, in what had to remain their project. She wanted Francesco and his friends to be as proud of themselves as she was of them.

Even Sergio and Miranda's father, once updated by his daughter, found himself detouring from his route home from the office, steering his massive Mercedes liner slowly past the shop

windows, now covered with newspaper, to discreetly observe the progress of that unexpected entrepreneurial venture. It wasn't exactly what he had dreamed of for his son, but it was certainly better than imagining him sprawled on the couch with a joystick in hand or, worse, reading Schopenhauer with a highlighter in reach. Something Sergio, incidentally, had never done.

They had skipped their evening aperitifs for a week, working hard to clean, sand, and repaint the shutters and the big windows, restoring the aluminum frames to their former glory. They filled and repainted an indeterminate number of square meters of wall space, burning through seventy kilos of paint diluted to forty percent, blessing fervently whoever had once thought to install a shower in the shop's bathroom.

They spent the last three nights there, sleeping in sleeping bags despite the stench of paint that, according to the label, was supposed to be odorless. And when at last, late on a Friday evening, exhausted but content, they peeled off the newspaper and plastic sheets protecting the floor, they realized they had somehow worked their way right up to Christmas Eve.

A holiday none of them truly celebrated, but one that, nonetheless, demanded a toast.

As they trudged up *Via Caprera*, crossing the *Sturla* bridge, dragging their feet from exhaustion, they sensed something odd in the air, something beyond the faint trace of Christmas spirit they hadn't even noticed.

The kids coming down the hill, on skateboards, bikes, or on foot, were looking at them strangely. Friendly, but strangely. Some raised two fingers in greeting, others gestured in odd but cordial ways, and one guy with a thick beard, blue eyes, and tattoos all over seemed to even mouth Frank's and Miranda's names, nodding as he passed without stopping.

«O...K...» Teo drawled, stopping halfway across the bridge.
«Is this happening to you too, or is it just me?»

«That guy called you by name, do you know him?»

«Me? No...» said Francesco. «Maybe I've seen him at the Blues, but I'm not sure. Hipsters all look the same. We've definitely never been introduced.»

«Yeah, but it wasn't just him» Teo went on. «Don't you get the feeling everyone's kind of... greeting us?»

«Well, it's Christmas. Even hipsters must get nicer this time of year.»

«Sure, served with potatoes and rosemary.»

«Maybe we've inhaled too many paint these past days?»

They laughed.

«What do you think, Miranda?» Teo asked.

«I don't know, guys. I've never exactly had the gift of invisibility» she said drily, resuming her walk. «People look and say hi to me all the time, more often than I'd like, holidays or not.»

«Yeah, yeah... You've got boobs, we know.»

They kept walking. Beyond the bridge, things, so to speak, got worse. It was as if everyone they passed made a point of greeting them somehow: a nod, a glance, a small wave. Some, emboldened by alcohol, even wished them Merry Christmas. Until finally, almost at their destination, Miranda noticed it too.

«Okay, this is absolutely not normal. I'll give you that.»

«Jesus, I feel like in *The Truman Show*. This is kind of creepy.»

They quickened their pace, pushed through the crowd of rolled-up trousers outside the bar, and, with the same eerie feeling, took refuge inside the Blues House. The few patrons at the tables instinctively turned toward the door and, after recognizing them, rose to greet them one by one, led by Bla's

welcoming shout from behind the counter, wearing, of course, his classic red-and-white Santa hat.

Fine, Giacomo was there too, but who the hell was all the rest of this crowd? And why did they all suddenly seem like friends? It's not like they'd just won the lottery.

«Now it all makes sense» Miranda said, staring at the table where they usually sat.

«So it's all Bla's fault» Teo said, walking closer. «Still, that's awesome.»

The center of the wooden table had been hollowed out and fitted with a brass plaque that read:

*Reserved for life to:
Frank, Miranda, Sergio & Teo*

«I didn't know how else to thank you» said Bla. «Your table's been waiting for a week, but I figured tonight you couldn't possibly miss it. Merry Christmas, guys.»

«Merry Christmas, Bla.» Miranda hugged him.

«Oh, man... I've always wanted to have my own table» said Francesco, once the mystery was solved. «So this is all your fault.»

«What do you mean?»

«Everyone was greeting us on the way up, or at least it seemed that way.»

«And you're not used to that, huh?» Bla laughed.

«Well, no. Of course not.»

«Yeah, I guess I made you a little famous. Everyone's been asking me about you this week. I didn't tell them why, obviously, but I had to explain more or less who you are. Now» he added in a lower voice, «the hipsters are desperate to get their own table too.»

«Well done, you've shot yourself in the foot.»

«Yeah, well... they'll realize soon enough this isn't a privilege for everyone. Hope you don't mind, guys.»

«Are you kidding?» Teo said. «Why would we mind? We'd have gone nuts if we hadn't figured it out.»

They laughed.

«Actually» Miranda added, «it'll give us great publicity.»

«Well, Giacomo already took care of that. He told everyone you're opening this huge, super-stylish store, his exact words. People keep asking me when the grand opening is. Do you have a date yet?»

«No, not yet. We've only painted and cleaned so far. We still have to furnish it, and decide what we're even selling.»

«Wait, you don't know what you want to sell yet?»

«Well, no» they glanced at each other, «we've got a lot of ideas, sure, but nothing concrete for now.»

«You know, that's... that's a very, very complicated decision, Bla. Lots of input, lots of output...»

«Yeah, luckily we maintain a strict aperitif regime, to keep the mind, let's say, flexible.»

They laughed.

Bla didn't catch the reference.

«Don't worry» Miranda said. «We'll update you soon.»

«I hope so, people are getting curious. There's *panettone* on the counter. What'll you have to drink, beer?»

«Yes, please. Red for me, given the occasion» said Teo.

«Red.»

«Same.»

Francesco nodded. «How come in English?» he asked, sitting down.

«It's cooler, isn't it?»

They all laughed.

The red beer, helped along by the adrenaline of suddenly finding themselves famous, dulled a bit of the exhaustion they'd

arrived with, but after the second round, with no real protein intake to speak of, fatigue came back to collect its dues. So, after trying (and failing) to pay for their drinks, the four of them headed out again, taking a good ten minutes to get through the wall of hipsters eager to connect with those four weird but so-cool guys who skipped the bill and had a table reserved for life.

The dream of every customer.

Francesco was exhausted, wrecked, dreaming of collapsing on a real mattress. Yet the thought of being away from Miranda, after three nights of holding hands from one sleeping bag to another, gave him a strange sense of unease. He could have gone to sleep at her place, as he often did, but that wouldn't have eased the need that, perhaps fueled by sheer physical fatigue, now felt more urgent than ever. So, once they reached her building, he asked her to wait a few minutes. Miranda sat on the steps, telling him to hurry.

Inside the apartment, without wasting words, he grabbed *Apocalypse Now* and nodded goodbye to his friends.

«Today is the day?» asked Teo.

«Tonight, rather» said Sergio. «So our boy's leaving us, abandoning us» he pretended to sob, «after all we've done for him, on Christmas night of all times.»

«The sacrifices we made to get him through school» Teo joined in, «to put a roof over his head, to raise him right and God-fearing.»

«God-fearing, really?» Francesco asked from the doorway.

«Well... yeah» Teo corrected himself, yawning. «Man, I'm dead tired. See you tomorrow at the shop?»

«Of course, what kind of question is that?»

«Remember» said Sergio, hugging him carefully to avoid crushing *Apocalypse Now*, «she's my sister, you know?»

«I know...»

«No, I mean, you know what I'd have to do to you if you ever hurt her?» He grinned.

«That won't happen. You have my word.»

«Good. Now get out of here, you don't expect actual tears, do you?»

«Not even a couple?»

«You're moving three hundred meters away, without a change of clothes, carrying a chili plant. See you tomorrow, idiot.»

«Just hope you find your underwear» Teo added, practically shoving him out the door.

«By the way» Francesco said from the landing.

«What?» they both replied in chorus.

«Merry Christmas, guys.»

«Merry Christmas to you too, you little dweeb» they answered, smiling before closing the door.

Francesco bounded down the stairs two at a time, thrilled by his own spontaneous decision, instinctive, unplanned, but halfway through the last flight he was seized by a sudden fear that he'd misread Miranda's invitation. It had been a while, not long, but long enough, and she hadn't repeated the offer. He picked up his pace, nearly tripping, trying to outrun the panic that was about to freeze him on the landing. When Miranda turned at the sound of his footsteps and saw Apocalypse Now in his hands, she rose from the steps and stood still by the doorway. He stopped too, halfway across the hall, searching her face for a sign, a glance, a flicker, something that could either send him into orbit or bury him alive.

They stood frozen for a couple of seconds, maybe less, but to Francesco it felt like an eternity. And when he caught sight of a tear tracing down her cheek, he felt as if he were being born again.

Miranda opened the door, and he, slowly, without breaking eye contact, stepped out, *Apocalypse Now* held in both hands. She took his arm, and without saying a word, they walked quietly home.

By February, the shop was starting to take shape.

They'd parked the Volkswagen diagonally at the back of the space, where it would stay with its rear doors open, between them, hangers for T-shirts. On the wall behind the van, perfectly visible through the front windows, they had a Fine Arts student paint their logo. The Bonneville was parked on the opposite side of the shop, positioned so it could always be seen from the street but remained, along with the van, behind the counter line, which of course couldn't span the full width of the store.

Near one of the two big windows, they'd set up a kind of lounge area with a pair of faux-Spitfire armchairs scavenged from flea markets, a small tea table, and a Flos *Toio* lamp. Regulars would become part of the décor themselves, living mannequins unknowingly contributing, for free, to the aesthetic of that oversized space.

To greet customers, they'd splurged on eBay for an old bar counter, massive larch wood, about four meters long, with a beautiful brass footrail running its full length and matching stools. The fridges had been gutted to make shelving, and on the underside, perfectly flush with the front profile, Sergio and Teo had mounted eight industrial Teflon wheels. Once unlocked, the beast could be rolled across the shop with no effort. They did the same for all the cabinets and shelving meant to hold merchandise.

Even the exterior sign, with its faint retro flavor so beloved by hipsters, was ready to be installed. But something was still missing, something to fill that vast space, despite the two large sofas facing each other beside a bookshelf soon to overflow with

alternative editions, all newly reupholstered by a tailor in rich, multicolored fabrics. Even the fully functional, utterly vintage pinball machine, which alone had cost over a thousand euros, wasn't enough to complete it.

Despite the movable rectangular partition, five by four meters and two meters high, complete with a sliding door, which they had wallpapered with a collage of original Woody Allen movie posters to hide from view a sort of annex with a sofa bed. Despite a desk and a small printing lab. Despite the little rainforest Francesco had created against one of the load-bearing columns in the middle of the place, plundering a nursery inland, and despite the thirty or so small chili plants, similar but not belonging to the Apocalypse Now family, which he had scattered everywhere, trying to create a thread connecting all those different styles.

Maybe, once the shelves were full and customers were wandering around browsing, that feeling of emptiness would disappear, but it was still too soon to tell.

Every day after school, a crowd of hipsters gathered at the bus stop right in front of the entrance, trying to peek inside through the slits left in strategic spots among the newspaper sheets, to see how far along the setup was. A store like that had never been seen in Genoa, not of that size, nor furnished in that way. The Bla was literally flooded with inquiries, and even on the few evenings when they had enough energy to allow themselves an aperitif, they were bombarded with questions. By now everyone knew them and called them by name, while in more distant neighborhoods, in hipster bars and hangouts they hadn't even heard of, someone had begun talking about a strange character who roamed the streets at night wearing an odd coat, '70s sunglasses, and holding a chili plant in his hand. Sergio and Teo were amused by all that attention, Miranda didn't even notice it, being used to it as a woman, while

Francesco, at times, was even frightened. Sure, the glasses and the coat gave him an unusual look, but he couldn't believe that all youth had become so shallow as to have nothing better to do than debate other people's outfits. Although, come to think of it, even they hadn't done much else for quite some time. They were enjoying a brief wave of popularity that wouldn't sustain itself for long, they had to open as soon as possible to ride that unexpected and profitable wave.

So they threw themselves into it, almost nonstop.

They even patented the idea for that absurd hollow log that hipsters could use to amplify their phones' audio without electronics, and they registered a new logo to attribute its authorship to a fictional, world-famous American company: 3BeCa Audio Research. Famous judging by the fake websites Francesco was putting together at night, to be launched at the right time, that is, only after deciding who would handle production and signing a confidentiality agreement. Francesco and Sergio had taken charge of seizing Walter and Fiamma's T-shirt collections, scanning each one to produce perfect replicas, then used a selection of the originals to decorate the store, having custom square frames made of molded Plexiglas that would encase each shirt as if frozen in a block of ice. They had found a very competitive company in southern Piedmont to produce the brass plates that would display the logo of 3BeCa Audio Research, the name hipsters around the world were going crazy for, according to the press releases Francesco already had saved like obituaries on his hard drive.

Miranda had handled the legal side of every single project, driving herself insane trying to make sure they couldn't be dragged to court. Sergio, in fact, had come up with another brilliant idea to tap into hipster bank accounts: producing prints and T-shirts deliberately wrong, like the ABBA logo with the faces of Ricchi e Poveri, Andy Warhol's soup can attributed to

Keith Haring, the Blur logo under the Gallagher brothers' faces, Star Wars written in the Star Trek font, and other gems of that sort that would surely send the trendiest ones into orbit. And although Miranda believed she had made almost every aspect of their soon-to-open business, which they hoped to launch by the end of March, legally airtight, that was still the only part shrouded in uncertainty. They might be able to protect themselves by invoking an old law from the 1930s that allowed street vendors to sell items of their own making. Maybe they could even produce those T-shirts right in the shop, packaging them with a detailed explanation of their obvious irony, irony probably lost on the subjects involved, but sooner or later, they'd have to face some kind of legal trouble. The key thing was to estimate in advance how serious it might be, since beyond the damage, such a lawsuit could also give them publicity.

In the end, they decided to take the risk. They would produce a small batch of the *Wrong Ones*, that's what they called them, and Francesco had to rack his brains for yet another logo, which they would print only on the inside, on the washing label. They wouldn't display them directly, they would keep them safe inside the Volkswagen, for sale, certainly, but only to those who knew of their existence. And Miranda already had a few ideas about that.

At the beginning of March, the first deliveries began to arrive. Teo had found a knitwear manufacturer in Vicenza producing high-quality cotton with professional four-color printing, and Miranda had signed a couple of consignment agreements with small artisans making eco-sustainable home décor, lamps, ornaments, and small furniture, a godsend for hipsters. They also spent a fortune on a multicolored assortment of Tivoli radios.

Only a production deal for those wooden logs that had started it all was still missing when a black ocean liner pulled up at the bus stop in front of their shop window, surrounded as usual by curious hipsters. Miranda, Sergio, and Teo were arranging the merchandise on the shelves, trying to create the best visual impact, while Francesco, acoustically sealed off by a pair of large headphones, was working in the back room on the final touches of the store's website and all the satellite fakes. He didn't notice someone knocking at the door.

«Yes?» said Miranda, opening it, ready to repeat the same spiel for the umpteenth time. She still didn't know exactly when the store would open, though it wasn't far off, but she froze, smiling, when she saw her father standing there. «Dad» she said, «what are you doing here?»

«I was curious. May I come in?»

«Of course» she said, closing the door behind him.

«Counselor» Teo greeted him from the top of a ladder.

«Hello, Teo» he replied.

Sergio, frozen like a statue of salt, couldn't utter a word.

«Could you give us five minutes, Teo?» asked the lawyer.

«Of course» he said, climbing down. «I was just about to grab a *chinotto*. Want anything?» And he was out before they could answer, immediately swallowed by the mass of hipsters who no longer seemed to know whether they were waiting for the bus or for them.

The lawyer took a few steps, looking around.

«It's very big» he said.

«Yeah, maybe a bit too big.»

Sergio didn't move.

«And that pinball machine, does it actually work?»

«Of course» Miranda replied. «Want to play a game?»

The lawyer smiled. «Another time, gladly. Truth is, I came to talk to you» he said, pointing at Sergio.

«Should I go have a *chinotto* too?» Miranda asked.

He laughed. «No, of course not, my love. We're a family.»

«We are? Really?» said Sergio, coming back to life.

«Of course we are. I know you're angry with me, and you've every right to be. But one day you'll understand that parents make mistakes too, sometimes for good reasons, but still, mistakes. Granted» he said, gesturing at the vast store around him, «this isn't exactly what I'd hoped for you. I can't deny that. Just as that bizarre degree of yours wasn't either, so to speak.»

«Sorry, what's bizarre about philosophy? About the search for the meaning of life?» he shot back.

«Oh, come on, don't tease me. What meaning of life? You wanted to challenge me, picking the one field you knew would lead you nowhere. You didn't want to study law, I can understand that, especially now, after nearly three years of therapy, but you could've studied anything else. With your brain, you could've excelled at anything...»

«Therapy? You've been in therapy?»

Even Miranda was stunned.

«For almost three years, son. I couldn't risk losing you without trying everything.»

«And listening to me wouldn't have been enough?»

«Hey, I'm not perfect, I know that. At least more than before. It wasn't easy, you know, getting here cost me quite a bit, even financially» he smiled. «People talk badly about lawyers, but shrinks aren't exactly cheap either.»

«I'm sure you didn't just pick one at random.»

«No, of course not. I did my research and went to the best. Sorry, but that's how I am. I've always been that way. I work from morning till night, I earn obscenely well, I can't complain, I'd be a hypocrite, and I always wanted you to have everything I had. Okay, maybe it didn't mean as much to you as it did to me, I'm only now starting to realize that. But you should try to

understand where I come from. My background's very different from yours. I struggled, sweated through more than seven shirts, risked real hunger, but in the end, I was rewarded.»

«Yes, I know. I've heard the story.»

«Yeah...» he admitted. «I've passed by here often these days, on my way home, and I've seen you working hard» he went on after a long pause. «You've committed yourself, you're building something, and I respect that. I just wanted you to know, that's all.»

«We're doing it all together.»

«Of course, I know. But I'm talking to you. I know perfectly well your friends are your real family, your friends and your sister, thank heaven for her at least» he muttered, «don't think I don't know that, or that I'm not jealous of it» he smiled. «I'm glad you have people who care about you. In that sense, I've got everything to learn.»

Teo came back in. «So, Counselor, what do you say, should I grab a soda too?»

«No» he smiled, «I've said what I needed to say.»

«Good» said Teo. «My stomach's already like a balloon.»

When Francesco took off his headphones, he heard someone in the store and went to see. «Hello, Counselor» he said after a moment of surprise.

«Hello, Francesco. I didn't know you were here.»

«No, me neither. I mean, I didn't know you were here. I knew I was here.» And he stopped. The lawyer had always intimidated him, and now that, besides being the lawyer, he was also his girlfriend's father, things were even worse.

The lawyer managed a polite little smile that, after a few seconds, turned into something like a laugh, an odd sight, given his character. He came closer, cleaning his glasses to get a better look at him, and when he was near enough, he lost that stiffness of movement many mistook for elegance.

«But those are Ricchi e Poveri, not ABBA.»

Miranda had thought of having everyone wear those T-shirts while they were working so passersby could see them, and she'd asked the Bla to wear one too. A marketing strategy as simple as it was effective. If they weren't afraid of possible legal repercussions they would have handed a few to the most prominent people in town in the hope that someone would feel like wearing them.

The lawyer couldn't recognize the Gallagher brothers under the Blur logo, nor the famous Unknown Pleasure cover of Joy Division under the word Nirvana, nor the profile of Le Iene topped by Harvey Keitel in place of the Blues Brothers, but he knew Ricchi e Poveri and ABBA well.

«You did this on purpose, it's... it's brilliant» he said, amused.

«We did a bunch of these, want to see them?»

«Certainly.»

Miranda and Teo showed him all of them, most had to be explained to him, but some were perfectly understandable to any age, like the one with the Rolling Stones tongue under the word Beatles. The lawyer seemed genuinely entertained while Sergio and Francesco watched the scene in disbelief from a safe distance.

«I'm proud of you, kids» he said, words that left Sergio even more stunned. Never in his life had he heard his father say anything like that, «I absolutely want one with Ricchi e Poveri, white with a V-neck, is that possible?»

«Uh» said Miranda, looking for the others' approval, «I think so...»

«Hey, I didn't mean for free, I'll pay for it. I'd like to be your first customer, and besides, I need that T-shirt» he smiled, «their lawyer's a good friend of mine, next Saturday we play golf together. Wearing that will be hilarious.»

«The Ricchi e Poveri?» Francesco asked.

«Of course.»

«No, Dad» Miranda said, «look, we don't yet know whether circulating these shirts is legally safe.»

«You're not actually afraid someone might sue you, are you?» he said, rummaging through the pile for a shirt in his size, as if the store belonged to him.

«Well, yes, we're afraid.»

«Here, this one's perfect, XL, white, V-neck.»

«Dad, you're not listening. We can't do that.»

«Like what?»

«Like a lawsuit, these people, apart from Ricchi e Poveri, are global rock stars, they'd crush us.»

«They'd make you famous, you mean.»

«Poor for sure, famous... I wouldn't bet on it.»

«Don't worry, sweetheart» he said, stroking her face, «if it comes to that you'll have the best lawyers available, okay?»

«So you'd and your partners provide us with pro bono legal help?»

«Of course, what question is that? I'm your father.»

«Yes, but maybe you still don't get the point» she said, taking a T-shirt, «this one's Lady Gaga, okay? Maybe you don't know her, but she's one of the highest-paid pop stars right now, and we wrote Madonna on it. Do you see the level we're playing at?»

«Yeah, maybe I messed up» he said.

«Right...»

«Maybe I was wrong to send you to do your traineeship at another firm. I thought it was right to cut the cord a bit, but I see my colleagues didn't live up to my expectations.»

«No one ever has, Dad. No one.»

«Yes, you're right, I'll concede that. But back to us» he said, snatching the T-shirt from her hands. «This one you call Lady...»

«Gaga.»

«Lady Gaga, right... To me it looks like a simple monochrome print of an indeterminate model with a kind of bizarre wig, and the word Madonna, well, that could refer to anything, especially in this country.»

«They're legal loopholes, Dad. The intentions are obvious.»

«The law's all loopholes, we're in Italy, there are workarounds for everything, even the worst crimes, the point is having the means to use them.»

«We live in a shitty country, okay, but I don't want to discuss this now.»

«Neither do I, darling» he smiled, «neither do I. What I want to say, seriously, is that I like this idea of yours. And, as you and your brother will know, I haven't often said that. I like it, I like what you're doing, and I offer you my support.»

«See, Counselor» said Teo, «what perhaps your daughter can't express is the fear that you and your partners might be harmed by this.»

This time the lawyer laughed heartily. «Okay, I take note of that, but if you think I'll be intimidated by some rich twit I'm on the wrong side of town. That washed-out singer, the one accused of pedophilia, didn't we kick his ass?»

«Michael Jackson?!»

«Exactly, I can't remember the name.»

«You handled Albano's case?»

«*I cigni di baccalà?*» Francesco lapsed, but the lawyer took it as a joke and laughed.

«*I cigni di baccalà*, exactly... what a piece of work.»

«We blackened him, I mean: we made him look black. Can you say that?» he asked with an ungainly, politically incorrect

grin. «So relax and go on as if there's no tomorrow. We kept that, what's his name?»

«Michael Jackson.»

«Michael Jackson, right... And if necessary, we'll kick Madonna's ass too, Lady Madonna.»

«I can try...» Francesco couldn't help himself.

«With a little help from my friends» the lawyer replied with a smile. He'd always liked Battiato, even if he'd never told anyone, not even his analyst. «So» he concluded, folding the T-shirt, «how much do I owe you?»

Miranda looked around, trying to decide whether to accept the risk and really go ahead as he'd said: as if there were no tomorrow. Teo, lightly twirling his palms, made it clear that if it was fine with the Lawyer it was fine with him too. Sergio abstained, too stunned by that sudden change to react. He and his father hadn't spoken in years, and even when they had, he didn't remember ever hearing him laugh or express himself like that. Never in a million years would he have believed him capable of such a radical shift in perspective. More than a shrink, his must be a magician.

Francesco nodded, trying not to open his mouth.

«Okay, then» Miranda said, «one T-shirt in exchange for possible future legal assistance. Doesn't seem like you've made a great deal.»

«You must be joking» he said, hugging her, «I've never earned so much in my whole career. Bye, Sergio» he added, moving closer to his son.

«Bye, Dad» Sergio replied, and after a brief awkward pause they hugged too.

Then, once they were at the door, eyes still wet: «Can I come to the opening?» he asked.

«Of course, Counselor, you must» Teo said, shaking his hand. He smiled.

«See you soon, Teo, goodbye Francesco.»

«Cuccurucucù, Counselor» came the reply.

The lawyer left, chuckling, making his way through the usual crowd of onlookers.

«What's happening to you?» Miranda asked after she'd closed the door.

«I don't know» he said, trying to come out of that odd trance he'd slipped into, «your father puts me in paranoia.»

«Yeah» said Sergio, still thoughtful.

«So that's settled, right?» Teo asked, «seems to me there's plenty of material here for an aperitif.»

«Also for an *aperi-dinner*» Sergio smiled, as if a weight had been lifted from his stomach, «also for an *aperi-dinner*.»

Miranda suddenly felt lighter, almost younger, as if the whole universe were again her oyster, her shell, and not something she had to defend herself from every day by wearing a suit.

«Let's take some T-shirts to Bla, now that we're legally covered.»

«And fast» said Sergio, «just one thing.»

«What?» asked Francesco.

«*I cigni di baccalà?!*»

They laughed.

The Bla was starting to show the strain from the nonstop requests for information. Everyone wanted to know when the strange shop would open, everyone wanted to be there, if only because nothing ever happens in Genoa. Rock was dead, apart from a few bands, nobody played anymore, theatre had dwindled, cinemas had been absorbed into multiplexes complete with bowling, shops and fixed-price, multiethnic restaurants. Opening a shop like that was equivalent to an Smiths reunion, for some even a first-period Genesis revival. They absolutely had to set a date, that evening the Bla was categorical. Sergio and Teo agreed, they could keep it loose if needed, but they had to do something, while Miranda argued it was better to decide when they were ready. They still didn't know where to produce the Log-Peaks (they'd named them in honor of Margaret Lanterman), and they had no idea how long it would take, but they agreed they had to speed things up. Public attention was tuned to their frequency, but it wouldn't stay that way for long. They had to start broadcasting.

Francesco, however, had other ideas.

«The customers' attention won't wane, actually, we'll give them something even more mysterious.»

«Mysterious?! What have you been smoking, the Cluedo cards?» Miranda asked.

«Yeah, what's mysterious about opening a shop?» Teo chimed in.

«Well, the date, first of all» Francesco said quietly.

«I don't think not saying when we'll open is good marketing.»

«Relax, I have an idea, just let me check one thing» and he stepped outside.

Miranda, Sergio and Teo sat at their table watching each other.

«Have you decided?» the Bla asked.

«Beer» they all answered.

«And the date?»

«Frank said he has an idea.»

«Oh, great!» he exclaimed, hurrying back to the tap, «An idea from Frank is exactly what we needed.»

They laughed.

«Perfect» he said on his return, «I just spoke to Walter and it's absolutely doable. A bit illegal maybe, but doable.»

«Illegal?!» they asked in chorus.

«Yes, but not like crossing the border with a trunk full of weed or offing someone. Illegal like, I don't know, passing a copied Creative Suite 6 to a friend» they sighed in relief, «no, maybe a tad more. Like, if a plane were to crash it'd be a bit of a mess, but...»

«Eh?!» they all said together, now convinced he'd lost his mind.

«Relax. I'll tell you everything later» he whispered, «this isn't the right place.»

«Ok» said the Bla, tray of beers in hand, «this brilliant idea?»

«It's top secret» Miranda said.

«Confidential» Teo added.

«Classified» Sergio chimed in.

«You American movies are bad for you, guys. Pick a date and do it fast, got it?» he said, pointing both fingers at them. «You're under double secret surveillance.»

«So?»

«Let's organize a Toga?!»

«Frank, come on, try to be serious. The Bla's right, we have to open, with or without the Log-Peaks.»

«Relax, my love, it's all sorted. I asked Walter for help and he» he continued whispering, «gave me a phone number. A carpenter friend of his can make us a hundred twenty-centimeter Log-Peaks and about twenty one-meter ones in a week for a thousand euros plus VAT. No finish and no bases for the tall ones.»

«That's not exactly a steal for a bunch of hollowed wooden logs» Sergio said.

«The small ones we'll sell for sixty euros each, they cost us less than ten. We'll just have to stain them and put them in a box. For now, I'd say that's fine.»

«Okay, and what about timing?»

«Tomorrow I'll go talk to the carpenter. The box layout is ready, we just need a metalworker to make a few brushed steel bases for the tall ones, and that's basically it.»

«I'll go talk to the metalworker» said Teo.

«You know one?» asked Sergio.

«Absolutely not, but my father will point me in the right direction.»

«So by the end of March we should be good to go.»

«End of March?» said Giacomo, who had caught a piece of the conversation from the next table. «And when exactly?»

«There is no exact date» said Francesco, climbing up on his stool with a pint of red ale in hand. He was in it now, he thought, so he might as well dance properly, fool around, even act a little crazy, why not? It was business, after all. «Radical Choc is at the starting line and will light up the neighborhood like an aurora borealis, but like that, it can't be forced to appear at our command. It will shine over the skies of our dull little town out of nowhere, and out of nowhere it will no longer be the same.» He drained the pint in one long gulp. «Sorry, brothers»

and he was surprised to hear himself use that word, «but we can't reveal the exact date. Just like the aurora borealis – visible for five days from every corner of the globe – you'll only need to look in the right direction, and when the time comes, you'll know.»

After a small uproar of mixed opinions, the place returned to normal.

His friends gave him side-eye for quite a while. Miranda included.

Once outside, on the way home, Francesco explained what he had in mind. Sure, they didn't have any kind of permit to pull something like that off, but they had to make use, somehow, of the legal coverage provided by one of the biggest law firms in the country.

Even if it had only cost them a T-shirt.

By the end of the month, everything was ready. They had stained all the Log-Steaks with various wood finishes, a couple of limited editions even painted with black anti-rust coating that gave a polymer-like sheen, similar to the new luxury car paints, which in someone's mind would justify the doubled price: one hundred and thirty euros for a piece of wood with a couple of holes. They had mounted the steel bases – brushed or darkened, depending on the stain color – on the larger Log-Peaks. They had applied the little plaques of the so-called 3BeCa Audio Research, put the websites online, and even requested a temporary change in their electricity plan to support the night's power consumption.

Only Walter, Fiamma, Sergio and Miranda's parents, Teo's father, and of course the Bla knew the exact date. The clientele, buzzing with anticipation, had only managed to get hold, one way or another, of a business card with the shop's logo on one side and a cryptic message on the other: *don't look where you step*.

The counter had been set up for its intended purpose, and the Bla, at the signal, would close the bar and move over to pour cocktails, draft beer, and wine at the opening. Walter had brought over a truckload of stage gear and installed a light mixer in the annex. Miranda, with Fiamma, had taken care of the music selection. For the opening and the store's presentation, they'd keep a background collage of Woody Allen movie dialogues, the only thing they had managed to edit, but when the atmosphere started to heat up, Fiamma would start the dancing and Walter would turn the place into an eclectic, exclusive club.

On the night of the grand opening, Miranda, Francesco, Sergio, and Teo had been locked inside the store for at least three days, chasing a kind of perfection they could never really reach, because it was an illusion. The store had been ready for days, everything arranged to the best of their abilities, but only an outsider's eye could have seen that, there was always something they felt could be improved. Then finally, amid the general nervousness, the sun went down.

It was Thursday, March 26th.

Walter arrived a few minutes after sunset, while at the bus stop, oddly enough, there wasn't a single curious bystander. For a moment, Francesco felt a wave of discouragement. Maybe the hipsters, fickle as prima donnas, had gotten tired of waiting. Maybe they'd lost interest. Or maybe, more likely, they were crowding the bars for their usual *aperi-dinner*.

Looking up and down *Via Sturla* to make sure no one was arriving too early, Sergio and Teo went out with a ladder, climbed up in front of the entrance, and mounted the shop sign – hand-painted, with retro charm – on the supports already fixed to the wall. Then, still trying not to be seen, Walter rolled out what looked like a huge aluminum pot on wheels. Sergio and Teo went back inside and came out carrying two large sheets of colored plastic with handle-like grips at the edges, one green, one blue.

Behind the bar counter, Miranda lined up six shots of tequila, straight, no salt or lemon, on a tray. She came out and handed them around. «We're on» she said.

«Rock and roll» said Walter.

«Rock and roll» echoed the others, one by one, before drinking.

Once the glasses were set aside, Miranda and Fiamma, with a shiver, began peeling off the newspaper still covering the windows, while Walter got ready to remove the hard cover

hiding a professional spotlight of over ten thousand watts. After pressing one of the switches, the pot started vibrating, emitting a not-very-reassuring hiss. Then, when the sound stabilized a few seconds later, Walter put on his sunglasses and pressed a second button.

A beam of light, almost a meter wide, shot into the sky like a tractor beam, reaching forty meters high. After timing about thirty seconds, he pressed a third button, and that light beam began to sway from side to side while Sergio and Teo, using the plastic filters, painted the sky in the classic hues of an aurora borealis.

The Bla didn't even need to guide the clientele. Giacomo and his partner were just stepping into the bar when they saw that burst of color and finally understood the meaning of that mysterious business card that had been popping up all over the city for days. Their friends poured out of the place and started spreading the word from one neighborhood to another.

The moment had finally arrived.

After about ten minutes, Walter locked the beam of light in an upright position, left it there for a few minutes so that everyone could more or less pinpoint the location, then turned everything off. He rolled up the industrial power cable and hid the spotlight and filters inside one of his vans parked a few meters away. If some airline pilot, or anyone else, wanted to file a complaint about that little stunt, they'd have a hard time proving they hadn't just witnessed a strange atmospheric or alien phenomenon. Then they all hid in the dark inside the shop.

The only lights on were two small rectangular LED spotlights, precisely illuminating the sign mounted perpendicularly to the entrance, one on each side. In the dim light of the annex, Francesco slipped into a pair of tight jeans, trendier ones, and a pair of triple-soled Church's shoes that Walter had lent him. Under his coat, a four-ply blue cotton V-

neck sweater Miranda had chosen for him. Looking at himself in the webcam reflection on the Mac screen, he had to admit he didn't look bad at all. Miranda and Fiamma didn't need to disguise themselves in any way, they could've stopped traffic even in pajamas, while Sergio and Teo wore the wrong shoes under two wool cardigans. Sergio even agreed to roll up his pant cuffs a little.

People were starting to arrive from both *Via Sturla* and *Via Caprera*. Small processions wound through the neighborhood streets, not to mention those who'd show up later, alerted by their friends via text message. For the first time, Francesco realized the place didn't feel that big anymore.

The Bla texted that he was on his way, the bar had emptied out, and that he'd blend into the crowd, making his customers believe he had the gift of ubiquity. Never in his career had the Blues closed its shutters before two a.m.

When the crowd, surprised to find the shop completely dark, began to press at the entrance, risking spilling into the street and blocking traffic, since people just kept arriving, Francesco glanced at Walter at the mixer. Walter gave him a thumbs up, then hit a key on the computer. From the speakers hidden in the shutter compartment came the final dialogue from an absolutely cult TV show episode:

«Goethe's final words: more light.»

A tiny electric candle lit up at the back of the shop, creating a single small point of light. The crowd fell silent.

*«Ever since we crawled out of that primordial
slime, that's been our unifying cry.
More light.»*

Another lamp switched on at the back, triggering a murmur of approval.

*«Sunlight, torchlight, candelight, neon, incandescent. Lights to banish the darkness from our caves, to illuminate our roads...
The inside of our refrigerators.»*

With each pause, Walter pressed a button on the mixer, turning on light sources that grew brighter and brighter. The hipsters, frozen on the sidewalk, some still holding their drinks, were completely entranced.

«Big flood for the night games at Soldier's Field... little tiny flashlights for those book we read under the covers when we're suppose to be asleep.»

The bookshelf beside the sofas, now filled with books, lit up completely, and the crowd roared.

«Light it more than watts and foot-candles. Light is a metaphor.»

The lampstand in the window switched on, revealing the outline of two armchairs.

«Rage, rage against the dying of the light.»

A laser beam illuminated the motorcycle parked at the back of the shop.

«Lead, kindly light, amid the encircling gloom. Lead thou me on! The night is dark, and I am far from home. Lead thou me on!»

The inside of the Volkswagen minibus lit up.

«Arise, shine, for thy light has come.»

A spotlight hit the bar counter.

«Light is knowledge, light is life... Light is light!»

At that point Walter pressed a larger button, and the shop seemed to explode in a battle of multicolored laser beams, as if imperial fleets had landed with the sole purpose of erasing the place from the face of the Earth. Miranda, who had resisted until the very end the idea of pairing those silent fireworks with the *Star Wars* theme, had to admit to herself that she'd been wrong.

The kids, those hipsters with thick beards, rolled-up pants, and multicolored parkas, that crowd of oddballs who months before had wanted to fight their own private revolutions, and whose names they now even knew, were in rapture, even though most of them, instead of watching the show live, were filming the colorful explosions on their phone screens.

Then, after a couple of minutes, after fading out a theme otherwise too long, amid cheers and applause, one by one the neon lights and industrial lamps hanging from the ceiling lit up the store in its entirety.

With a shiver, Francesco opened the door. «Ladies and gentlemen, friends one and all» he said, loosened up by the tequila he'd continued to enjoy, «Radical Choc, hipsters, quanta and rock and roll welcomes you. My friends and I sincerely hope that our little shop», he smiled, «will be to your liking. But enough talk, come in and make yourselves at home, the bar is open!» he shouted, stepping aside to avoid being trampled.

The crowd began to pour toward the bar, where the Bla, already in position, started pulling pints, filling wine glasses, and mixing a selection of quick cocktails. Miranda had to jump in to help, while Francesco and Sergio were already giving directions to the most curious visitors.

«We're already on the Tube» said Teo shortly after. «About fifty views already for the northern lights. I have a feeling the buffet won't be enough.»

«Hey, we've got five vegetable pies, five kilos of pizza, a ridiculous amount of stuffed focaccias in every imaginable way, the catering's bringing us a wheelbarrow of *penne all'arrabbiata* at ten, plus sandwiches, ten kilos of *Taggiasca* olives, fried veggies and chips of every shape and size. We've basically committed financial suicide for the catering. What else were we supposed to do?» asked Francesco.

«Less, maybe» said Teo, watching another human snake approach the entrance. «We should've advertised less.»

They laughed, a little worried perhaps, but happy. A crowd like that had never been seen at a simple opening. Of course, this wasn't an ordinary store, it was more stylish, more trendy, more cool, bigger, but that night it didn't show it at all.

Walter and Fiamma withdrew to the back room, now invaded by food supplies, with a couple of glasses of red wine. The crowd was starting to get almost annoying. Walter had planned to play snippets from Woody Allen movies in the background, but there were too many people and too much noise for that kind of soundtrack, so he took responsibility and replaced it with a particularly eclectic musical selection. The others, now carried away by total delirium, didn't even notice.

Once everyone had something to drink, they actually began to look around, scanning the shelves for some unmissable must-have, but in there, everything was.

«Hey, Frank... what are those?» asked Giacomo, pointing to the Log-Peaks display.

«Eco amplifiers for iPhones» he replied, as if everyone should already know. «Never seen them? They're made by a single craftsman in the world. They say there's even a waiting list to get one in the U.S.»

«No kidding!»

«Look, I don't buy it» he added, «to me they're just hollow chunks of wood, but they're selling like crazy everywhere. I still don't know if I like them or not, but just in case I've got one at home too» though he didn't confess that he used it only to stop the door from slamming.

«It's true» said a kid nearby with a tablet in his hand. «Look» and he showed Giacomo the manufacturer's website. «They cost way more on the list, by the way, here it says they're hard to find in New York.»

«Wow» said another hipster who'd joined the conversation. «Can I see?» The kid handed him the iPad.

«This one also says they're almost impossible to find» he said, looking at another website that Francesco knew well, since he had created it. «So how did you guys get them?»

«Well, there's an Italian distributor» shouted Francesco over the noise, «we got the exclusive for the center-north. That's why we had to delay the opening.»

«Nice» he said, taking one of the two black-painted blocks.

Miranda, after helping Bla with the launch, had returned to the register. They'd set up a small desk near the door, and as people flowed out, some to smoke, some to get some air and comment on what was happening with the crowd outside, they paid or left the item to be picked up later that evening.

By ten, when the catering guys delivered the *Penne all'arrabbiata*, the shelves looked ransacked, barely any T-shirts left, and only about half of those absurd wooden blocks

remained. The bookshelf had been completely gutted, probably by people who, after refilling their glasses a few too many times, were too embarrassed to leave without buying something.

Even Miranda, caught up in the frenzy, had kept drinking tequila and had ended up selling even the two armchairs from the window display, Spitfire imitations she'd bought secondhand for forty euros each and resold for ten times as much. Transport not included.

That the world was sick and everything was universally falling apart she had long suspected, but when she realized that the first two receipts rung up were for the two black Log-Peaks, she had her confirmation. In the third millennium there were still people dying of hunger, and others who thought nothing of spending one hundred and thirty euros on a piece of wood, truly convinced it could amplify and improve the sound of a simple phone.

Sergio and Miranda's parents, and Teo's father with his girlfriend, arrived soon after, just in time to eat a plate of *Penne* and nibble a few slices of vegetable pie. Everyone showered them with compliments, and the lawyer recounted in detail the golf game he'd played, and won, wearing what he had now officially declared his lucky T-shirt. In fact, he emphasized, he needed a whole stock of replacements, preferably including a few short-sleeved polo shirts. Sergio, between one customer and another, had to admit that the *Wrongs* were sold out. Maybe a few small sizes were left, and not with the design he wanted, but he'd get him more soon, polo shirts included.

Teo's father's girlfriend, who had to be about Teo's age, went wild for the T-shirt with Lady Gaga under the word Madonna and immediately put on one a couple of sizes too small, creating quite a stir among the customers. Miranda couldn't bring herself to charge her for it. She imagined her

breasts about to burst out at any moment, and that image was priceless.

By eleven, when the shelves, the bookcase, and the bar had all been raided, and Miranda, after a quick calculation, decided she was actually afraid to go home with the night's takings, Walter hit a few buttons on the light mixer. After shaping the illumination, switching from commercial mode to club mode, he launched a custom-made playlist: a mix of trance, trip, goa, EDM, dub, electroclash, and psybient tracks, not tied to any known artists but still totally danceable.

Bla had been right: they were snobs.

They managed to pull the shutters down only around two. As expected, a couple of police cars had shown up, drawn by the human swarm that at times had even blocked traffic, but the officers were reassured and sent back on patrol by a couple of plainclothes colleagues who were clearly under the influence of red wine. Not before taking a look around and buying, with a discount, a couple of T-shirts themselves. Luckily, no one complained about the noise or about that so-called northern lights show. Even Bla had left, after setting his eyes on an older hipster woman he'd practically seduced with buckets of *Prosecco*, leaving her legally incapable of driving home on her own.

Exhausted, Sergio, Teo, Francesco, and Miranda collapsed onto the sofas beside the stripped-down bookshelf. Glasses, dirty plates, and food leftovers were everywhere. They sat quietly for a bit, glancing around to assess both the damage and the takings. The merchandise seemed to have vanished. On the shelves, only a few T-shirts, a couple of lamps, and the bulkier furniture remained. The Log-Peaks had sold out, and Francesco almost felt guilty for having conned those poor guys he'd actually started to feel some affection for. Only the Tivolis were left unsold, maybe one less than before. Even the chili plants were gone. Miranda had had to make up a price on the spot and figured ten euros was perfect for what she described as cuttings from a *Raja Mirch* plant, one of the hottest chilies in the world, which, she made sure to clarify, sadly couldn't reach its full potential outside of India.

«We even sold the planting calendar» said Sergio, combing through the empty bookcase.

«The armchairs too, if it matters» said Miranda.

The three of them turned to look at her.

«Well, what was I supposed to do?» she went on. «There was this guy who fell in love with them. He liked their vintage look.»

«Vintage?! Used, more like.»

«Used, vintage, don't be pedantic, Frank. For hipsters it means the same thing.»

«So?»

«He asked if they were for sale. What could I do? They were in the shop window, after all. So I told him yes, but since they were vintage, they'd cost four hundred euros each.»

«Four hundred euros each?»

«Yep» she smiled, biting her lip. Francesco shivered. «Delivery not included.»

Sergio and Teo burst out laughing.

«And he paid you?»

«Hell yeah, eight hundred and fifty euros, no questions asked. My first credit card swipe. Not bad, huh? We're delivering them on Monday.»

«Nice one, Randi» said Francesco.

Sergio and Teo nodded in agreement.

«Since we're clearly sleeping here again tonight, what do you say, do we deserve a nightcap or what?» asked Teo, grabbing the tequila bottle.

«We deserve more than one» said Miranda, «but I doubt we'll manage to stay awake much longer. Anyway, before the toast, I need to get comfortable.»

«Great idea» said Sergio, getting up too.

«You're not changing, Frank?» asked Miranda. «You've had those shoes on since last night, don't they hurt?»

«Not at all» he said, realizing they actually fit perfectly, even though his left foot had always been half a size bigger than his right. But he agreed that sweats and slippers would definitely be more comfortable.

«We do realize, don't we, that we've got a hellish weekend ahead?» asked Teo, holding out his glass for Miranda to fill. «There's practically nothing left in here.»

«I'll call the carpenter first thing in the morning, see what he can do.»

«I'll head back to the nursery and fill the car with plants» said Sergio.

«Books aren't a problem, the distributor delivers within half a day. I'll ask them in the morning to prepare another batch» said Miranda. «The real problem is the T-shirts.»

«Then I'll go beg the print shop» said Francesco. «But either way, we should clean up this disaster first.»

«Tomorrow» whispered Miranda, «we'll deal with it tomorrow.» She poured herself another glass. «Rock and roll» she toasted.

The others followed suit.

«So, what do you think, guys?» asked Francesco, eyes wide from the tequila. «Did we pull it off?»

«Too early to tell. An opening night doesn't count» said Teo.

«We'll know in about a year» said Sergio. «But one thing's for sure, tonight we crushed it.»

They nodded, too tired even to smile. Then Miranda and Francesco moved to the sofa in the back room and turned off the light, wishing even Goethe goodnight.

They woke up early the next morning, all moderately sore in their joints after too many nights spent on the sofas, tongues thick from the tequila, but clear-headed and rested, especially compared to the night before.

What had seemed like a primordial mess now, in the light of a new day, was nothing more than what it was: a large number of glasses and dirty plates to wash, a floor to sweep, and some leftovers to bring to Bla for his aperitifs. Nothing insurmountable, in less than two hours, when Walter arrived to dismantle the mixer and lights, he was amazed to find everything almost perfectly tidy.

«Fiamma was over the moon last night» said Walter, fiddling with the cables. «We got home just after midnight, but she had so much adrenaline running through her that she couldn't fall asleep until half past two. She was so proud of you, I've never seen her like that» he smiled.

«I never gave her a reason to be.»

Walter laughed heartily. «You're crazy, kid. You have no idea how proud Fiamma has always been of you, it's just that what you did last night...»

«What we did. Without you, we'd have just opened the door and that's it.»

«Come on, what does that mean? The idea was yours. If I hadn't been there, you'd have hired another guy like me, that's not the point. The point is that, in a time like this, in the middle of a crisis when shops are closing one after another, you didn't let yourselves be crushed. You identified a target, built an

image, and invested in it. Not to mention how you pulled together the starting capital.»

Francesco nodded.

«Aren't you opening today?»

«No, we've bought ourselves time until Monday. We need to reorganize a few things.»

«Okay» Walter said, dragging toward himself the large flight case where he'd packed the mixer, lights, lasers, and cables. «If you need anything, call me.»

«Okay, Walter» said Francesco. «Thanks for everything.»

Walter smiled, nodded, and after saying goodbye to the others, busy straightening the shelves, left with his gear chest.

«Oh, crap» blurted Teo, staring at his phone, «we already have a YouTube channel! Thirty videos uploaded, and one... no way!» he exclaimed, zooming in with two fingers. «One has over eight hundred views!»

«Impossible» said Sergio flatly.

«Come on, fire up the computer.»

It was true. Videos of the *Northern Lights* show were everywhere, along with plenty from the party. Some probably sleepless user had already taken it upon himself to gather them all into one channel. One of the many videos of the grand opening had racked up something like eight hundred thirty-six views and about twenty enthusiastic comments.

But the real surprise came later in the afternoon, after countless phone sessions that each of them, in turns like proper managers, had to handle. Teo was sending in a purchase order when an incoming email popped up in the inbox linked to the 3BeCa Audio Research website, a company that, in fact, didn't exist.

A major American audio equipment retailer was requesting a catalog including a price list and details on minimum order quantities.

All four took turns in front of the computer, reading and rereading the email down to the smallest detail. Sergio even checked the header and traced the routing, concluding with great confidence that it was genuine.

«O...K...» drawled Francesco. «So what do we do now?»

«Let's reply right away» said Teo.

«No» said Miranda, «we have to wait. We need to create a price list first, something that looks professional.»

«Okay, but what kind of prices? If these guys actually place an order, we'll have to factor in shipping, export, customs... not to mention invoicing. 3BeCa doesn't even exist.»

«Well, we'll open it if we have to.»

«And issue an invoice for an existing order before the company itself exists?»

«Well, time travel is our specialty, isn't it?»

They all laughed.

A price list was already practically ready, Francesco had designed the website to perfection, and the retail prices were already quite high. All he had to do was add a 40% reseller discount, write a short English paragraph about the minimum order (roughly a hundred units), and specify that shipping and export costs would vary depending on destination.

Sergio pointed out that it might look odd for a company based in TriBeCa, New York to be shipping from Italy, so Francesco drafted a *company history* page to justify it. According to this new lore, 3BeCa Audio Research, a fictitious American firm registered at a nonexistent address in southern Manhattan, relied on the expertise of Genoa's last master shipwrights and a team of luthier-trained craftsmen to ensure the quality of its products. Since every piece was entirely handmade, 3BeCa Audio Research could meet only a small portion of demand, with highly variable delivery times, as no more than a hundred units were produced per week.

A couple of hours after sending the price list, another email arrived, an order for two hundred units. A hundred basic models in assorted colors, and a hundred one-meter stand-alone versions with brushed steel bases.

«Holy crap» said Francesco, «roughly speaking, with the prices I randomly set on the site, that's an order worth over twenty thousand euros.»

«Costing us, what, maybe a tenth of that to produce.»

«Well, we'd also have to open another company.»

«To be fully legit, yeah, but better check with the accountant first.»

«Let's reply right away» said Francesco. «We'll make them pay one-third upfront, one-third when the goods are ready for shipping, and the final third on delivery.»

«O...K...» said Teo, mentally searching for the proper formula for a professional email.

«Wait» said Miranda, checking the time. «New York's six hours behind, but it's almost eight here. No one would reply to an email at this hour. We'll do it tomorrow, no rush. We're swamped, we don't have time to deal with everyone.»

Which, after all, was true.

By the end of summer, Radical Choc s.a.s. owned the so-called 3BeCa Audio, now officially based in Italy, which produced and distributed its famous Log-Peaks to half a dozen overseas retailers for an initial turnover of about two hundred thousand euros. And soon, the 3BeCa name began popping up online even on websites Francesco hadn't created himself.

The more the American success of that chunk of wood made waves, the more customers adored it. In their shop, people could always find one of those objects to gift, or to resell on eBay with a small markup. Even when the rest of the world had practically run out of them.

They had managed to create demand without a product, and the product before the producer, shaping at will a timeline that was usually much less flexible, turning that initial guilt of having fooled a few poor souls into a kind of pride, more artistic than entrepreneurial, for having crafted something absolutely brilliant in its uselessness.

Their reputation, in the scene, was growing exponentially. Even in Milan, Turin, and other big cities, people were starting to talk about four hipsters who owned one of the coolest stores in the country, who had a lifetime reserved table in a bar where none of them ever paid, and who, according to unconfirmed rumors, had even bought 3BeCa Audio and moved it to Italy.

Those months were tough. After the opening, none of the four managed to truly relax. The video games that used to fill their afternoons were replaced by occasional pinball games to ease the tension between phone calls, negotiations, and shipments.

They had replaced the armchairs in the window, adding more seating to entertain customers at aperitif hour. Anyone could always count on a glass of wine and a few snacks in there, even if they didn't plan on buying anything. The shop, Sergio maintained, shouldn't look like a shop at all, it was a sort of private club where members even had the privilege of buying something if they wished, unlike everyone else. And once you managed to pass off some absurdity as a privilege, the game was won. People spent half their lives working, still convinced that having a job, at the cost of a life, was something to be thankful for. They accepted depositing their savings in banks that used them for profit without giving anything back. They accepted being subdued and humiliated every day at work, even at home, as long as they, too, had someone to step on. Offering them something slightly higher, like the illusion of belonging, was all too easy.

The store changed shape week after week, just as Walter had suggested. They found a company in Brianza to mass-produce the Log-Peaks at a fraction of the cost, and they added a clothing section that Miranda stocked with the strangest pieces she could find online. They struck a deal with a Milanese company to package the T-shirts either in tin cans, like peeled tomatoes, or in cardboard boxes identical in shape and color to the famous Barilla pasta packs. That way, the shelf where they displayed them, though aligned in design with the contents, looked like a supermarket aisle.

They brought Bla in as a partner: without his money, none of it would have happened, so they decided to give him a small share that would entitle him to a portion of the profits, with their right of first buyback intact, and he was so moved by their generosity that from that day on, he never managed to charge them for their drinks again.

The store kept evolving, week after week, and on Sunday nights Miranda, Francesco, Sergio, and Teo would eat pizza there together, as they had always done at home, playing pinball with the unspoken agreement not to talk about work. Bla would join them at the end of the night, if he managed to close at a decent hour, often ending up teasing them. They wanted to fight the hipster invasion, he laughed, and in less than six months they were practically leading it. According to him, it was time to level up.

Someone would have to grow a beard.

Autumn was at the door, the temperature dropping, and that evening, sitting at their usual table at Blues House, they were all particularly excited. An Economics professor from the University of Genoa had just invited them to give a lecture to his students, hoping the four would agree to reveal, if not a few secrets, at least some tricks of the trade. Sergio and Teo would have accepted on the spot, with the barely subconscious desire to steer the lecture toward a scathing critique of the national university system, while Francesco and Miranda, though intrigued by the idea, were much more hesitant.

How could they tell the students that everything had begun as a joke, more ironic than entrepreneurial, as an attempt to push back against a world they didn't understand, to which they felt no sense of belonging, and that now, not even a year later, that very world had turned them into role models? Of course, they could talk about how their products had come to be, perhaps concealing the built-in prank that many failed to notice and others interpreted as a stroke of genius. They could explain their decision to cut out every kind of middleman, buying directly from producers, or producing directly, to limit the costs of pointless representation services. But beyond that, they didn't have much else to teach. Their ideas had surfaced on their own, bobbing up like buoys from the sea of irony they swam in, certainly not as the fruits of market research, studies, or trends. Maybe that was their real strength, maybe the hipster instinctively recognized and rewarded the genuineness of an idea, unlike the industrial vegetables that Bla kept serving them without shame, with sadistic pleasure.

But what would they say when a student asked how they'd started? They couldn't possibly recount that absurd chain of coincidences that, for better or worse, despite the benefits, they'd had to face. And holding a lecture just to tell how lucky they'd been would have been, at the very least, in bad taste.

«Are we celebrating your birthday at the shop?» Miranda asked.

«At the shop? Why not here?»

«It's next Monday, Bla's closed. If we do it down there, he can relax too.»

«Ah, okay... but something quiet, not like the usual parties.»

«Your birthday's our business» said Teo, «not a launch event. Just the four of us and Bla.»

«And Fiamma and Walter» added Teo.

«That goes without saying.»

«And Giacomo and his partner.»

«Them too?» asked Francesco.

«Come on, he's practically our PR guy.»

«Social Media Manager» said Sergio. «PRs are an endangered species.»

«Social Media Manager. Got it.»

They laughed.

The leaves were starting to yellow and night came early. As Francesco stood to refill his glass, a strange feeling crept over him. All that talk about whether or not to give that lecture had brought to mind that odd old man he'd met, the one he was starting to resemble more and more each day. He looked at himself in the mirror behind the bar, with the yellow glasses, the coat, and those shoes so comfortable he still hadn't given them back, he really did look like him. He didn't have any gray hair yet, thankfully, but his birthday was around the corner, and the ones after that, unless time decided to take a break, would come one after another.

But that sort of seasonal melancholy lasted only a moment. Bla handed him a mug of amber ale, and after his first sip, still standing at the counter, he thought about how quickly those months had passed, and how much had changed.

The evening went on quietly. The bar wasn't crowded, and every now and then Bla managed to sit with them, until he noticed a familiar figure outside the door.

«Miranda» he said, nodding toward the entrance.

She turned just in time to see an old man dressed exactly like Francesco walk in. Her blood froze.

«Good evening, everyone» he said as he entered. «There's electricity in the air tonight» he went on, «tell your friends.»

Bla nodded. «Look, they're right over there, tell them yourself.»

The old man turned toward them. «There's electricity in the air tonight, tell your... Oh, what a lovely coat, my compliments.»

Francesco stood up, his legs shaking, barely able to keep himself steady, but he relaxed as soon as he realized the poor man had absolutely nothing to do with the one he'd met at the concert, despite the identical coat and glasses.

«Thank you» he said with a sigh of relief, «yours is very nice too.»

The old man laughed.

«Have a drink with us?» Miranda asked, switching to tu as if they already knew each other, Bla must have.

«I'd love to, miss, I really would, but Miranda wouldn't approve. She says tomato juice doesn't go well with my medication, or maybe it's the vodka, I can't remember.»

«Miranda?!» she exclaimed.

«My lady» he said, then paused. «Or maybe my sister. I forget things sometimes, but it passes» he finished, and with a

confused look, as quickly as he had entered, he left. After glancing both ways down the street, he started off toward *Sturla*.

«So» asked Bla, while Miranda, still frozen on her stool, was trying to make sense of what she had just witnessed, «should I give him a check?»

«No, poor thing» she said quickly, trying to cover for him, to avoid having to explain to Bla that she'd been lying to him from the start, one lie covering another. «Look at him, he's really gone downhill lately.»

«Alzheimer's?» asked Bla.

«Yeah» she replied, feeling filthy.

«Damn, he looked just like your man. If I were you, I'd be careful» he laughed. «If Frank plans on aging like that, maybe you should give it some thought.»

They laughed.

«And buy him a decent pair of shoes» he added.

«What's wrong with these?» Francesco asked.

«Not now» said the Bla, «in about forty years. The ones that guy had were totally wrecked.»

«Well, I know someone» she said, looking at her boyfriend, «who never gives up on a pair once he finds them comfortable. Even if they're not his» she laughed.

Francesco shivered.

The following Monday everything was ready for the party, the private party, as Giacomo, the ever-dutiful Social Media Manager, had called it. Miranda had ordered food from *I Tre Merli* in *Corso Magenta*, one of the city's most renowned taverns, which would deliver wine and provisions shortly after eight, once the last customer had gone home.

The movable furniture turned out to be a brilliant idea, even more so than those drilled wooden logs, though far less profitable. In no time, Miranda and Fiamma moved the sofas and shelves, creating a cozy lounge in the center of the shop. Then they dimmed the lights and put on some background music while waiting for the supplies.

Fiamma was over the moon. The more she looked around, thinking about what her son and his eccentric friends had managed to pull off, the write-ups in the local papers, the online chatter, the overseas sales, even that invitation to lecture at the university, the prouder she felt. She knew she couldn't take credit for such entrepreneurial brilliance, maybe it came from his father, whoever he was. Life was absurd, she thought, for granting her grace just when she had already given up on it, and how much more could still happen, now that she finally understood how, in a handful of seconds, everything one believed in could crumble like a sandcastle and be reshaped entirely anew.

Miranda and Sergio, both happy to have patched up a family crisis that already felt far behind them, hadn't invited their parents to the party. Just because things had been more or less resolved didn't mean their father wasn't still a first-rate

braggart. He could be charming and respected in court or in an alpha-male club, but in everyday life that showy self-confidence was still hard to digest. And besides, he and Francesco had never really had any kind of relationship, at least not yet. That, too, would have to change eventually.

He and Miranda had been living together for months now.

Giacomo was glad to have found new friends. Though the hipster community had embraced them completely, even idolized them, he knew they were different. These four didn't spend their time grooming beards, rolling up pants, or panicking over non-organic salads. They couldn't care less about the food they ate, especially the alcohol, and had no ambitions to change the world. From what he'd gathered, their family issues weighed far more on them than the ozone hole, chemtrails, SARS, mad cow disease, bird flu, milk quotas, or Elvis sightings. He'd never even heard them mention the Ebola outbreak that dominated primetime TV to remind millions of overworked, demoralized viewers, drained by a collapsing country and chronic lack of enthusiasm, that at least they were still alive.

When he finally came out as gay, as if they hadn't already guessed from his socks, he was amazed by their reaction. No one twisted themselves into knots to dodge a topic that in Italy could still get you figuratively burned at the stake, nor did they overdo the empathy to show how open-minded they were. Teo simply explained what he liked to call the paradox of homosexuality. The Catholics and the clueless, armed with prefab dogmas, kept calling it *unnatural* unaware that over fifteen hundred animal species had been observed exhibiting the same behavior, without even mentioning hermaphroditism, whether simultaneous or sequential. So, since universities could no longer afford to watch animals make love, logic dictated the opposite: heterosexual fundamentalism was the real *unnatural* practice. No debate needed. If His existence hadn't been

scientifically disproven, it would've been fair to say that God loved the gays.

Walter had just finished work and looked exhausted, wiped out, really, but the truth was he'd smoked half a dozen joints with his electrician's apprentice just to survive the *Forza Italia* convention he'd been hired to cover. Now he was chemically altered, starving, and counting the minutes until he could get something to eat.

Francesco and Teo, standing behind the counter, back to its original function, were mixing the aperitif (just a simple *Sbagliato*) with the kind of tension usually reserved for chemistry exams. As if the Valdobbiadene, Martini, and Campari might blow up at any second. The Bla, slumped in an armchair, watched them in disbelief and frustration, he'd promised Fiamma he wouldn't lift a finger that night, not even to save the block from exploding.

Filippo, Giacomo's boyfriend, who didn't really know anyone yet, watched their goofy, deliberately childish antics with amusement. He had already realized at the grand opening that both Fiamma and Miranda were naturals.

They managed to toast a couple of times before the food arrived, and the Bla survived without major incidents. Then they began setting the table.

Walter slowly came back to life over a couple of plates of *gnocchi al pesto*, then fully revived when the *buridda di seppie*, a traditional Genoese cuttlefish stew, hit the table. The conversation, fueled by a *Verduno*, a rare grape close to *Nebbiolo*, became lively, witty and, of course, at times completely insane. At least until Miranda got up to fetch another bottle of wine.

«What the hell is this?» she shouted, almost terrified, pointing at a glass jar, lined up with others on that part of the

shop that looked like a supermarket aisle, filled with black pins featuring a red chili pepper in the center.

«The pins?» asked Sergio.

«Yeah, what the hell did you guys do now?»

Walter, Fiamma, Giacomo, and Filippo exchanged puzzled looks.

«We had a batch made to close an order. The customers love them.»

«You can say that again» said Filippo, pointing at the one on his jacket lapel. «After all, you're the ones who started the trend.»

«Trend? What trend?» asked Francesco.

«What, you're telling me you don't know?»

No one replied. The Bla got up to grab the bottle that had become stranded in what seemed like a pointless discussion.

«Well, some people, following your example, go out at night carrying your chili plants around. Others, like me, who already have a dog and can't be bothered, just wear your pins instead. They're basically a must-have now.»

«O...K...» Walter drawled, laughing and filling his plate a second time, «it's been a while since I've heard bullshit of this magnitude.»

«People carry chili plants around?» asked Fiamma. «And why on earth?»

«Partly for fun, partly to get noticed. Let's not kid ourselves, we're all desperately chasing those famous fifteen minutes of fame.»

Fiamma nodded, amused.

«We should've sold cacti» said Teo.

They all laughed.

«Yeah, but after everything that's happened, did you really have to print pins like these?» said Miranda, still agitated. «Couldn't you pick another symbol?»

«Oh, come on» Sergio said, «look where we are now, remember where we were a year ago. I don't see the problem.»

He was right. Everything that had happened, coincidences or quantum events, whatever they were, had only ever helped them, tracing a path they'd never have imagined otherwise. What unsettled Miranda wasn't believing in such absurdity, it was the fear that one day her man might just wander off through time and leave her stranded in some random century.

«Guys» said Fiamma, now serious, «I think at this point you owe us an explanation, at the very least.»

«I second that» said the Bla, raising a full glass. «What the hell are you talking about?»

Walter extended his own glass to be refilled.

Miranda nodded, looking at her friends. At that point, there was no reason to keep it to themselves anymore.

Francesco took a long sip of red and began to speak, first apologizing to Fiamma, Walter, and the Bla for keeping them in the dark until now. Then he told them everything that had happened before and after the Tom Waits concert: the strange old man, the coat, the glasses, the appearance at the Blues House that forced them to borrow money from their friend (even if it turned out not to be the same person), and finally that absurd windfall in the stock market. He told them everything, in detail, omitting only the part about the investment still ongoing, the one they'd check again once they were adults, if that day ever came.

Giacomo and Filippo were speechless. They hadn't imagined, not for a second, that Francesco could have actually traveled through time, it was impossible, everyone knew that, but what baffled them most was how those four had managed to spot signals in the chaos, follow them, and take real risks, personal ones included, only to come out on top. It made them feel as

though they were in the company of truly extraordinary people. Reckless, maybe. Irresponsible, definitely. But damn lucky.

The Bla, more used to their eccentricities, didn't think too hard about it. He'd lent them money, they'd paid him back double, plus the ten percent stake in the company entitling him to profit shares. He was just glad they hadn't told him earlier, because for that kind of bullshit, he'd never have signed a check.

«Damn!» Fiamma exclaimed. «Looks like time travel runs in the family.»

«Huh?» said Francesco.

The others waited. The Bla's glass was full again.

«My love» she continued, «I know today's your birthday, and you don't like me talking about that day...»

«What day?» asked Filippo, turning to his boyfriend.

«The day he was conceived, at a Frank Zappa concert in '84» he whispered.

«Here in Genoa?»

«Yes, I think so» he murmured back.

«Then it was '83» Filippo concluded. But Giacomo didn't hear him.

«You've never forgiven me for fooling around at a concert, thinking I slept with some random stranger, have you?»

«Come on, Ma', drop it, this really isn't the time.»

«Yeah, you're right. But I just want to tell you one thing, a little story that might annoy you, but you'll definitely find... interesting.»

Francesco was about to object, but Miranda placed a hand on his knee, gently pressing his kneecap.

It was time to let that story finally come out, and move on.

Fiamma then told her lysergic experience in vivid detail, right up to that trip through time where she'd been able to glimpse a future that later (she was careful not to say unfortunately) came true much later than it had seemed.

Francesco couldn't see what their experiences were supposed to have in common, and picturing his mother young and tripping at a rock concert made him a little uneasy. Sure, she had felt that man was her soulmate, her Prince Charming, so much so that, after the concert, he had simply vanished without a trace. Fiamma had always been sincere, she always meant well. But her bouts of naïveté had never been easy for him to digest.

Fiamma didn't care about how time moved, or whether it even existed, or any of the delirious theories Teo's colleagues would sacrifice themselves over. She maintained, she knew, and she was utterly convinced that she had moved within it. Whether the active substance had sent her to another plane of reality, or she had simply slipped free from the natural flow of events long enough to witness them as an observer, it didn't matter. She was sure of what she'd seen, and that was proof enough for her that it was real. Teo might even have believed her, if what she'd described had actually unfolded according to the timeline she claimed to have witnessed. But since it hadn't, he had to lean toward the more conventional, unspoken conclusion: maybe one shouldn't mess with the hard stuff.

The silence that followed was awkward. No one wanted to dig deeper, out of respect for Fiamma, and for Walter, of course. It couldn't have been easy listening to how long his wife had waited for her Prince Charming before settling for him. But Walter seemed entirely immune to jealousy that night, he filled his plate a third time without blinking.

When Francesco was finally forced to blow out the candles, the Bla, completely drunk, launched into a series of rowdy, folkloric toasts. Odd, since he usually held his liquor better than any of them, and they hadn't even been drinking that much, or so they thought. The truth was, the poor guy was sacrificing himself for a cause far greater than his liver.

After the cake came the gifts, and though Francesco always said he didn't want any, he still ended up with a few packages to open. Not from Sergio and Teo, they never exchanged gifts, sparing each other pointless errands downtown, but Walter and Fiamma gave him a cashmere sweater, Giacomo and Filippo, probably after getting some advice, a rare Tom Robbins book, while Bla, swaying, knelt before him:

«Today, more than any other day, I have been your humble servant, my lord, this is my gift to you...» He stood, hugged him, and whispered, «Don't worry, you'll understand later» then dragged one of the sofas near the table and collapsed onto it.

At that point, Miranda pulled out two packages, one larger than the other.

«Which one do you want first?» she asked.

«Is that even a question? The big one.»

«Okay» she said with a smile, handing it to him. «Happy birthday, Frank.»

«A pair of shoes» he said, opening the package. «Identical to the ones that.»

«You still haven't given back to Walter since the opening night.»

«And that you've never taken off» added Fiamma.

«I'm not sure Walter's dying to get them back» said Teo.

They laughed.

«Try them on, come on, they're the same model, same size.»

«The left one's a bit tight, as usual» he said, standing up. «His fit me perfectly.»

«You'll have to break them in a bit» said Giacomo.

«No, it's because I have my cobbler stretch mine» said Walter. «My left foot's half a size bigger than the right.»

«Me too» said Francesco, surprised. «Me too... Maybe you could...»

«Of course, I'll take it to my cobbler. He knows what to do.»

«Half a size, it must be hereditary» whispered Filippo to his boyfriend.

«Okay, now what?» Francesco asked, smiling, waiting for the second package.

«Right. But sit down first. You too, Fiamma, please» Miranda said, smiling. «You know, this one's a bit of a gamble. Maybe I should've talked to you about it first, but everything happened so fast, we just ended up here and...»

Francesco took the package from her hands. He opened it and looked inside.

In an instant, he was hurled into another level of reality, drifting through the past, and above all, the future, with far more uncertainty than Fiamma had ever faced. Miranda froze, breath suspended, as though her body had forgotten how to breathe, how to function. It was as if that moment were her final heartbeat.

Francesco watched his entire life flicker before him, a film unspooling from kindergarten, through his school days, his first kiss, his problems with his mother, Anita, that damn hipster he could now only thank, Miranda, that day, and beyond. And then, the equation changed, an unknown so vast it could flip the entire sum of his life. And he understood, with absolute clarity, that this was indeed the last day of his life. At least, on that timeline.

He resurfaced with a shiver, whether it was the vibrating strings, the collective unconscious, or simply the primordial chaos shaping the universe around him, whether he was really moving through it or only imagining he was, across however many parallel, alternate, or perpendicular dimensions existed, suddenly, it all seemed like a wonderful place to be.

He looked at Miranda for a moment, smiled, giving her body back its sense of control, and said, «Think you could have these stretched too? They're a little tight» glancing at Walter.

«Oh my God... oh my God... oh my God...» Fiamma burst out, rising as fast as a vampire on TV. «Oh my God, it can't be...!» She threw herself at Miranda, hugging her but without her usual bone-crushing grip. «It's not a joke, right? Tell me it's not a joke, you'd never do something like this to me, right?»

«Of course not» Miranda smiled, «look at him, poor thing» she said, pointing to the Bla. «We've been swapping glasses all night, he's been drinking for both of us.»

«Oh my God... I'm going to be a grandmother, a grandmother! It's my son's birthday» she threw herself at him, «and you've given me the best gift ever. Oh my God... oh my God...»

They all stood up to congratulate them. Fiamma was literally beside herself, bouncing around the room like a pinball. Walter tried to calm her down with a glass of whisky and handed one to Francesco too. «No cigars, sorry» he said, «but there's time for that. Congratulations, Frank.»

«Hey, we should toast with the mom, though» laughed Sergio, passing her the whisky glass, which she, of course, handed straight to Bla.

«I see» he said, «you all want me dead.»

«We need to make room, there's a new creature on the way.»

They laughed and toasted, everyone except Miranda, naturally.

Over and over again.

The celebration went on almost all night, dancing, drinking, and launching into wild speculations about what might soon happen. Then, during a musical pause, with his tongue slightly thick from alcohol, Filippo asked how Fiamma had met Walter again after all those years. He wanted to know what had gone wrong thirty years earlier.

Giacomo nudged him with his elbow to drop it, but alcohol had stripped him of any filters, and he didn't notice. Fiamma

explained that Walter wasn't the same man, that she had waited for a long time, yes, but then she had met this Walter, and thankfully her life had changed. But Filippo pressed on. «You mean Walter isn't Frank's father? Weird, they have the same nose.»

«Huh?» she said.

«Frank's got your face shape, sure, but the nose, maybe not his father, pardon, but the nose is Walter's.»

Fiamma had never really thought about it, but the kid was damn right.

Miranda got goosebumps. She had noticed a few odd coincidences between them that evening, both ate the cuttlefish before the peas, and okay, both had one foot slightly larger than the other, but to think Walter was that mysterious guy she'd met at the Frank Zappa concert? That was a stretch.

Fiamma sat down, poured herself a drink, and poured one for her husband too, now almost amused. «Tell me, darling, there isn't something you forgot to mention, is there?» she asked, tipsy herself. «You weren't by any chance at a Frank Zappa concert in '84?»

«'83» Filippo corrected.

Walter emptied his glass in one gulp, trying to find the thread of some bizarre theory. Or maybe it was just the convention residue kicking in under the whisky's push.

«I'm telling you, it was 1984.»

«Sorry to contradict you, Fiamma, but it was 1983, I'm sure of it.»

«Okay, but how can you be so sure? You weren't even born yet.»

«Actually, I was just born, that's why my parents couldn't go. January 1983. No way around it.»

«Excuse me, but you think I don't know when my son was conceived?»

«Of course you do, he was born nine months later, give or take» he smiled, «but maybe you're misremembering where he was conceived.»

Francesco was starting to get annoyed.

«Come on... fine, I wasn't exactly clear-headed, I'll give you that, but I remember it perfectly, the stage, Frank dressed to the nines» Walter grimaced and refilled his glass, «and the keyboardist pushing the keyboards back and forth like Boosta does now.»

«Oh... Christ» said Walter, draining his tumbler.

«Oh... Christ» echoed Miranda.

«Oh... Christ» added Filippo. «You're mixing up Elvis Costello with Frank Zappa, it was Steve Nieve pushing the keyboards, not Bobby Martin.»

«Okay, Mr. Know-it-all, how can you be so sure?»

«My dad used to own a record shop, I know these things.»

«And anyway, you can say a lot about Zappa» said Teo, «but elegant isn't one of them.»

«Oh... Christ» kept repeating Miranda, like a stuck record.

«Frank, forgive me» said Filippo. Giacomo had given up all hope of shutting him up. «What's your blood type?»

«Almost the rarest one on Earth.»

«AB positive?»

«Yeah.»

«And you, Walter?»

Walter filled his glass again, that bottle wouldn't be enough, he thought.

«Now you're into blood types too?» asked Fiamma.

Filippo suddenly regretted not choosing hematology as a specialty, it would've been so entertaining. «Well, I'm specializing in endocrinology, but yeah... I know a bit.» He smiled.

«So?»

«Blood type is inherited from your parents, and AB positive is very rare. What's your type?»

«O. O negative.»

«And Walter's?»

He lifted the glass again, but Miranda stopped him.

«Hey, are you okay?» she whispered.

«To tell the truth, I don't know. You know how many people in the world have that blood type?»

«No.»

«Seven percent of the population, maybe less.»

«O... kay... and you're...?»

«AB positive.» He drained the glass.

Francesco felt goosebumps rise on his arms.

«Walter, can I speak openly?» asked Miranda.

He nodded.

«You once told me something happened to you at that Elvis Costello concert in 1984, an experience like Fiamma's, right?»

He nodded again, reaching for the bottle, which Miranda pulled away.

«But you don't remember exactly what happened?»

«Right» he said, and his voice sounded like it came from the afterlife.

«Whereas you, Fiamma» Miranda said softly, «you remember what happened, more or less, but you might have mixed up when it happened.»

Sergio and Teo were frozen, mouths open, glasses in hand, while Bla, passed out on the couch, slept like a baby and snored like a drunk.

«Okay, but one thing» said Fiamma, suddenly defiant. «You had an experience like mine and never told me?»

«I didn't want to diminish yours by saying, hey, you know, something like that probably happened to me too, only I barely remember it.»

«Fine, you're a gentleman, I'll give you that, but gentlemen don't just vanish without a trace, do they?»

«I didn't» he muttered under his breath, finally managing to reach the bottle.

«Wait, you mentioned a phone number, didn't you?» asked Miranda.

Walter nodded, opened his wallet, pulled out a rectangular scrap of paper folded in two, its colors barely visible after thirty years, and handed it to her. Then he downed another glass of whisky. Somehow, the alcohol didn't seem to be affecting him at all that night.

Miranda looked at what little was left of the words printed on the ticket: *Goodbye Cruel World – Elvis Costello & The Attractions European Tour*. Then she unfolded it.

On the back, a handwritten phone number, still perfectly legible, nearly gave her a heart attack. Francesco noticed and panicked. «Hey, baby... you okay?»

«Yes» she said, her voice trembling, eyes wet. «I think so...» Then she folded the ticket again and handed it to him.

Francesco took it, studied the faded colors, opened it, and stared at the number, not immediately making sense of it.

«Okay, now I'm officially confused. Want to explain this to me?» he said, but Miranda had started to sob.

«What's wrong, Randi?»

«Jesus Christ, Frank, what the hell have you been smoking, pine caterpillars?» she blurted, crying.

Everyone froze. Miranda's tears, probably triggered by some hormonal storm, had blended into a fit of hysterical laughter, as if her body, overwhelmed by the sheer absurdity of the situation, had surrendered, choosing oblivion over the impossible task of rational deduction.

Luckily it didn't last long. Except for Bla, still unconscious on the couch, they all crowded around her, trying to figure out what could have shocked her that way.

Sure, Walter and Francesco had the same blood type, rare, at that, the same nose, one foot larger than the other, and both ate their cuttlefish before the peas, saving the sauce for last. The coincidences were piling up fast, and at that rate a DNA test would hardly have been necessary, but still, it didn't quite explain her reaction.

Walter's silence only seemed to confirm the outrageous theory everyone was gradually warming up to. For him, though, it was already crystal clear. He had realized that Fiamma had mixed up the dates, the musicians on stage, and, as usual, something far more important, making herself unreachable. He had no desire to dig into how that had happened. The simple fact of discovering he had a son, and meeting him after thirty-one years, was already stretching his brain to the limit. Not to mention, everything unfolding before him (and what he was about to learn) seemed to wink at his wildest theories. Teo would have to admit it, sooner or later.

Once Miranda calmed down, Sergio and Teo took a look at the ticket. The number didn't spark any particular reaction in either of them. They tried to show it to Fiamma, but she shook her head and backed away.

She wasn't ready.

They wouldn't have been surprised if their best friend's mother, a world champion of distraction, had managed to give her Prince Charming entirely misleading contact details.

Teo thought back to what that strange old man had told Bla, words he was only now realizing might have held real meaning: there really were trains that passed only once in a lifetime, but it didn't matter much, if you really cared, you could always walk the whole way.

Fiamma was living proof of that. She had walked, without stopping, for something like thirty years straight, to end up right there, now, her heart overflowing with joy and an inexplicable sorrow, proud of having made it this far, of never giving up, yet frustrated by the thirty years she'd lost along the way.

Giacomo had watched the entire scene with his hand over his mouth, trying to contain his shock, while his partner was dying of curiosity, baffled by how impractical these people seemed to be.

Unable to resist, he approached the table, and when he sensed he had permission, he picked up the ticket and dialed the number on his phone.

It was late to be calling someone's house, but it wasn't the time for such niceties, he thought, just before hearing the opening riff of *Any Road* by George Harrison rising from the depths of Fiamma's handbag.

Miranda started crying again.

«Easy, honey» said Fiamma, «it's just my cell phone» then frost covered everything.

"But... what..." Fiamma stammered, trying to break through that sheet of ice, before falling silent, her gaze lost in the void, light-years away.

Giacomo and his partner had expected anything from that night, anything but that. Not something they'd remember for the rest of their lives, or even tell their grandchildren about, or their children, if Italy ever became a civilized country.

Sergio and Teo, more prepared for such an eventuality, at least in theory, or perhaps simply more drunk, didn't let themselves be dragged adrift by the current of complex reasoning. They preferred to shake off that cold glaze right away, huddling around Miranda to give her some warmth. From Fiamma, after all, they'd always expected anything, ever since they were kids. Even Teo, who should have felt a twinge of

jealousy over such an experience, didn't feel that way at all. Trips like that brought responsibilities he would gladly have done without, at least for now.

The Bla kept snoring on the couch, oblivious like a child to grown-up problems, while Francesco slowly realized there was nothing to understand, nothing to analyze, nothing worth wasting more time on. Focusing so hard on the future only poisoned the present, the only fragment of space-time he truly had to live in, and could live in.

He thought of the monkeys from that old Zen parable, then of the more famous ones facing the monolith. Humanity would always have to live with mystery, and though over the years it would surely develop new and seductive theories, it would never be able to compete with the imagination of chaos. There was no god, no premeditation, no organization behind the state of things. They simply moved within it, admiring that tiny slice they were allowed to see, marveling, day after day, at everything chaos had managed to weave together.

They had no higher purpose for existing, except the one they would build themselves, no destination, except the one they would choose. And they were all completely alone in the universe, except for the family and friends they'd decide to have. For the first time in his life, Francesco felt whole.

«So» he asked Walter after a long silence, «when the hospital calls, you're forced to donate blood too?»

Walter nodded.

«A big step forward» he went on, «before, we defended the world with a joystick, now we're both on the front line» he laughed.

«That's what heroes do» Walter admitted, smiling.

«Pleasure to meet you, Dad» Francesco said, shaking his hand.

«The pleasure's all mine, son» Walter replied, crushing it in his grip. Then they hugged and began to cry like calves. The others, Bla excluded of course, soon followed.

When the tears began to run dry, Francesco hugged his mother, tightly, maybe tighter than he ever had before, and whispered in her ear that he never wanted to hear another word about the future. He'd lost something like thirty years, he deserved to live in the present now.

When he managed to free himself from her embrace, he went to the shelf, took the jar with the pins, and threw it into the trash. Then he reached out to Miranda and pulled her close. «Don't worry, my love» he said, «I'll never go anywhere without you.»

Miranda stopped sobbing, wiped her eyes with her palm, and after putting on her jacket, followed him, hand in hand, toward home.

They walked slowly down *Via Sturla*, all the way to the square, where the last hipsters were still loitering in front of the bars with their bikes, keeping the bartenders from going home. They crossed a stretch of *Via dei Mille* in perfect silence, passing the gas station for those who still hadn't converted to alternative transport, until they turned onto *Via del Tritone*. They didn't stop at the doorway. Miranda led him further on, to the beach, where they stood at the foreshore, staring at the sea.

Nothing seemed to have changed out there, in that world they no longer knew how to define. A few couples in the distance were still kissing and making promises, as they had for thousands of years, and from afar the sound of bongos and a timid guitar betrayed the presence of some kids sharing their first joints by the water treatment plant. The next summer, the beachgoers would again fight over a tiny patch of sand for their towels, and street vendors would pour off the trains and buses with huge bags and stacks of straw hats on their heads. Their daughter would be born then, because Miranda already sensed

she'd be a girl, and they'd work themselves to the bone learning how to be parents, rejoicing and suffering day after day, battling exhaustion and sleeplessness to be rewarded with a happiness they could only imagine for now.

Then, little by little, the days would shorten again, and autumn would carry them straight into another spring, since winter, especially by the sea, seemed to have retired.

And so it would go, year after year...

Just as it always had.

Francesco moved behind her, rested his head on her shoulder, and wrapped his arms around her waist, his hands resting on her belly. They stayed there, motionless, staring at the horizon, supporting each other until almost sunrise, lulled by the sound of the waves breaking on the shore, a mantra as old as the Earth itself.

When the horizon line, invisible just a moment before, was painted with a faint reddish glow, marking the divide between land and sky, Miranda slipped from his embrace, took her man by the hand, and led him home.

She had finally understood that the future was nothing but a state of mind.

www.patriziopinna.com
scrivi@patriziopinna.com

©2014 Patrizio Pinna – All right reserved

Cover image by Bjorn Giordano
<https://bjorngiordano.blogspot.com/>